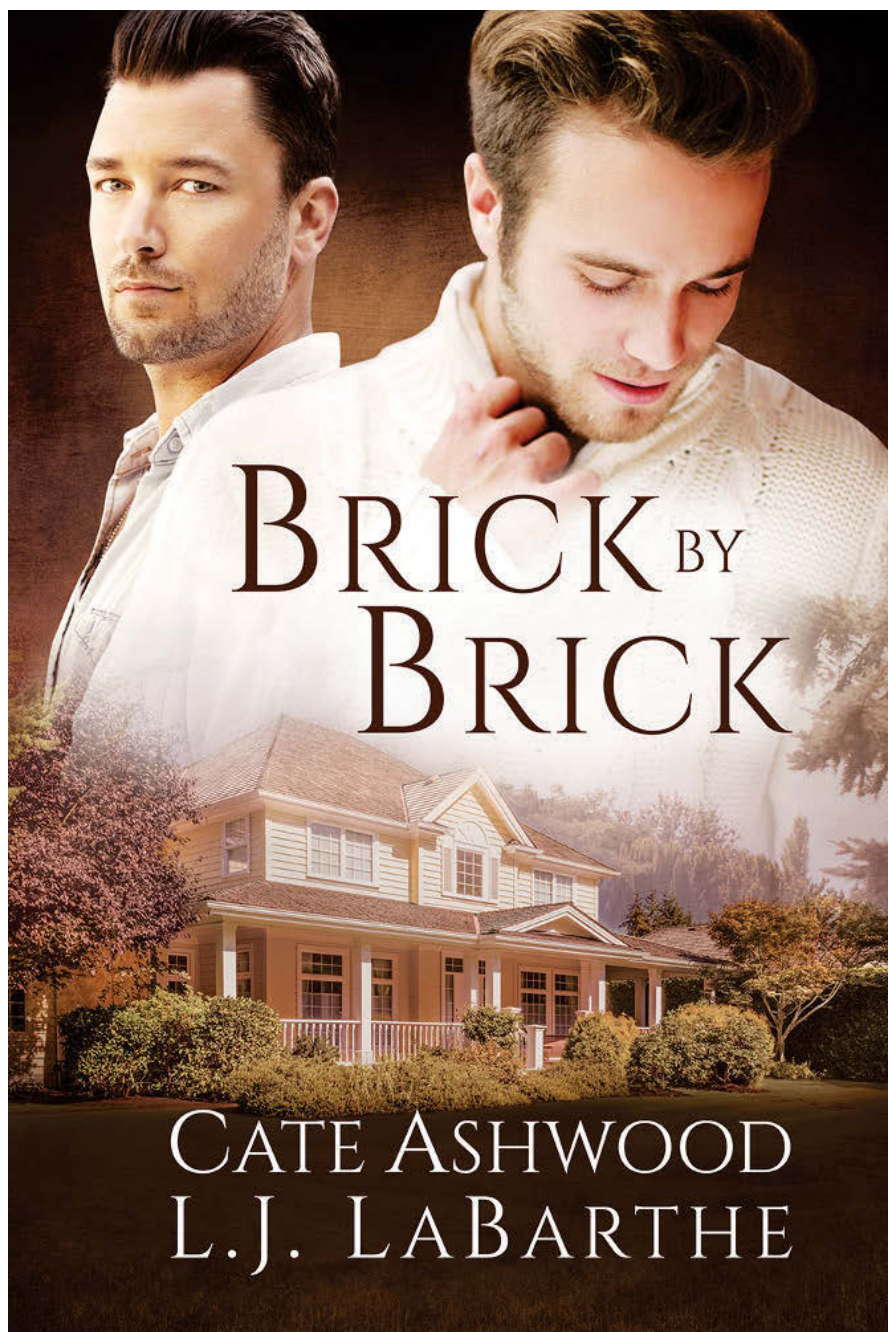




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CHAPTER ONE

PARLEY HAD had enough. He scowled at the ground as he walked, thinking hard about what he was going to do with his life. He wanted to get away, to run, to be *free*, to be able to shuck the formality of wearing suits and ties every day—even to school, and damn, hadn't that made his life difficult—and he wanted out. He wanted to get away from the expectations of his family, the expectations of his religion, and the expectations of his few friends at church. He should be preparing, everyone said, to go on the most important journey of his life, his crowning moment: going out into the world in the service of God and the church. Parley found that to be a pile of garbage. He'd graduated in one piece and, as far as he was concerned, *that* was the crowning moment of his life.

School had been hell. Parley, his parents, and his four brothers had moved to Vancouver when he was thirteen. He had enrolled in one of the local high schools with his brothers, even as his parents turned to their new church—same religion, different location, less stringent and controlling, and more welcoming and gentle. They immersed themselves in what they believed was right. They'd fled their previous home in eastern British Columbia the previous summer. Parley's father had supposed it to be a sinful place, home to apostates and pretenders, more interested in passions of the flesh than passions of Christ. Parley hadn't minded leaving. If anything, he'd been thrilled. The chance to see a big city such as Vancouver was exciting, and going to a real school, a school with more than sixteen kids, to learn things other than scripture study was intriguing.

The reality, while mentally stimulating and challenging, had not been at all what Parley had imagined. His two older brothers, Heber and Reed, and his younger brother, Parker, had remained aloof, convinced of their own superiority by reason of their upbringing, but Parley hadn't wanted to be that

way. He'd wanted to make friends and just be a regular kid. The first stumbling block to that, apart from the fact that he wore suits and ties to schools, was his name.

Parley had found himself the butt of many jokes, called "Parsley" or, more often than not, "nerd," "geek," "weirdo," and sometimes, much to his shame, "faggot" or "Bible basher." The first four didn't bother him, not really; the last two did. Parley had no real problems with the Bible. He'd been raised to read it and supplementary books, and over the years, those books had become less of a chore and more like friends. There were stories in those books about people with diverse lives facing great trials and tribulations, being persecuted and hated. Parley had grown to love those stories and he clung to them when, late at night, he would lie awake in his bed trying to ignore the tears that streamed down his cheeks as he thought about school. His brothers snored around him, oblivious to his turmoil, and Parley retreated more and more into himself.

But it wasn't just his fondness for the stories in the Bible, no. It was that Parley was painfully aware, more and more as he got older, that he was *not like other boys*. He wasn't talking with his friends or family about taking Sarah Smith to the prom or Louise Gray to the church's debutante ball. He was thinking about the boy who would be taking Sarah to the prom, what he'd be wearing, how he'd move on the dance floor, how he'd smile and laugh. He would watch the young man escorting Louise, trying not to let his gaze linger on the seat of his dark-colored trousers, not wanting to be obvious that he, Parley, was ogling another boy's bottom. His father would kill him, his mother would never stop crying, and his brothers would disown him. Parley's life had been focused on family and religion for so long that being bereft of either was frightening. As he grew older, the thought of losing his family became his biggest fear. Religion was everywhere, after all, as he learned in school. Family was not.

So Parley was definitely a faggot and he liked reading the Bible, which, he supposed, made him a Bible basher. He was a geek, a nerd, and a weirdo; he wore clothing more suitable for church or one of those super-expensive private schools. He was quiet, not interested in sports (except hockey, but everyone was interested in hockey), partying, getting high, or any other sort of teenage rebellion.

School had been dismal, all in all, bleak and full of a depressing sort of sameness. Go to class. Sit through it. Go to the next class, repeat until lunch time, then find a quiet spot to eat and make sure you didn't get picked on. That had been Parley's life until his final year when he'd met Zach. Zach had been sidelined from the soccer team due to an injury, and then he'd been made to take on a tutor, as he was failing math. That tutor was Parley. At first, things had been strained between them, but a mutual love of hockey had brought Zach out of his bad temper and they had quickly become friends.

Parley felt the corners of his mouth quirk upward. He couldn't stay angry when he thought about Zach. Zach was his first and only real friend. Zach swore like a pirate, laughed a loud, bellowing laugh that seemed to be the very definition of joyful, and was quite possibly the most gorgeous guy Parley had ever seen in his eighteen years. Zach was funny and kind, and, as their tutoring sessions had progressed, he'd apologized for being so cranky when they'd first met. Parley's smile grew as he remembered Zach saying to him, "Dude, sorry I was such an asshole back when I met you. I love soccer, you know? And being sidelined, that was like the shittiest thing in the world. And being told I was failing? That topped off the shitty cake with a shitty cherry. So I took it out on you, and I shouldn't have and I just wanted to say, you know, I'm sorry."

That apology had solidified Zach as the Sexiest and Nicest Guy Ever in Parley's mind. Their friendship had deepened quickly and lasted the whole of their graduating year. More than that, it was Zach's face that Parley would imagine late at night, when he lay curled into a ball in bed, his hand inside his pajama pants as he touched himself. It was Zach's name that Parley would repeat like a litany as he fought away the sense of shame that came from what he did in the dark, the sinful touches that felt so good, so *right*. Parley was bad. He knew that. He was made wrong, and one day, sooner or later, he'd be punished for it.

Eighteen and cranky, hot in the sweltering Vancouver sun, his discomfort was made worse by the cheap polyester suit he wore. He walked toward the school—the old school, the school that was now in his past—because he didn't know where else to go to get away from his family for a few hours. They were preparing for church service and his mom had been assigned to do the flowers for the chapel, and so everyone was running around, fetching things for her as she juggled the baby in one

arm—Parley’s sister, Emma—and vases and other things in the other. Emma was a blessing, everyone said. Emma’s arrival was a sign to show that coming to Vancouver was following God’s plan. If that were true, Parley thought, then he’d build a temple in Emma’s honor.

Coming to Vancouver had ended up being the best damn decision his parents had ever made. Despite the disappointment that school life had been, everything else had improved dramatically. Here, there was less restriction on who Parley could see and talk to, there were more people—many thousands more, in fact—and the city seemed to stretch forever, like a tide of humanity and color that filled Parley’s heart with wonder. There was less fear and there were people who weren’t part of his religion, perfectly kind, honest, genuine people. The best of them was Zach, who Parley felt was one of the nicest guys on the planet.

Parley turned into the school, the gates wide open as the soccer team trained. He gave the field only a cursory glance and kept walking, making his way toward the atrium, with its shaded walls and lush plants. This was where he’d spent a good deal of his final year sitting with Zach and talking about more than just math or hockey.

In the atrium, he stopped, staring in surprise to see he wasn’t alone. It was summer vacation and he’d expected everyone to be gone. That the soccer team was training wasn’t really a surprise. Coach was always yelling about how they needed the extra practice after school, before school, on weekends, during vacations. Parley had sometimes wondered if Coach would make his team run drills in their sleep.

Parley squinted as he tried to figure out who was sitting there, half-hidden by a large palm tree that seemed so incongruous in a space full of bushes and flowers and an ancient oak tree. But the figure turned and Parley started. It was Zach.

“Zach! Hi!” Parley ran over to join his friend. He couldn’t wipe the smile off his face. He suddenly felt lighter, as if he were running on air, his feet given wings by the surge of happiness he felt at seeing Zach.

Zach looked up and his handsome face split into a broad grin. “Parley, hey. I didn’t hear you.”

“Sorry.” Parley shrugged and sat down beside Zach. “What’s going on?”

Zach huffed, the smile fading. “I had to get away for a while. My parents are giving me shit because my grades suck too badly to get into UBC. Honestly I don’t think they’re good enough to get into Kwantlen. They got pissy because I said I didn’t really want to go to college, that I wanted to get a job, and then Dad... well, Dad slapped me, and so here I am.”

“Oh my goodness. Your father hit you?” Parley was shocked.

“Yeah, but it didn’t hurt. It wasn’t that hard. I think he was more horrified he’d done it than I was. He’s never done that before and I did kind of push his buttons. But damn, man, I know that if I don’t get a scholarship, there’s little to no chance of getting to college. We just can’t afford it. And I’m not so smart that I’d even stick it out. So I’d rather get a job and support myself, but Mom and Dad didn’t like that idea. I don’t know why—it was a good idea, I thought.”

“Parents are weird,” Parley said.

“Damn right. What about you? What brings you here? I would’ve thought you’d be off somewhere, like Bible Camp.”

Parley laughed at that. “No, we don’t do that sort of thing at my church. Mom’s busy with my brothers and sister, and Dad’s at work, so I ducked out and went for a walk. I left them a note on the fridge, though, so they wouldn’t worry.”

“You know, if you got a cell phone, they wouldn’t worry so much anyway.”

“Mom doesn’t like them. She thinks they’re tools of Satan. That’s not part of the church,” Parley hastily added as Zach gave him a look, his eyebrows raised almost to his hairline. “That’s just Mom.”

“Ah. Okay. Weird, though.”

“Yeah.” Parley didn’t add that his mother had been born and raised in a closed community dedicated to a fanatical interpretation of his religion. He didn’t say that his mom had been raised to believe that a woman’s place was in the home and to be a good wife and mother, to have as many children as she could before her body gave out. He didn’t say that the compound where she’d grown up had been raided a few years earlier by the FBI, and hundreds of young men and women taken into state custody. That was another country, another time, another world.

"I've been thinking," Zach was saying, and Parley pulled himself from his reverie to concentrate on his friend's words.

"What about?"

"Well, I think I might just pack my things and go. Just... hit the road and see where it takes me. I've got a bit of money, not much, but it'd get me a cheap, crap car and I could just take off, go somewhere else, look for work, maybe do some classes at community college a bit later. The more I think about it, the more I like the idea."

"Where would you go?" Parley was astonished at the audacity of the notion. He couldn't imagine doing such a thing, certainly not on a whim. "Would you tell your parents? They'd stop you!"

"Of course I wouldn't tell them, Jesus! I'm poor, not dumb. I'd leave them a note, like what you do, and just go. Call 'em when I got settled. I just don't want to stick around here for the rest of my life."

"But where would you go?" Parley asked again.

"I don't know. North, south, east, west—does it matter? Pick a road, and drive." Zach shifted to face Parley. "You should come with me."

Parley gaped at him, stupefied by the statement. A legion of reasons why that was a bad idea marched through his head, promptly followed a small voice saying, *You could be free. Really free. And with Zach, who you really like. Isn't that what you want? To be free? To be who you really are?*

Parley swallowed hard, as he felt fear rise within his chest. "I-I don't know...."

"Come on, man, it'd be fun." Zach lightly punched Parley's shoulder. "You could wear clothes that weren't suits. Wouldn't you like to get up and put on a pair of jeans and a T-shirt? Go barefoot, walk through long grass and wriggle your toes in the dirt? Or what about not being made to read the Bible all the time? I know, I know. You like reading that, but wouldn't it be better to read it when you want, and to read what bits of it you want, without someone else ordering you to?"

Parley privately admitted to himself that did all sound rather awesome. But the whole idea of taking off, of running away from everything he knew, was more than a little terrifying.

Zach continued. "We could go to a smaller town, somewhere away from here." He leaned back on his elbows, so that he was half on the low wall and half on the garden bed behind it.

Parley pursed his lips. "I don't know...."

"All right. Let me put it to you this way. Do you like your life the way it is now?"

Parley frowned. "You know I don't."

"Yeah, *I* know that, but do you?"

"That doesn't make any sense," Parley protested.

Zach shrugged. "You keep telling me that you hate how your family lives, the stuff you have to do in the name of religion, that it's not the religion that bothers you, or the Bible or that stuff, but how people twist religion to suit themselves and, most of the time, that doesn't help anyone who follows it. Here's a chance for you to get away from all that, to be your own guy, and to hang out with me, your best friend in the universe. At least try it out and see what you think."

"Zach, running away in a beat-up old car is not exactly trying something out. It's *running away*. My problems, and yours too, will still be here when we come back."

"If we come back."

"Fine. But they'll still be here. And you say you'll call your folks after you settle somewhere, but don't you think they'll take the whole country apart to find you? It doesn't matter that I'm nearly eighteen or that you already are. They're our parents and they love us. They worry about us. They just want us to have a great life and to be happy."

"No, what they want is to live vicariously through us." Zach scowled. "And don't look surprised that I know a word like 'vicariously.' I'm not an idiot."

"I know you're not, and I was surprised that you felt like that, not that you used the word," Parley said. "I would never say you were stupid. Never."

Zach wrinkled his nose. "Sorry, man. I know you wouldn't. But come on. This thing. Let's do it."

Parley shook his head and got to his feet. "I can't. I have responsibilities."

“You’re almost *eighteen*,” Zach said. “We’re teenagers. We should be about to begin our lives, not have them mapped out for us already by someone else.”

“I can’t listen to this. If you do it, at least come and say good-bye before you go,” Parley said.

Zach sighed. “Okay.” And then he hugged Parley, hugged him tight, and for a moment, Parley thought seriously about going with him, especially as it would mean being near Zach, his warmth, his vitality.

“I have to go,” Parley said.

“I’ll come see you tomorrow,” Zach said, ending the hug and stepping back. Parley felt suddenly colder and as if all the color had drained out of his life.

“Okay.” Parley turned and walked quickly out of the atrium. He didn’t look back, instead keeping his head down and his eyes fixed on the pavement as he made his way home. He wouldn’t do something so reckless and irresponsible as what Zach had asked him to. No, he wouldn’t.

But the closer he got to his home, the louder the little voice at the back of his mind grew. And as he entered the house and was assaulted by the sounds of his sister screaming, his mother yelling, his brothers talking over the top of one another and, from next door, a dog barking, Parley wondered. What would it be like? What would life be like not having to crowd into one room with twin bunk beds, sharing with three other teenage boys? What would it be like not having to start the day at 5 a.m. to do an hour of scripture study before getting ready for school? What would it be like not to have to say a prayer before every meal that was so long that by the time “Amen” was said, the food had gone cold?

“Parley! Get in here and take care of Emma!” Heber poked his head out of the living room and glared at him.

“Okay,” Parley said, and went to pick up his sister, gently jiggling her and singing wordlessly to her. Her face was as red as a tomato, screwed up as she wailed, and thankfully she was dry. Parley sent a quick prayer up toward heaven for that small mercy—he hated changing diapers. Soon, she calmed, and although her eyes were glassy and her small, pink bow lips were turned down, she was no longer wailing in his ear.

Parley moved to sit on the sofa and settled Emma on his knee. He leaned down to pick up one of her toys, a plush dinosaur with an outlandish yellow hat on its head, and Emma clapped her tiny hands together as he wiggled the toy in front of her. Of all his family, he would miss his sister the most, Parley thought. And then he stopped as he realized what it was that he'd just thought to himself.

He was going to do it. He felt a frisson of fear and excitement shoot down his spine. He was going to leave everything in his life behind him and go with Zach to wherever it was they ended up. He'd pack his bag and throw it out the window when his brothers were greeting their father, and then he'd grab it when Zach came to see him tomorrow.

Parley felt himself grow hot, as if he'd stuck his hand into a bucket of boiling water. It wasn't summer doing this to him, but nerves. He cooed to his sister, and then he kissed her forehead. Smoothing back the fine ginger-blond hair, he gazed into her wide blue eyes and said very softly, "I'll miss you, Em."

Emma made a happy noise and then giggled, reached out, and grabbed his nose in one hand. He yelped, then laughed. She giggled again and Parley hugged her close, feeling as if they were already separated. That had to mean something, but what it was, Parley had no idea. All that remained now was to pack the few things he wanted to take with him, along with his allowance, and leave. He'd tell his mom that Zach had bought a new car and they were going to the library to do some studying so Zach could apply to community college—anything that sounded plausible enough for her not to ask questions. And then he'd get in the car with Zach and they'd go.

"I love him a lot," Parley whispered to his sister. He knew that she wouldn't understand a word of what he said and there was absolutely no chance of her repeating to anyone what he told her. "I love him and that shouldn't be a sin. It shouldn't be something that's immoral. Heavenly Father made us all in His image and if this was wrong, no one would ever feel the way they did."

Emma nodded seriously, as if she understood what Parley was saying to her.

"Thank you, baby girl," Parley said. "I'll miss you when I'm gone. I promise I'll try and keep in touch."

Emma promptly hit him on the side of the head with her plush dinosaur and Parley laughed.

“Right, there will be no try. I *will* keep in touch with you.”

Emma nodded again and then giggled and leaned into him.

“I hope this doesn’t end badly for us,” Parley whispered as he cuddled her. Around him, the chaos of his family ebbed and flowed as his mother ran into the living room, demanding Heber tell her where he’d put the big vases the last time she’d brought them home from church, Heber in her wake saying he’d put them where she’d told him to and it wasn’t his fault if they’d been moved since then.

Parley watched it all, watched as Parker and Reed came into the room, Reed saying that their father was home now and had just pulled up in the drive, so they should go and greet him. Parley took a deep breath and got to his feet, saying, “I’ll just put Emma in her playpen first.”

No one paid him any mind as he left the living room carrying Emma and went to do exactly that... and pack his duffel bag with the clothes he liked the most, a few books, and the allowance money he’d saved up and hidden in his mattress. Heart pounding, Parley carefully dropped his duffel bag out the window, where it landed in a clump of rhododendron bushes and was hidden by foliage. Then he rushed out of his room, made sure that Emma was all right in her playpen, and went out to join his family in welcoming home his father. He stood slightly apart from the rest of his brothers, watching and listening, knowing they were paying little to no attention to him at all.

As Parley watched his parents discuss the flowers for Sunday, he wondered where he would be by then. His family would be sitting in pews near the front, singing gustily along with the choir and gazing rapturously at the speakers at the meeting, but he, Parley, would not be with them. He’d be with Zach and it would be the first Sunday in his entire life that Parley hadn’t been in a church service of some kind.

“I’ll make it up,” he said, directing his words heavenward. “I promise.”

There was no bolt of lightning, no clap of thunder. No sign or portent to suggest that what Parley was doing—and promising—was wrong. Parley took courage from that and felt comforted a little. Maybe this was the right thing to do after all.

CHAPTER TWO

ZACH PACED nervously around his room. It had never occurred to him that Parley would say no when he asked him to run away together. He'd played the scenario over in his head a thousand times, and every single one ended up with them driving off together in his car, ending up wherever the road took them. He'd thought Parley coming with him would have been a sure bet, and at the edges of his mind, he'd hoped that maybe Parley felt the same way about him as he felt about Parley. He should have known he might have some reservations about taking off without telling anyone. Parley was a good guy. He respected his parents and he never lied, something Zach hadn't always understood, but it was part of what made Parley who he was.

Zach remembered the first time he'd seen Parley at school. He'd transferred in from god knew where. His origins were a mystery, and all anyone could talk about was how weird he was. And he definitely was. He dressed weird and talked weird. He even acted kind of weird. Weirdest of all was that he was really *polite*.

Zach hadn't really thought much of him either way until they were thrown together for math tutoring. Zach had turned his nose up at the idea of having a tutor, especially one his own age, in his class. How mortifying would that be? He'd fought it at first, eventually caving when he was threatened with being thrown off of his extracurricular activities, which for Zach meant soccer. But Parley had met him, sitting down next to him at one of the outdated brown laminate tables in the library, and immediately Zach had felt at ease. His friend had a way about him that relaxed Zach and made him feel like he was capable of doing anything.

After that day, Zach knew Parley was different, and not just because he wore suits to school—Jesus Christ, who *did* that?—but in that his soul was gentler, or kinder somehow. In any event, Zach took an instant shining to him and they became fast friends. Not all the other guys Zach hung

around with had understood their friendship, and that was fine with Zach. Anyone who didn't like it could go fuck themselves. Life was too short to put too much stock into what other people thought of him and who he spent his time with.

And he and Parley had spent a lot of their time together.

It hadn't been a conscious decision at first. In the beginning, it had just been the tutoring sessions, but as they had gotten to know each other, those sessions lasted longer and longer each time, until they were spending their Saturdays together at Zach's house, watching TV or playing video games, just hanging out. From that point on, Parley had become a permanent fixture in Zach's life, and Zach liked it that way.

He had a sudden memory of the first time he'd shown Parley his PlayStation, and how big Parley's eyes had gotten, how his mouth had dropped open in amazement, as if he'd never seen anything like it in his life. It had been hilarious watching Parley fumble with the controller, caught between staring at the TV screen as if he was transfixed by it and trying to make the game behave the way he wanted it to. In the end, Zach had taken the controller from him and played while Parley watched.

He grinned as he thought about the last year. The grin faded slightly as he remembered the conversation they had after that day.

"Par, you were acting like you'd never seen a TV before," Zach had crowed, laughing as he spoke.

Parley had shrugged and looked down at his shoes. "I haven't, Zach. We have one now, but no one's quite sure how to use it, so... we haven't. But we will," he'd added hastily. "I'm positive we will."

Zach had thought it was a bit weird at the time, but had written it off as part of the whole weirdness that was Parley's world and thought nothing more of it. Now, though, the memory made him wonder. What was Parley's family really like? They were so into their church, and that was weird, too. Zach shrugged. He'd ask Parley about this—and about his life before Vancouver—when he saw Parley next, no matter how far away that would be.

Zach turned his thoughts back to leaving town. Graduation was still a week away, but he was itching to get out of there. It felt almost as if there were ants beneath his skin, crawling around and fueling his urgency. He walked to his closet where his T-shirts were piled haphazardly on the

shelf and grabbed a couple, stuffing them in his duffel bag. It wouldn't hurt to be prepared by packing in advance. He'd need to leave at a moment's notice anyway to escape having to tell his parents he was going. He just wished Parley had been as excited as he was to get out of there.

Now that there was a chance he was going to have to go alone, Zach felt differently about it. Where there had been excitement and fire, now he only felt trepidation and reluctance.

He was still going, though. No matter what. He had to get out of this place and see what else the world had in store for him. There had to be more to life than what had been offered in the overpopulated city. He knew that some kids would count him as lucky, growing up in a place where the world was seemingly at his fingertips. He could go anywhere, see anything, and do anything within the city limits. His options were endless in a city like Vancouver, but it wasn't what Zach wanted.

He didn't want the constant traffic and overbearing crowds. He didn't want to be some nameless, faceless kid in a throng of thousands of students. His options for university were limited, and he knew it. Even if they hadn't been, university wasn't high on his list of things to do in his life. He'd known people who had gone to school, and where had it gotten them? No place he wanted to be.

No, Zach liked things simple and honest. He wanted a house in the country and maybe a couple of animals. He wanted quiet and time to himself, and he wanted to work with his hands. He'd always been good with them, but his parents were so focused on the academic side of things. They wanted a superstar soccer player son who was granted a free ride to the education they had always desired for him. They wanted good grades and a white-collar job with a prestigious title.

He got it. His parents hadn't had the same opportunities he had. They wanted better for him, more for him, a better life. But they'd never once stopped to ask him what he wanted. He knew they'd be disappointed with his lack of ambition, but to Zach, doing something like carpentry was what made him happy. *Simple. Honest.* Something he could be proud of.

He wasn't smart like Parley and he never would be. He accepted his lot in life, and he thought he was all the happier for it.

Thinking about Parley again brought back those fluttery feelings in his stomach. Usually they cropped up when he thought about Parley, just

because he was Parley. Today, though, they were there for an entirely different reason.

HALF AN hour later, Zach was mostly packed up and ready to go.

“Zach, dinner!” his mother called, the sound muffled by his closed door. He knelt down on the floor and stuffed his bag under his bed, making sure the straps were completely concealed before standing and wandering out to the kitchen.

“Wash your hands and sit down,” she instructed, as though she hadn’t been telling him the same thing every night for the past eighteen years.

He did as he was told, though, taking a seat beside his father and letting the zesty smell of his mother’s casserole waft over to him. It may not have been gourmet, but he did love his mother’s cooking.

She sashayed into the dining room, carrying the dish of chicken, vegetables, and creamy sauce, and set it down on the trivets in the center of the table.

“Help yourselves,” she encouraged Zach as she passed the serving spoon to him.

He dished out a portion for himself and passed the spoon to his father.

“How was school today?” his dad asked.

“It was fine. Just winding down for finals.”

“When is your first one?” his mom asked.

“Tomorrow.”

“Are you ready?” His dad had always taken a keen interest in his academics. Zach knew they had pinned their hopes and dreams on him, and he felt like shit for letting them down. He knew they were going to be devastated when they found out he wasn’t going to university.

Until now, he hadn’t had the heart to tell them that he hadn’t gotten in anywhere. True, he hadn’t put much effort into the application process. It seemed like a waste, spending hundreds of dollars to apply for a spot in a school he didn’t want to attend. He’d sent out a couple, just to be able to say he had tried, but he knew deep down he would never be accepted at

the big universities. If he were going to go to school, it would be at one of the smaller colleges, and his heart just wasn't in it.

"Yeah, piece of cake," Zach lied. "Parley helped me study for this one, so it shouldn't be too tough."

"Math?" The doubt crept in around the edges of his dad's voice.

"History."

Did his parents look worried? Maybe they wouldn't be so surprised after all that he hadn't gotten into school.

"Have you heard back from any of the schools you applied to?" his father asked, as though he had been reading Zach's mind.

"No, they're still waiting on final grades from the exams. It shouldn't be too much longer, though."

"Hmm," his mother thought aloud. "I think the Khan boy has been accepted to UBC."

"Probably conditional acceptance. Not all schools do that," Zach said.

"Yes, that makes sense."

After that, the topic was dropped for the remainder of dinner. The family ate in silence, which put Zach on edge. He didn't really like lying to his parents, but he couldn't bring himself to dash all their hopes and dreams in one shot. He knew they would find out eventually, but he hoped to be far, far away by then. Was that a little cowardly? Maybe. But it was the only way he could see the situation playing out.

THE NEXT few days were torture for Zach. Final exams left everyone stressed and on edge. Most of his friends were guaranteed spots at universities based on sports scholarships, but not Zach. Despite his decision to forego a postsecondary education, the pressure remained on him to do well on his exams. Even if he didn't want to go to college *now*, it didn't mean he would never want to, and he wasn't willing to close those doors for himself.

Parley was even more preoccupied with exams. He had never been one to take academics lightly, and although he probably could have slept through his classes, never cracked a book, and still aced the tests, Zach could see the pressure building. He was practically vibrating with it.

He wanted to pull Parley into his arms and hold him, massage the tension from his shoulders, and tell him everything was going to be okay. He didn't dare broach the subject of leaving together again quite yet. Parley had enough going on, and Zach didn't want to add to the anxiety he was feeling. He thought it best if he left the topic untouched for a time and asked Parley once more on the day he planned to go. He knew Parley wouldn't have forgotten, and was hoping that by the end of exams, he would have changed his mind.

Part of Zach was afraid to ask. He didn't want to hear Parley tell him no again. He hoped with everything he had that his friend would change his mind and go with him. He felt like his whole world was banking on his answer, like the rest of his life hinged on that one yes or no.

He knew that was ridiculous. Most people from high school didn't stay friends for long, but he hoped that he and Parley would defy the odds and keep their relationship as strong as it had always been.

Finally, it was the day of Zach's last final. He arrived at the school a little earlier than usual. This test was going to be the most challenging of all. Math. Something he had always struggled with and never really conquered or fully understood, despite Parley's best efforts to help him. He never would have passed the class if it weren't for his friend's help, but even with the valiant efforts, his grades weren't as high as he would have liked.

He saw Parley across the parking lot in front of the school. Waving, he walked toward him.

"How are you feeling?" Parley asked as they both turned and began walking toward the school.

"Good, I think. As prepared as I can be, I guess." Zach responded.

"You're going to be great."

"How about you? This should be no big deal for you. You've got this in the bag," Zach teased.

Parley merely shrugged. "I've prepared as much as possible. Now I just go in and do my best."

They passed through the double doors into the school. The hallways were still quiet that early in the morning. With only a few days left in the school year, most students had reached their limits, opting to cram in their last-minute studying at home rather than sit in the classrooms and

hallways that had felt like a prison for so long. Zach felt the same way, but any chance to spend time with Parley was worth a little sacrifice, especially if these were the last few days he was going to be able to see him.

They stopped by their lockers, both aware that this would be the last time they performed this ritual, one they had developed after spending day in and day out in this building. First thing in the morning, Parley would come to Zach's locker. Zach would grab his things and then follow Parley to his locker. If they were lucky enough to have the same classes that morning, they would walk together, and if not, they would part ways and meet up again when schedules permitted.

Today there wasn't much left in the lockers. No textbooks, magnetic mirrors, or old sandwiches crammed in the bottom. No jackets or notes from friends hung inside. Today was the day they would hand in their locks, write their last exams, and finally be free.

They found a spot just outside the exam room to sit. Sliding down to the floor with their backs against the wall, Zach let his knees fall to the side, resting them against Parley's. The physical contact calmed him, just when his nerves were starting to fray at the edges.

"Do you want me to quiz you on the formulas?" Zach asked, knowing full well that Parley didn't need the help, but wanting to offer it anyway. He often felt lacking in comparison to his friend. Parley was so smart, and so kind, and what did Zach really bring to the table?

"Yes, please," Parley said as he folded his hands patiently against his stomach.

Zach reached into his pocket and pulled out the formula sheet, running through them one by one. Of course, Parley was able to rattle them off effortlessly.

Before they knew it, it was time to go in.

"This is your last one," Parley said. It wasn't a question, because Zach knew he already knew the answer.

"Yup. Last one. You have one more?"

"Yeah, chem is this afternoon. Then I'm finished."

"Want to meet up tonight at Jack's?" Zach asked, naming the popular burger place.

"That would be good," Parley replied.

Their teacher gestured for them each to take a seat at one of the desks, then went through the list of rules for taking the exam. Zach zoned out. This was his last one and he'd heard this speech a hundred times already. No talking. No cheating. No disruptive behavior. Blah, blah, blah.

The booklets were handed out, and the students were given instructions to begin. Zach tore open the packet and began to answer the questions methodically. It was difficult to concentrate on the numbers in front of him. Every time he tried to remember a formula, it reminded him of learning them in the first place with Parley's gentle guidance. In the quiet room, with the only sounds being the scratching of pencils on paper and the occasional cough or sigh from his fellows, he glanced over at his friend and let his mind wander for a moment.

Parley had never been one of those guys you could just throw your arm around. In fact, he had never been much into physical contact at all. The first time Zach had touched him, he'd flinched. Zach had been a bit surprised, but backed off immediately. He hadn't been trying to make Parley uncomfortable, but physical contact was always something Zach had taken for granted with his other friends.

Over time, Parley had become more relaxed with him, and the closeness they developed and the bond they shared became more and more effortless. Zach loved being the person that Parley was comfortable enough with not to worry about keeping safe physical distance between them, and secretly, he loved touching Parley.

Not that there'd been too much touching; there had never been any boundaries crossed, but the simple act of their knees touching under the table or their shoulders brushing as they walked down the street together made Zach's skin tingle in a way it hadn't with anyone else. When he was alone and there was no one around to guess what he was thinking, he let his mind wander to thoughts of one day gathering up enough courage to kiss Parley. It was a favorite fantasy of his, but not something he ever dared to share with his friend. He didn't know how that would be received, and he was terrified of ruining the trust they had built.

Zach glanced over at Parley, who had his head down, bowed in concentration as his pencil scratched furiously at the paper. Zach smiled to himself. He was in the zone. Which was exactly where Zach should be. He

turned his attention back to his exam and tried to focus. He owed it to Parley, and to himself, to try his hardest.

AFTER HANDING in the last exam he would probably ever write, Zach gave a brief wave to Parley as he walked out of the room, and then proceeded at a near run out of the building. He was so glad he was done. No more high school. Forever. Now he could concentrate on doing what he wanted to do, rather than what was demanded of him. He couldn't wait until he took off, to become his own man, away from the expectations of his parents.

He was looking forward to meeting up with Parley at Jack's, but first he had something very important he had to do.

Changing course for the opposite way from home, Zach walked the few blocks down to the used car lot he had passed a few weeks earlier. There, in the corner, was the car that had inspired his idea to get the fuck outta Dodge in the first place.

The ancient, partially rusted-out red beater car was nothing like the swank BMW and Mercedes vehicles that the international students at school drove. There was nothing sleek or polished about it, and Zach knew it wasn't going to run forever, but if he could afford it, it would be all he would need. It was the first time he'd ever made a major purchase like this. It made him feel more like an adult than finishing high school had.

He patted his wallet in his back pocket, smiling to himself at the thickness of it. This was it. He was really going to buy this piece-of-shit car he was already mostly in love with, and he was going to use it to flee, steering it toward the life he'd dreamed of having.

Marching into the dealership, ready to take that step forward, Zach approached the first salesperson he saw. "I'd like to talk to someone about buying a car."

The salesman, an older man with neatly trimmed graying hair and a set of wire-rimmed glasses, smiled as though he had once been in Zach's shoes and knew exactly how he felt.

"That's probably something I could help you out with. My name's Martin. Did you have a car in mind?"

"I'm Zach. I wanted to take a look at the little red Honda Civic hatchback you have in the parking lot."

"You bet," Martin said. "Let me just grab the keys."

Zach exited the dealership and walked over to the car, peering through the windows to the gray fabric seats. He could see himself sitting there, driving with one arm resting on the open window frame, relaxed and listening to music. It was a nice image.

"Here we are." Martin jingled the keys in his hand.

Zach's stomach leapt. The car was a piece of junk, but he wanted it so badly he could taste it, like anticipation was a tingle on his tongue. He waited patiently for Martin to unlock the doors before he slid into the driver's seat. There was an odd smell coming from somewhere, a bit like patchouli and tobacco, but he found he didn't mind the scent. It added... character. Zach slid his hands along the well-worn fabric, getting a feel for the foam beneath. This was the captain's chair, the chair he would sit in as he set out on his great adventure.

Martin handed him the keys. "Start 'er up," he encouraged.

Zach didn't need to be told twice. Slipping the key into the ignition, he turned it over, listening to the gravelly sound of the engine starting. No coughs or sputters to be heard, and although it wasn't the quietest of vehicles, there was no doubt that the thing ran just fine.

"How much?" Zach asked, almost afraid of the answer. There was a sticker mounted to the window with the word "SALE" printed in large red block letters, but Zach hadn't seen a price anywhere.

"Make me an offer, kid," the man said, that knowing smile from earlier back once more.

"All I got is three hundred. I know it's not much...." Zach let the words fall as his stomach knotted tighter. This car was by far the worst one on the lot. If he couldn't afford this one, there's no way he was going to be able to afford something else. This was his only hope.

Martin chuckled. "Tell you what. The list price on this one is three fifty, but tomorrow is our customer appreciation sale. All the cars on the lot are going to be discounted. Maybe we could call this an early bird special and I could give it to you for two twenty-five. You'll have a little left over to buy some gas."

BRICK BY BRICK

Zach wanted to leap out of the driver's seat and throw his arms around the guy. Two twenty-five? Was he for real? Suddenly, Zach's dreams of riding off into the sunset were back in glorious Technicolor.

"You got yourself a deal," Zach declared, happier than he could remember being in a long time. He couldn't wait to show Parley his new wheels. Maybe he could drive him home after they grabbed their burgers. He was going to be so excited.

"Let's go write it up," Martin said, shaking Zach's hand.

CHAPTER THREE

JACK'S WAS nearly empty when Parley arrived. He smiled and nodded in greeting to Joyce, one of the owners, who was behind the counter. Looking around, Parley realized he'd arrived before Zach, so he made his way over to a corner booth by a window and took a seat.

He gazed with unseeing eyes out into the parking lot that fronted Jack's. There were three cars: a brown sedan, a Honda motorcycle parked close to a shiny red Chrysler, and a small white two-door hatchback with pink flower stickers along the bottom of the rear window. Beyond, the road pulsed with life, cars moving in the ebb and flow tide of constant motion.

"What can I get you, hon?"

Parley jumped, jolted out of his reverie by Joyce. "Um...."

"Sorry, didn't mean to startle you there. You okay?"

"Yes, I'm fine. Sorry. I was just thinking, that's all."

Joyce smiled at him. "I'm told that happens a lot. So, can I get you anything?"

"Just a glass of water, please."

"Sure thing." Joyce gave him another smile and left, and Parley sank back into the seat.

He was glad she hadn't asked if he'd wanted a pop or a milkshake or coffee. For one thing, he'd never had caffeine in his life (which Joyce knew) and he wasn't about to start now. For another, and more importantly, he thought, he wasn't sure that something full of sugar would sit well in his stomach, considering it was packed with butterflies. Those butterflies seemed to be performing astonishing acrobatics that only made him feel queasy and anxious. His pulse raced and he felt hot despite the cool air that was swirled through Jack's by the efficient air conditioning.

Joyce returned a moment later with his water, and Parley bit out a quick thank-you, hoping she didn't notice how breathless he sounded. He

was on the verge of a panic attack, Parley realized. He closed his eyes and took a deep, slow breath, concentrating on exhaling through his mouth. In and out, in and out. Gradually, he felt his heartbeat calm and the butterflies take roost, letting the queasiness fade away and the terror ease. He opened his eyes and then let out a loud squawk.

Sitting opposite him, gazing at him with concern, was Zach.

“What are you doing?” Zach asked.

“Breathing,” Parley snapped. He looked down at the bright orange Formica tabletop, clenching his hands together on it. “Sorry,” he added.

“‘S all right. What’s going on in your head?”

“I’ve reached a decision.”

“Oh yeah? Wait. Before you tell me, look out the window.”

Parley did as he was told. “What am I looking at?”

“See that car?”

“Which one? Oh—the red one beside that car with all the pink stickers on it?”

“Yeah.”

“Yes, I see it.”

“Isn’t it awesome?”

Before Parley could answer, Zach continued. “It’s mine.”

Parley turned his head so he could look at Zach in astonishment. He felt as if he’d given himself whiplash from moving so fast, and he wondered if he looked as comical as he thought he did: his eyes wide, his mouth open. “What?”

“I bought a car,” Zach said. “And that’s the car that I bought.”

“Oh my gosh. You’re really doing it. You’re going to just drive off into the sunset!”

“Yeah, man.” Zach reached over and grabbed a packet of sugar out of the dish on the table. He toyed with the paper as he spoke. “I got a sweet deal on it too.”

“Does it run?” Parley couldn’t help himself from sounding skeptical. “It looks as if all that keeps it going is a wish and a prayer.”

“If the wish and a prayer are called fuel and engines, then sure. Dude, it runs. It’s old and it’s not beautiful or anything, but she goes and she’s mine, and I love her.”

"You are aware that you're speaking about a car, right? Cars are not anthropomorphic."

"Par, it amazes me how you can take something as awesome as my first car and turn it into something totally uncool. Anthropomorphic? Really? And I know what the word means," Zach added hastily as Parley opened his mouth.

"At least you were paying attention in class, I suppose," Parley said. Then he sighed. "I have something important to tell you."

"Okay." Zach looked a little hurt, and Parley wondered why.

"The car is... well, I'll take your word for the moment that it runs. But it's good that you bought it, because I've decided that you're right and that we need to get away. I need to find what it is that I want out of life for myself. I need to learn about myself. I love my family, but I need to be away from them for a bit."

Zach's expression had changed as Parley spoke, and as he finished, the smile that was his reward was almost brighter than the sun. It was all the affirmation Parley needed. This was the right choice, the right path to take. Zach was his best friend, and while Parley wasn't entirely sure what else he felt about Zach, he knew that he loved him, platonically if nothing else.

The little voice in the back of his mind, however, had much more to say. *You love him much more than that, Parley. You think dirty, wicked thoughts about him. Just admit it.*

Parley pushed the voice aside and forced himself to concentrate on what Zach was saying to him. "Pardon?"

"Do you just zone out at random points?" Zach asked. "This is a serious question, by the way—I've noticed you do that a lot. It seems like you're paying attention and then bam! You're off with the fairies or the angels. I guess they would be more to your liking."

"Angels are everywhere," Parley said automatically. "I'm sorry. I'm still a bit freaked out at myself. I've never made a decision like this in my entire life. I feel like I'm standing at the edge of a cliff, and I know the best choice is to jump rather than turn away, but I can't see what it is I'll be jumping into. It's the not knowing that is giving me some problems."

Zach reached over and touched Parley's hand. His fingers were warm and dry against Parley's skin. "I know what you mean. I do. Don't

think I'm just saying that, because that's how I feel too. But I don't want to let the fear win this. I want to beat it and do what I know is the right choice for me."

Parley gazed at Zach with new respect. "I wish I was as brave as you are."

Zach laughed at that. "Dude, I'm not brave. I'm good at faking it, that's all."

Parley smiled at that. He felt his lips twitch and a rush of relief pour over him. "I'm glad you're human," he teased.

"Just as human as you." Zach sprawled back in his seat. "Do you want a Coke or something?"

"No, water's fine, thank you."

"Oh right, no caffeine for you. I forgot for a moment. You could have Sprite? I don't think that has caffeine in it."

"No, that's all right. Water is what I want."

"Okay." Zach seemed to accept that and Parley was relieved. He would have to tell Zach about his childhood at some point soon, he realized. They were going to be on the road together, the two of them alone in a confined space, traveling to who knew where. Silence could be golden, but conversation with a trusted, much loved companion was diamonds. Soundlessly, in the depths of his mind, Parley promised himself that when they were on the road, he'd tell Zach about his life.

"Do you want a Coke?" Parley asked. "My treat," he added, seeing Zach hesitate.

"I..."

"Joyce," Parley called, deciding to take the lead, "Zach wants a Coke, if that's all right?"

Joyce, back behind the counter, laughed and Parley smiled. "Of course it is, hon."

Zach thanked her and Parley lifted his glass of water to his lips and took a small sip.

"You didn't have to do that," Zach said.

"I know." Parley set his glass back down on the table. "I wanted to."

"So what made you decide to come with me?" Zach asked.

Parley waited until Joyce had brought over the pop, and once she was out of earshot, he took a deep breath and began to speak. He kept his

voice low; he knew Joyce wouldn't be able to hear him from the other side of Jack's, but he felt this was a subject that should be kept between him and Zach, and that meant keeping his voice soft. Anyone could walk past at any time. He looked over Zach's shoulder and saw a half-dozen kids they'd gone to school with come in, talking and laughing loudly, and that made him be even quieter.

"You remember that day in the atrium back at school when you told me your idea?" As Zach nodded, Parley went on. "I got home and everything was in chaos. Okay, not literally chaos. But it was very hectic. Mom was yelling, my brothers were running about, my little sister was screaming and crying. I picked Emma up and cuddled her, and I had this revelation. I realized that I'd decided to go; I just hadn't admitted it to myself yet. And I thought, well, I haven't been punished by God. I haven't been struck down for having these thoughts and for making this decision, so it must be right."

Zach pursed his lips and gazed at Parley. His look was indecipherable, and Parley squirmed a little in his seat. Had he said too much?

"I honestly don't know how you can put so much faith into, well, faith," Zach said finally. "I don't get it. It doesn't bother me; I just don't understand it."

Parley shrugged, relieved that was all that was on Zach's mind. "It's all I know. It's how I was raised."

"One day you'll have to tell me about that," Zach said.

Parley smiled and nodded. "One day," he agreed.

Zach pulled a face then, rolling his eyes and screwing up his nose, looking almost comical. "God, they're loud," he said, jutting his chin in the direction of their former classmates. "I can hardly hear myself think."

"I should head home soon anyway," Parley said.

"All right. How about I swing past your place later, say around five?"

"Make it five thirty," Parley said. "I'll tell Mom and Dad I'm going to help you study for an entry test for community college."

Zach nodded. "That's a good excuse to give them. It even sounds true." He winked, and the cheeky expression did a lot to absolve Parley's

feelings of guilt at having to tell his family a lie. "So we hit the road around five thirty?"

"That sounds good." Parley picked up his glass of water and lifted it to his lips. They felt suddenly very dry, as parched as the Sahara Desert. He drank the water quickly and set down the empty glass as he swallowed. "Okay, I should go. I'll see you tonight."

"Damn right," Zach said cheerfully. "Later, dude."

"See you later," Parley said. He slid out of the booth and quickly left Jack's, his heart pounding against his ribcage. Whether it was pounding in fear or anticipation, Parley couldn't tell.

BY THE time 5:00 p.m. rolled around, Parley was almost in knots of nerves. He was shaking, and he was almost positive his family could see, but no one said anything. Dinner had been a quiet affair, Heber giving the prayer before they ate, and the only sounds at the table once "Amen" had been said were those of eating and coos from Emma in her high chair. Parley had begged to be excused as soon as he'd cleared his plate, and bolted to the bedroom he shared with his brothers to sit on his bed and gnaw on his fingernails, staring at the clock on the wall.

"Are you all right?"

Parley managed to restrain the noise of surprise at the interruption of his inner panic. Reed stood on the threshold of the room, and his expression was one of concern. Reed was the oldest, and sometimes Parley thought Reed took his responsibilities as the eldest son far too seriously.

"I'm fine. Thanks for asking."

"Are you sure?" Reed entered the room and sat down on the bed opposite Parley. "You were very quiet at dinner."

"We were all quiet at dinner," Parley said.

"That's true." Reed smiled, a soft, gentle smile. "Can I tell you something?"

"Of course." Parley wondered what was on his brother's mind.

"I'm going to ask Leanne to marry me."

Parley gaped at him, stunned. It took a moment for his brain to work, confused as he was by the combination of nerves, worry, and this new

information about his brother's life. And then Parley gasped. "Reed! That's wonderful news!"

"Let's wait until she says yes first before we start to issue congratulations," Reed said. But his smile had grown. "She's a lovely girl, don't you think?"

Parley nodded. He didn't know Leanne very well, but he knew that she was very devout and his parents were friends with hers.

"Her older brother just got back from South Korea," Reed went on, "so there's going to be a welcome home party tomorrow night. That's when I'm going to ask her."

"I'm so happy for you," Parley said, and he meant it. "I'm sure she'll say yes."

"I hope so. Thanks, Par."

"For what?" Parley was confused.

"For not telling me I'm too young or that she wouldn't want to marry me."

"Who said that? Wait. No, that doesn't matter. You're old enough to get married—Mom and Dad were your age when they married. And I don't know what she thinks, but when I see you two at church, she looks happy in your company." Parley shrugged. "Good luck."

"Thanks." Reed stood up and moved over to Parley, then reached down and gently tugged him to his feet. He hugged Parley then, a brief, almost bone-crushing hug, and when he let Parley go, he was smiling broadly.

"You're welcome. And again, congratulations, good luck, all of that." Parley sat back down.

"Oh—one more thing. Why are you sitting in here all by yourself? Weren't you supposed to meet your friend to go and tutor him?"

"Yes. I just wanted to pray a little before I went," Parley said. It wasn't exactly a lie; he had been praying, but prayers in the vein of "Please, God, let this all go to plan" and "Please, God, don't let there be any trouble" were not the usual style of prayers that Parley said.

"Oh. Well, I'll leave you to it." Reed ruffled Parley's hair and had left the room before Parley could say anything else.

The clock had ticked to 5:28 p.m., Parley saw. He took a deep breath and went to the window, opened it, and leaned down, stretching almost

painfully to reach his duffel bag hidden in the lavender bushes. He grunted with effort as he managed to grab it with two fingers and pull it up, wriggling a little in the open window as he got himself back into the room. Straightening his clothes, Parley shouldered his duffel and took a deep breath.

“Right, then,” he said to himself. “Now or never.” He licked his lips and pasted what he hoped was a calm and normal expression on his face and then went out of the bedroom and toward the front door.

“Are you off with Zach, Parley?” It was his mom, calling from the living room.

“Yes, Mom,” Parley called back. “We’re going to the library downtown.”

“All right. Don’t be home too late, and be good.”

“Yes, Mom.” Parley bolted, rushing to the front door and opening it, slipping outside and closing the door quietly behind him. He didn’t dare look anywhere but in front of him, taking quick, long steps down the path to the gate that led to the street and Zach and freedom. “Keep walking, don’t look back. Don’t look back,” Parley muttered to himself, trying not to run. He knew he was being watched. The living room window faced onto the street and his family was no doubt sitting and following his every move through the curtains. It felt as if invisible eyes, full of lazy malignance, watched him, boring into his back and debating whether or not to grab him and haul him back, foil his plans, and dash his hopes.

Parley felt panic rise like gorge, bile hot and thick in his throat, and there was an unpleasant metallic tang on his tongue. He swallowed several times, his mouth gone dry, and then he was pulled from his inner turmoil by the sound of a loud car.

Stepping through the gate and onto the pavement, Parley gaped at the car that roared down the street toward him. The headlights shone bright, revealing the red paint, and the car’s engine sounded less mechanical and more like the mighty bellow of a metallic beast. As Parley watched, amazed, the car slowed and stopped, the engine idling as Zach leaned out of the window.

“You ready, Parley?”

Parley swallowed and nodded, ran over to the car, and opened the passenger side door. As Zach pulled himself back into the car and grinned,

Parley slid into the passenger seat, closed the door, and fumbled with the seat belt.

“Let’s rock and roll!” Zach let out a whoop.

“Can you wait until we’re far enough away that my parents won’t hear you?” Parley demanded, fastening his seat belt.

“Relax. They won’t hear me over the sweet, sweet sound of Bertha’s engine.”

“Bertha?” Parley stared at Zach.

“It’s a work in progress. I might change her name.” Zach did something that seemed entirely esoteric to Parley and the next thing he knew, they were moving, driving away from his family and his home in the dark.

“What’s that smell?” Parley asked.

“Patchouli and stale cigarettes. It’ll fade.” Zach drove along, humming. “Turn on the radio, dude.”

“Okay.” Parley leaned forward to peer at the ancient radio with its cassette deck and shook his head in bewilderment. What had he gotten himself into? Well, too late to back out now, he thought. The only thing to do was enjoy himself.

As he clicked the radio on, Parley repeated that over and over to himself. But it wasn’t until they hit the bridge that he began to relax.

The wind rushed through the open window on the driver’s side of the car, ruffling Parley’s hair, and it was warm and smelled faintly of the sea and exhaust fumes. There was a sense of freedom in the smell, and Parley relaxed further, finding himself tapping one foot in time to the beat of the music that was coming from the radio. Beside him, Zach drove, his hands steady on the steering wheel, and he was grinning. Parley allowed himself a small, longing look at his friend, taking in his handsome profile, his shaggy hair being tugged playfully by the breeze that blew around them, and he knew then that wherever fate—or God—would lead him, as long as Zach was with him, everything would be all right.

For the first time since his childhood, Parley felt safe, truly safe, and truly free, beholden to no one and nothing except the handsome, witty, talented young man beside him. It was liberating and it was intoxicating and Parley did not want it to ever end.

CHAPTER FOUR

ZACH FELT as if he was floating. He'd been planning this escape for weeks, but now that it was actually happening, it didn't seem real. He chanced a quick look at Parley as they merged onto the highway. What could possibly be better than running away with his best friend?

He'd had his doubts that Parley would actually come with him. After being turned down the first time, Zach had prepared himself for disappointment, but now they were leaving together and Zach couldn't have been happier.

"Where should we go?" Zach asked. He had some vague ideas in mind, but he wanted his friend's input more than anything.

"I don't know. Somewhere we can't be found?"

Zach was right on board with that. "That's a good idea. We'll go for a bit on this highway, then we'll exit and take some back roads, maybe head toward the interior."

Parley dropped his head back against the seat. "Perfect." After a time, he said, "I still can't believe we're doing this."

"I still can't believe you came with me," Zach countered.

"I can't either. I must be insane."

"Or brilliant. It's usually a fine line," Zach teased.

"My parents are going to have an absolute meltdown once they've found out what I've done. They're going to be so upset."

Parley's voice was quiet, barely above a whisper. Zach had seen him like this once before when he'd thought he'd lost his weird CTR ring with the spinner chain in the band.

"It'll all be okay." Zach tried to soothe him, to bring him back to the present, and rested a gentle hand on Parley's knee. "Everyone flies from the nest sooner or later. We just did it in an unconventional way. I really do think this is what's best, though, for both of us."

Zach's reassurance seemed to work. Parley blinked slowly a few times and then a somewhat disheartened smile crept onto his face. "I know, but my family is just... different."

"It's going to be fine."

And for now, it seemed like that was almost enough for Parley. His breathing evened out a little and he visibly relaxed into the seat, although his muscles remained slightly tense beneath Zach's touch.

Zach wanted to get them off the highway as soon as he could. He knew the traffic was part of the reason Parley was so on edge. Just as it was when they were alone together in the library, Parley was more comfortable when it was only the two of them, alone rather than surrounded by strangers.

He kept his speed constant, not wanting to risk a run-in with police, but maneuvered around the slower-moving vehicles into the openness of the passing lane.

It didn't take them long to get through the tunnel, and then down the highway past the farmland. The roads were mostly clear now that the after-work rush had subsided, and they were free to go where they pleased.

Before they ran out of road, Zach exited the highway, taking a left, aiming them toward the valley. Living downtown, he didn't get out to the suburbs of Vancouver much, and he'd forgotten how pretty it was out there, greener than anything and less crowded. He chose one of the roads closest to the border to travel. Not many people used it to get from place to place; it was mostly local traffic and a few dump trucks and farm vehicles that were too slow for highway speeds.

Zach slowed the car down, enjoying the ride with his best friend. The road was well worn, the lines painted along the center and sides almost faded completely, and the ditches were bordered with thick blackberry bushes, the flowers just starting to bloom. A couple of months from now, the branches would hang heavy with the dark berries, sweet and ready to be picked.

Zach was almost sad to be leaving. There was a lot here he was going to miss, but he had the most important person in his life with him, and he knew that leaving with Parley was for the best. He needed to forge his own path in life, and having Parley with him made creating that course so much easier. Maybe it was a little selfish—he gave Parley's knee one

more squeeze, finding he was still tense—it was a lot to ask of his friend to give up everything he'd ever known, but in his heart, Zach truly believed he could make Parley happy.

He had no idea how long they had been driving; he just navigated the car down roads that seemed interesting, or at least a little more scenic than the typical residential streets downtown, where the houses were crammed tightly together with the generic city-planted trees that all looked the same. He drove on, and without a destination, it really was the journey that mattered. They weren't on a schedule, and there was no timeline or curfew. They were free to go where they pleased and do what they pleased, and Zach was in no hurry to get anywhere.

"What's the first thing you want to do when we get where we're going?" Zach asked.

"I'm not sure. I suppose we should unpack the car and get settled."

"No, I mean besides that. What do you want to do now that you don't have any responsibilities? Now that you're free to do whatever you you'd like?"

Zach had barely finished his thought when smoke began to pour over the windshield of the car. Taking a deep breath, he switched on his hazard lights, even though they were traveling down an all-but-deserted road, and pulled off to the side.

"What the fuck?" Zach cursed as he shoved the car into park and threw his door open. Parley piled out next to him, inspecting the smoke billowing from the sides of the hood.

"Open it up," Parley instructed, positioning himself in front of the car.

Zach pulled the lever to release the hood and watched as Parley reached underneath to unlatch the hook holding it shut. As he opened it, the steam enveloped them both.

"Goddamn piece of shit car overheating," Zach swore, ripping his shirt off to wrap around his hand, then locating the radiator cap. If he unscrewed it, it would release some of the pressure and the car could cool faster.

"What are you doing?" Parley demanded, grabbing Zach's hand and pulling it back from the guts of the car. Parley waved away the steam a little and waited for it dissipate before leaning in to look at the engine. As

he began to work, he began to talk. It seemed to Zach as if Parley were musing on the past, reliving old memories as he worked with what was familiar to him.

“Before we moved here, my brothers and I used to do a lot of work on engines. Cars, trucks, tractors, mowers—you name it. Heber said he wanted to be a mechanic when he was allowed. Reed used to tease him about going to Hollywood and working with the Osmond family or someone like that. But all the boys in the... community where we lived did work like that. We didn’t go to school, not like school here.

“One day, I remember there was a new car and we had to give it a tune-up. That was fine; we liked the work, and it was a gorgeous car, an old Cadillac. So we were working, and the owner came up to us. We hadn’t realized who he was—he was this really important guy in... the community”—and Zach could tell that Parley was catching himself from saying something other than ‘community’—“and he was furious. We hadn’t used original parts, basically because we didn’t have any. We made do, you know? Anyway, he started screaming about blood atonement, which is when you can shed blood, either your own or someone else’s, for forgiveness. He grabbed me, and had his men grab my brothers, and they hauled us over to this big old tree. They tied us to it, stripped off our shirts, and then began to beat us with our own belts.”

Parley paused to do something with the spark plugs—or was it the radiator?—Zach wasn’t really paying attention. He couldn’t see anything beyond the film of red fury in front of his eyes. And Parley kept talking.

“My mom came running out, sobbing, begging them to stop, but they said they had the right, the mandate from God. So they beat us and... it hurt, sure. It hurt a lot. We’d been beaten before, like, in class, when we’d be learning about scriptures, sometimes the teacher would pick on one of us, drag us to the front of the classroom and pick us up by our ankles and shake us as if we were sacks of rice. That was to shake the evil out of us.

“But this time, the guy who was the leader, he told Mom to get salt. She wouldn’t do it, so he had another of his men grab her and tie her to the tree with us. They beat her too. And then they got the salt from another of the moms there, because everyone was terrified they’d be next. Salt in fresh wounds is the worst feeling in the world, but even more than that was how Mom screamed. I’ll never forget it. She didn’t scream out in her pain, but she

screamed for forgiveness for us, for us to be let go, and she'd take all the punishment herself."

Zach found himself clenching and unclenching his fists. He felt as if he were rooted to the spot, unable to move, unable to think, only able to feel fury unlike any rage he had ever known. He wanted Parley to stop—just for a moment, long enough for Zach to process—but Parley kept talking as he worked over the car.

"Dad came running over then. He had a shotgun. He fired into the air. I kind of lost track of things. It was all a blur. I remember him and Mom helping us into one of the pickup trucks that belonged to the... the community, and then we were driving. The next thing I remember is the hospital, and having the wounds treated. And then Mom and Dad said we were coming to Vancouver to start a new life, with a new church who had the same beliefs but didn't beat women and children."

Parley's voice broke and tears began to stream down his face. Zach let out a deep breath.

He could think of nothing else but committing murder. It took him a minute to pull his thoughts together, and then all he could muster was an angry exclamation. "What in the holy fuck, Parley?" Zach bellowed, not really expecting a response. Parley was too far gone, and frankly if Zach heard any more, he was likely to develop sudden homicidal tendencies. If Zach's innate urge to protect hadn't been piqued by Parley's earlier panic, this was more than enough to launch him into action. He couldn't believe the things that were falling from his best friend's mouth, and it took every ounce of strength he had not to begin punching the side of his car in anger.

He needed to calm down. Parley needed to calm down.

Zach approached him, stepping up and invading his space without a second thought. He crowded against him, sliding his hands up to stroke his thumbs along Parley's temples. Zach tried to lock eye contact with him, but Parley's gaze was unfocused. Zach held him still.

"Come on," Zach pleaded, his voice much calmer and more soothing than he felt. "Just breathe with me. One... two... three...." Zach counted all the way to ten before Parley's eyes narrowed in on his, and Zach felt a surge of relief that his friend was coming back to him. "Everything is going to be just fine."

"Is it?"

The question was sincere, and Parley's voice sounded so small.

"I promise," Zach replied, pulling Parley toward him. He held him close, petting the back of his head as he would a scared child. In a way, Parley reminded him very much of a lost little boy, someone Zach needed to take care of. And he would. He would give up everything to make sure Parley was safe and happy.

He needed to get to know more about what Parley had said before, but it would have to wait. Now was not the time or the place to be delving into Parley's past. Zach had always known there were ghosts lurking in the depths of Parley's mind, ghosts that haunted him and created the dark circles that stained the skin beneath his eyes, but Parley had never really divulged many details before. What little Zach did know made his blood boil in his veins.

Zach continued to hold Parley, trying to come up with a game plan now that they were without a car. Stranded in the middle of nowhere wasn't how Zach had pictured the day ending. He needed to think of something. Parley was holding it together with a gossamer-thin thread. Zach could feel him trembling in his arms.

"I think it's dead, Zach," Parley said, turning gray-green eyes on him. "We'll need to get a few things for it. I know what it needs—it needs some coolant. But then I can fix it."

He looked around, willing a solution to fall out of the sky. He needed to rescue them, but he wasn't willing to give up his plans of escape quite yet. He checked his cell phone quickly, but dismissed the thought. Calling for help was not going to be an option. There was no way he would call time of death on their adventure without exhausting every other possibility first. He powered it down, wanting to conserve the battery in case they needed it later.

When Zach spotted the driveway a few feet past where they had broken down, he felt like his chest was instantly lighter. There was no way he was calling his parents, but asking a stranger if they had some extra coolant sitting around, or at least where the nearest gas station was, was an option. It had to be within a few hours' walk, Zach just had no idea what direction to go in.

He let go of Parley and pointed toward the nearly hidden driveway. The end was almost completely overgrown with blackberry brambles, but something was definitely there.

“Let’s go see if someone in the house back there can help,” Zach suggested, just glad he actually had a plan.

Parley nodded silently and followed Zach, sticking close, as though proximity to Zach was what was keeping him sane. The thought filled Zach with a feeling he couldn’t quite describe. His chest felt larger, like it had expanded with the pride of being Parley’s protector, even if it was just from a panic attack and no real danger.

They stepped cautiously along the gravel driveway, careful to avoid getting snagged by the thorns. As they walked, the house nestled in the distance became clearer, and Zach’s heart sunk a little more with each step. It was very unlikely they would find coolant in the garage of this house.

It was unlikely they would find *anything* in the garage of this place.

There didn’t seem to be anyone living in this house. The grounds were overgrown, the grass and gardens neglected for what Zach could only assume had been years. Bushes overtook two sides of the house, and older-growth evergreens cast shadows across the yard in the dimming light of the evening. The house itself had once been beautiful, as far as Zach could tell, but no one had loved it in years. It was dilapidated, the windows boarded up and the roof missing more tiles than were left in place. The columns in the front that framed the entrance still stood proudly, holding up the sagging porch roof.

Zach took one look at the place and fell in love.

This was the kind of place he had pictured himself living in—maybe without the dust and decay, but all it needed was a little care. Zach surged forward, the broken-down car all but forgotten in his haste to inspect the house more closely.

Together they walked up the jagged path to the front door, being cautious not to trip over the stones that had become uneven from the insistent push of roots beneath them. The steps up to the porch were in need of repair or, more likely, replacement, but they held their weight with only a small creak in protest. Zach pressed the button for the doorbell, and when no sound could be heard, he knocked tentatively on the large wooden door.

He waited a few minutes, not really expecting anyone to answer. Most people would have to be crazy to live in a place like this, but to Zach, it looked like paradise. He could see past the disrepair to the beauty underneath. Unbidden, the thought entered his mind that this was exactly how he thought about Parley. People had always said his best friend was weird, treated him like an outcast, but Zach could see beneath all that, beneath the shy reserve and the polyester suits, to the man hidden away.

When no one answered, Zach reached out, placing his hand on the doorknob and giving it a gentle twist. Much to his surprise, the latch gave way with very little effort and the door swung open with a loud groan.

Parley grabbed Zach's arm. "Do you really think we should be going in there?" Parley asked, the reluctance in his voice clear.

"Sure. Why not? Obviously, no one lives here. I just want to have a quick look around. It's a cool-looking place, don't you think? Besides, there might be a phone book inside and we could try to find the nearest garage or gas station or something... get the car back on the road."

Parley stepped forward in consent, following Zach into the house.

Sunlight filtered between the boards on the windows, illuminating the interior of the house in a dim light. It wasn't much, but enough to make out the features of the place. The room to the left of the front entrance was the living room. Sheet-covered furniture remained, placed in a normal configuration around a very large, ornate stone-carved fireplace.

Immediately in front of them was a grand staircase that was wider at the bottom than at the top. To the right was a dining room, again with the table and chairs covered in a thick cloth.

"Come on," Zach whispered, for some reason feeling as though quiet was more respectful for a place like this. They trod carefully through the dining room, past the staircase to the kitchen. This had once been the heart of the home. Zach could imagine a family making breakfast together on the large gas stove in the center of the bank of cabinets directly in front of him.

He began looking around, opening cupboards and peering in drawers.

"You shouldn't be snooping," Parley said.

"Just looking for the phone book," Zach replied. "Besides, I don't think the old owners would mind. No one has been here in a long time."

Zach ran his finger through the thick layer of dust that coated the marble counters, blowing it off to make a point.

“Maybe not, but this was someone’s home. All their things are still here. It’s not ours.”

“We’re not stealing anything, just looking around. It does make me wonder, though, why someone would leave a place like this. It’s beautiful, don’t you think?”

“Yes,” Parley conceded, “It is. If I had a house, I think I’d want it to be someplace like this.”

Zach’s heart swelled. He was inexplicably delighted that his friend was able to see the hidden beauty as he had, and more than pleased that they felt the same way about it. For a moment, he let himself dream of owning this house, he and Parley together, as a family.

CHAPTER FIVE

PARLEY WASN'T surprised when the car broke down. Truthfully, he'd been surprised that it hadn't happened earlier. When he'd inspected the engine, he felt as if he'd gone back in time, back to when he was a kid, and his life was ruled by three principles: study the scriptures, do what work he was told, and obey without question. He'd talked about things he hadn't thought about for years, and now he wondered why. Why had he mentioned these things to Zach? Why hadn't they stayed buried?

A legion of questions and fears marched through Parley's mind, and his protests as Zach led him into the abandoned house were only halfhearted. He was grateful for the distraction; if nothing else, trying not to inhale too much dust kept him from thinking about what he'd said and what Zach might think of him now.

But Zach treated him the same as he always did—apart from his growl of anger. That, though, Parley thought, had been due to his story, not because of Parley himself. That was a relief, because Parley wasn't sure what he'd do if Zach was angry with him. He scuffed the toe of his left shoe against the dusty floorboards and avoided looking at his friend.

"I wonder if the stairs are okay," Zach said, his voice pulling Parley from his thoughts.

"What? You can't go upstairs. What if you fall through? We're in the middle of nowhere, with a broken-down car! I can't get you any help!"

Zach clapped Parley on the shoulder. "It'll be cool," he said, and before Parley could protest further, Zach had bounded over to the stairs with all the enthusiasm of an eager puppy.

Parley bit his lip, worrying at it between his teeth as Zach tested the first stair. Emboldened by the fact it didn't give way beneath him—in fact, it didn't even creak—Zach stepped up onto the second. And then the third, the fourth... before Parley knew it, Zach was on the landing above him

and whooping with glee. The sound echoed through the house, and Parley couldn't restrain himself from smiling at the sound.

"Par, you have to see the view from up here," Zach called. "It's amazing."

Parley sighed. "If I die falling through the floor, I'm coming back as a ghost and haunting you forever." He made his way over to the staircase and gingerly began to climb, indescribably relieved that the thing held his weight and didn't protest. Soon he was standing beside Zach on the landing and gazing out through the window.

It was grimy from years of neglect and dirt, streaks from rainfalls winding little paths down the glass, but even in the low light you could still see through it well enough. As Zach had said, the view was incredible. Parley gazed out over the landscape, a sea of grass and low, forested mountains, the road a black ribbon winding between sun-bleached fields of corn and long, overgrown weeds. There were fences, wood and wire, standing as silent sentinels between each field and along the shoulder of the road. There didn't seem to be any other human habitation for miles, although he thought he could see what looked like a barn and maybe a large storage shed.

"Where are we?" he asked Zach.

"BC," Zach replied.

Parley sighed. "No kidding. Where, exactly, are we?"

"Somewhere rural."

Parley rolled his eyes. "You have no idea, do you?" It wasn't really a question.

"Nope. Hey, maybe there's a map in the glove compartment of the car."

"You didn't pack one?" For some reason, this was more alarming than anything else that had happened so far. Parley turned from the view to stare at Zach, sure that his expression mirrored his feeling of incredulousness.

"No. Did you?"

"No, I thought you would! You're the one who owns the car!"

"Parley, it'll be fine." Zach raised his hands in a placating gesture.

Parley snorted. "You've been saying that since you picked me up."

“And it’s been fine, hasn’t it? Mostly.”

“The car’s broken down, we’re in the middle of nowhere, and we can’t see anywhere that we might get help. Yes, it’s been a fine mess, that’s for sure.”

Zach looked so downcast at his words that Parley instantly regretted them. He placed a hand on Zach’s shoulder, feeling the warmth of Zach’s skin beneath the thin fabric of his T-shirt. Parley squeezed gently and forced a smile as Zach looked at him, his expression full of doubt.

“It’ll be okay. You’re right. After all, things are sent to try us, so that we can overcome obstacles and learn and grow in the process, right?”

Zach nodded. “Yeah. Did you learn that back where you came from too? Like how to fix a car?”

Parley shrugged. He turned his head to look out of the window again. “Yes, I learned that from people there who gave a damn,” he said softly.

“Look, you know what you said... before.” Zach paused and Parley looked back at him, raising an eyebrow in silent curiosity. “I’m not even going to pretend to understand what your life was like or why your parents didn’t leave that place earlier. Dad says that sometimes religion makes people do weird shit, and so does politics, so that’s why religion and politics should never be a part of polite conversation. Which is bullshit, because half the time, all people talk about is religion or politics. Anyway, I just want to say that if you want to talk about anything—anything at all—I’m here. I won’t judge you. I can’t. You’re my best buddy, and you know me better than anyone else does. I trust you completely. So, you know, just saying... you can trust me.”

Parley was silent for a moment. He had no idea what to say, but he could see how Zach was affected by the snippet of his earlier life that he’d shared. So he nodded and gave Zach’s shoulder one more gentle squeeze. “Thanks,” he said. “I might take you up on that later.”

Zach’s answering smile was warm. “Anytime.”

“So,” Parley looked around the landing, “maybe we should explore this house. There might be old tools or something here, maybe some parts so I can fix the car enough so it can limp to the nearest town and we can get what we need from a proper mechanic shop.”

“That’s a great idea,” Zach said.

"This is a big house," Parley mused, looking around again. "I wonder what the people who used to live here did. And I wonder why they left."

"Yeah, that's kind of weird, isn't it? I mean, it looks like they just took off, leaving all their belongings. And that it happened ages ago, to judge from how thick the dust is." Zach touched the windowsill, leaving fingerprints in the grime. "I kind of want to get a vacuum cleaner and a mop and bucket and clean the place."

Parley burst out laughing. "You want to clean someone else's house? I've seen your room, Zach. You can't even keep *that* tidy!"

"Hey, everything is perfectly in order there, I'll have you know. I have a very complex and efficient filing system." But Zach laughed too, and Parley felt much better than he had since leaving Vancouver.

"Let's go look around," Parley said.

"Okay."

THEY EXPLORED the house from top to bottom, covering themselves in dust in the process. The majority of the building was as Parley had expected—empty, with a few pieces of furniture here and there. He had been amazed when Zach had tried the faucet in one of the bathrooms and, after several dry coughs and splutters, water gushed out. It had been brown and brackish at first, but as they watched, the water cleared and ran as well as it did out of the faucet in Parley's mom's kitchen. After that little discovery, they tried the faucets in all four bathrooms and the kitchen and the laundry room. They flushed the toilets too, and although three of them didn't work, one did, and that was enough for Parley. The practicalities of the situation had hit him as they'd tested toilets—what on earth were they going to use for toilet paper? And towels?

None of these questions seemed to bother Zach, though. He'd kept up a running commentary as they moved from room to room, opening doors, testing switches and faucets, trying to open windows. Each new discovery seemed to fill him with zeal and an infectious delight that Parley found utterly wonderful. He could learn a lot from Zach, Parley thought. He could learn so much about how to see the good in everything, how to find the best in every situation. Zach was so exuberant, so enthused by the

house and everything in it, that it was hard not to be caught up in the tornado of joy he had become.

In the kitchen, Parley began to wonder what they'd eat. He wasn't sure Zach had thought to pack any food; he certainly hadn't and he was mentally kicking himself for not grabbing a few cans from his parents' food storage. He eyed the ancient-looking stove with suspicion, wondering how it was powered—was it electric or gas?—when he spied the large rusting metal box by the door. The door, he thought, would lead outside, but the box intrigued him.

Parley went over to it and opened it. The hinges shrieked in protest but the contents of the box were a sight for sore eyes. It was full of dry, neatly cut firewood, and Parley smiled as he saw it. At the same time, he heard Zach let out a loud yell of glee, and he turned.

"I found cans of food!" Zach was pointing at a small room Parley hadn't noticed. The door had been set into the back wall of the kitchen and upon closer inspection, Parley realized it was a pantry. A rather well-stocked one too, by the looks of things.

"And I found firewood," Parley said, stepping closer to examine the contents of the pantry. He didn't expect that their luck would hold out and that the food would be edible, but it was better to be sure.

"How much of it is okay?" Zach asked. "I mean, what are the expiration dates?"

"I'm having a look," Parley said. There were shelves full of neatly stacked, unopened cans: things like SpaghettiO's, baked beans, Spam, and corned beef. He wasn't sure about the canned meat. That could definitely have gone bad. He peered closely at the other cans, taking in the labels and tilting them so he could catch the light and see better.

"Unbelievable," he murmured. "They're all within a few days or weeks of their expiry."

"So they're okay to eat?" Zach asked. "'Cause I'm getting a bit hungry."

Parley laughed at that. He couldn't help it. "Did you think about food when you left home?"

"Well, no. I thought we'd end up in a town or something, not in a deserted house. But it makes me even more curious about who used to live here."

"I don't think they're coming back," Parley said slowly. "I think if they were, they would have by now, and taken everything. All the dust and the rust—it's too thick. No one's been here in years."

"So you think they filled up the pantry and then left?" Zach frowned. "But why?"

Parley frowned as well. "I have no idea."

"Maybe when we get into the nearest town we can check out the local library or something," Zach suggested. "Someone there might know."

"You? Offering to go into a library of your own free will? I'm shocked!" Parley teased.

Zach blew a raspberry at him, and Parley laughed, Zach joining in a moment later.

"We should have a look outside, too," Zach said, when the laughter had died down. "See if we can't find somewhere for the car. We'll have to roll it down here, I don't want to leave it out on the road."

"Good idea," Parley said. He didn't want to be completely abandoned out here, forgotten, just like this house. At least the car was fixable—and, okay, so was the house—but the car was of greater importance at that moment. "Let's do that before the sun sets completely. We can figure out what to do about lighting after that."

"Oh, there were candles beneath the sink," Zach supplied. "I found them while you were looking at the firewood."

Better and better. Parley felt almost giddy with relief. Things were definitely looking up.

"Great! Bring a couple with you, just in case we get caught out in the dark," Parley suggested.

"Right."

THE OUTSIDE of the house was full of weeds and thigh-high grass. The late afternoon sun was hot, and Parley began to sweat. After a few moments of debating with himself, he took a deep breath and tugged off his jacket and tie, then rolled up his shirt sleeves. It felt good to be able to do that, to not have to answer questions about why he wasn't dressed

appropriately or what was he thinking, tempting the sins of the flesh like that.

“Put your jacket and tie inside,” Zach suggested. “Then you won’t have to worry about losing them out here.”

“Good idea,” Parley said, and he did so, jogging into the kitchen and hanging his jacket and tie from the pantry door handle. He went back outside to join Zach, and found him staring at a small shed that hadn’t been visible from the windows or the road.

“I think there might be something we can use in there,” Zach said.

“Like what?”

“Tools? I don’t know, dude.”

Parley went to the shed and looked at the door. It was secured with a padlock, old and riddled with rust, and he thought that giving it a good, strong hit with something, like a rock, would shatter it. He turned around, casting about for something, when Zach stepped up, a rock in his hand.

“Here, let me try this,” Zach said. It seemed as if he’d read Parley’s mind, and Parley smiled to himself as Zach swung his arm and brought the rock down hard on the padlock.

It shattered with two blows of Zach’s rock, and then they both shouldered the door open. Its hinges had rusted into place, and so it was with a great deal of grunting and, on Zach’s part, swearing, that they got it open.

The interior was dim, but there was enough light to see by. As Parley’s eyes adjusted, he let out a soft gasp. The shed was a veritable treasure trove.

“Whoa,” Zach breathed from somewhere to Parley’s right. “This is amazing!”

“Yeah,” Parley agreed.

The shed contained an old car, a Buick, Parley guessed. It also had row upon row of shelves full of tools for working on machinery or in the field. There were several cans marked Fuel and Parley wondered if that gas would be the sort that their, no, Zach’s car could run on. Several metal storage boxes sat, their lids wide open, revealing all manner of parts.

“I found a few lanterns,” Zach said.

Parley spun to look at him. “Really?”

“Yeah. Look.” Zach held them up. They were old-fashioned candle lanterns, glass and copper and chrome, not much to look at, but, Parley thought, more than good enough for them to use.

“That’s fantastic,” Parley said, and he meant it. And in his mind, he sent up a silent prayer of thanks for this discovery of the shed and all its wonders.

“Light’s going, though,” Zach said. “We should carry these lanterns into the house and bring the car around here before it gets dark.”

“Okay.” Parley spied a smaller trunk by the door, hidden by the shadows and, unlike the other boxes, made of wood. Fueled by an urge he couldn’t identify, he went over to it and opened it. The lid lifted easily, and Parley saw that inside it were books: notebooks, ledgers, and records. He leafed through the top one, gasping at the detail he could see written in a neat, meticulous hand. “Zach,” Parley said, aware of how awed he sounded, “I think these will tell us who the people were who originally lived here.”

“Holy crap,” Zach said, coming to stand beside him. “Shit, that’s amazing. This whole place is amazing! Let’s get it inside. We can look through it tonight.”

“All right. Then we can get the car.”

“Yep.”

Together they carried the box and the lanterns into the house, Parley squinting as the sun began to set, the brightness of the golden and orange rays sharp against his eyes, which had only just gotten accustomed to the dimness of the shed. He dashed outside to make sure the shed door was closed as well as it could be, and then ran around to the front of the house where Zach waited for him.

“This is really becoming an awesome adventure,” Zach said as they walked down the side of the road to the car. “And you were worried we were going to starve or be eaten by zombies.”

“Hush. I was not,” Parley said. “Certainly not by zombies, at any rate.”

Zach burst out laughing.

They reached the car and slowly rolled it back down the road to the gate, where gravel, rocks, and overgrown grass concealed the drive. It

took them a while to turn the car, Parley finally getting into the driver's seat and steering as Zach pushed. Then he got out and closed the door, and the two of them, panting, pushed the car down the uneven drive to the side of the house.

"What do you think, Par?" Zach was sweating and there was a smudge of dirt on his forehead. "Should we push it around to the back?"

Parley shrugged. He wished he had thought to bring a bottle of water or something out of the house with them. It was too late now, though. The sun had set, and it was the murky purple light of twilight. Night was not far away.

"We should give it a try," Parley decided. "Do as much as we can now, the rest in the morning."

"Okay."

Parley unbuttoned his shirt and tugged it off so that the sleeveless white cotton T-shirt he wore underneath was visible. He tied his shirt around his hips as he moved to the back of the car and rested his hands against the trunk, preparing to start pushing again. He was sweating profusely, he knew. It had been quite a long time since he'd done hard work like this. He also knew that when he woke up in the morning, all his muscles would ache. "I am so out of shape," he muttered.

As he looked around for Zach, Parley frowned. Where was he? "Zach?"

"Um. Yeah. Coming."

Zach's voice sounded weird, but Parley dismissed it. They had to get the car around to the back of the house before nightfall. That was first and foremost on his mind. When Zach joined him, Parley bent to the effort of pushing the car and felt his muscles straining. He heard a strangled sort of noise come from Zach beside him, but wrote it off as Zach not used to exerting himself like this and finding it difficult.

Before long, the car was just around the back part of the house, and Parley was relieved. He was also exhausted. "Let's go inside," he said. "Sit down and light those lanterns, and then see about something to eat."

"Sure, Par," Zach said.

“Okay.” Parley grinned at his friend as he untied his shirt from around his hips, balling it up and using it to mop the sweat from his face and neck. “What I wouldn’t give for a shower.”

Zach made that strange noise again, and Parley looked at him sharply. But Zach looked the same as he ever did, although details were hard to make out in the gloom of twilight. “You okay?” Parley asked.

“Sure. Fine. See? Everything’s fine, like I said.”

Parley shook his head. “Okay, okay. You were right. Now let’s get inside.”

CHAPTER SIX

THE LANTERNS created a soft glow that enveloped the kitchen. Zach stood, staring into the pantry, reading the labels in the dim light. He was determined not to think about Parley wearing that T-shirt, all the muscles in his arms and shoulders straining, and that little bit of skin that had been revealed by the back of the garment riding up. No, he wasn't going to think about that *at all*. Not right this second, at the very least.

"What do you feel like tonight? Beans or SpaghettiO's?" Zach asked.

Parley walked up beside him. "I've never had SpaghettiO's."

Zach shot him an exaggerated look of disbelief. "Well, then, prepare your taste buds for the most remarkable culinary treat available from a tin can."

Parley laughed. Zach picked up the can, tossing it in the air and catching it before placing it down on the counter. "We're going to need a way to heat this up. Do you want to try to find a pot and maybe one of those cooling racks or a grate or something, and I'll see if there's something we can make a fire in?"

"Sure," Parley said, opening the cupboards around the stove.

Zach looked in the broom closet near the back door and found a metal bucket, presumably used for mopping. "This should work," he said, turning around for Parley to see. Parley responded by holding up the pot he'd found in the drawer under the oven.

"Now we just need something to light it with." Zach opened and closed drawers until he found one with a plethora of various odds and ends—paper clips, some long-expired coupons, some bits of string—and lo and behold, a book of matches.

"We're going to eat like kings," Zach said triumphantly.

They carried their finds out to the back porch. Zach set the bucket down and placed a few of the pieces of wood inside. Tearing a match from

the book, he struck it against the strip. The scent of sulfur filled the air as Zach meticulously lit the bits of kindling. Parley placed the cooling rack over top of the bucket, and they watched the wisps of smoke curl around the metal squares. Parley opened the can of pasta and tomato sauce and emptied it into the pot. They set the pot down on the wire rack and sat back, pleased with themselves for their ingenuity and resourcefulness.

It didn't take long for the SpaghettiO's to start bubbling.

"That smells... interesting," Parley said.

"Yeah. Just wait until you try it. It has a taste like no other. I grew up on this stuff, though. It was the one thing Mom let me cook by myself."

"I'm sure it's delicious."

Zach looked down at their dinner. "Be right back," he said, darting into the house.

He returned a moment later with two spoons. "Can't really eat that stuff with our fingers," he said, handing one spoon to Parley.

"Thank you."

Zach took the pot off the fire and held it out to Parley. Parley dipped his spoon in, scooping out a small portion of the pasta. Blowing on it, he raised it to his lips and, when it was cool enough, tasted it.

Zach burst out laughing at the unintentional expression that spread across Parley's face.

"No good, huh?" Zach asked. "I guess it's one of those things that only tastes good because I grew up eating it."

"No, it's good," Parley insisted.

Zach shrugged. "It's not gourmet, but it'll fill our bellies."

To Zach, though, it tasted divine. It was the first meal he'd made away from home, and it felt fantastic. His mom had always been the homemaker in the family, his meals provided for him, his laundry done. He knew that most guys would love to have a family like that, but with those perks came a whole pile of expectations he wasn't content to live with.

He was more than capable of making his own way in the world, and part of that was feeding himself. He'd proven able, and although it wasn't the most elaborate meal—or the most nutritious—it would do.

The two boys sat close together on the steps of the porch where they could keep an eye on the dying embers of their cooking fire. Passing the

pot back and forth, they ate spoonful after spoonful of pasta until they were both full.

After the SpaghettiO's had been devoured, they poured over the letters and journals they had found earlier. It was difficult to decipher the writing, the ink faded by the years. There was mention of many names, but none of it made sense to Zach or Parley. Eventually, they gave up, stacking the documents neatly back into a pile.

Once the fire was extinguished, Zach and Parley went inside.

"I'll rinse these," Parley said, carrying the pot and spoons to the sink.

"Thanks. I'm going to see what I can find for blankets and pillows."

Now confident that the structure was sound, Zach ascended the staircase once more, lantern in hand, bounding up the steps with enthusiasm. Independence was as refreshing as lemonade in the summer. He'd had a taste, and although it was a small one, he didn't know if he could ever give it up.

Really, he didn't think there was going to be a need to. He and Parley had been careful about leaving. They'd covered their tracks. No one had seen them, and who would think to look for two boys in an abandoned house out in the middle of nowhere? Zach congratulated himself on such a flawless plan as he opened and closed the closet doors on the second floor.

In the cupboard across from the bathroom he hit the jackpot.

"Found some," he called to Parley, his voice sounding too loud in the empty house. Zach only just then realized that they'd taken to talking in hushed tones since they'd gotten there. It seemed safer somehow.

Zach pulled as many blankets as he could hold from the closet and carried them into the bedroom next door. He looked around, trying to decide if he should put blankets in the other bedroom as well. Would Parley want to share a room?

The thought of it sent a shiver through him. He didn't much want to sleep alone in this big, empty house. It wasn't that he was scared, but the place was a little creepy after the sun was down. If he were being honest with himself, though, that shiver had more to do with Parley than it did the thought of sleeping alone in the ramshackle house.

He and Parley were best friends, but they'd never spent the night together. Sleepovers were a part of growing up, but when he'd met Parley, they'd been a little too old for slumber parties, and besides, Parley's parents were really weird about him spending time at friends' houses.

Alone in this house, though, sharing a bed seemed really intimate. Zach knew exactly how he felt about it. The thought of sleeping next to Parley, of waking up next to him—he couldn't think of anything he'd like more. Well... maybe one or two things.

In the end, Zach decided to pile all the blankets on one bed and let Parley decide where he wanted to sleep. He was just returning to the closet to gather the pillows when he heard Parley stepping onto the landing at the top of the stairs.

"I brought all the blankets in here, but if you want to sleep in your own room, we can take some of them over to that one," Zach said, gesturing to the room across the hall.

Parley looked pensive for a moment before he spoke. "No, I think it'll be better if we're in the same room."

Zach didn't ask why, he just nodded.

"Are those towels?" Parley asked, stepping toward the closet. Zach held up his lantern so Parley could get a better view. "Do you think the shower works?"

"I dunno," Zach replied. "We could try it."

They walked into the bathroom, and Parley bent down to turn on the taps. Muddy water poured from the faucet and, just as it had downstairs, turned clear within a few minutes.

Zach ran his hand under the stream. "No hot water," he said. He lifted his arm and sniffed his armpit. "Wow. Guess I'll be getting in anyway."

Zach smiled to himself. A cold shower was probably the best idea anyway before climbing into bed with Parley. He was so beautiful, and he just had no fucking idea. Zach wanted to show him how beautiful he thought Parley was, but he couldn't. Parley had always been weird about dating and sex. The few times Zach had tried to bring it up, Parley had gotten all awkward, stuttering and stammering as he tried to tell Zach he didn't date.

Zach had no definitive proof that Parley was into guys, but once or twice he'd caught Parley looking at him. *Really* looking at him. He'd averted his eyes almost immediately, but he wasn't quick enough for Zach not to notice the longing that seemed to be simmering just below the surface. It made Zach want to push the boundaries, to show Parley how good it could be. Not that Zach had a whole lot of a frame of reference. At least not with guys. He'd dated Trina Beauclaire for almost six months the previous year, but it hadn't worked out for obvious reasons. There just wasn't anything he found appealing about the softness of women. When he thought about what he wanted in a partner, hard lines and smooth muscles were what sprang to mind.

More specifically, Parley's hard lines and smooth muscles.

Zach had almost swallowed his tongue that afternoon, seeing Parley all hot and sweaty, his shirt off and his muscles straining as they pushed the car off the road. It had taken him a few beats to get his heart back under control and his mind functional again.

Thinking about it now, he was just as affected. He wanted to reach out and touch Parley, to strip his clothes off, piece by piece, and pull Parley into the shower with him. And then he remembered it was going to be a cold shower. Thank the goddamn lord it was going to be a cold one. They weren't even in bed yet, and Zach's mind was running away on all kinds of inappropriate tangents.

"You need one too?" Zach asked, tilting his head toward the bathtub.

"Yes, I probably should," Parley said.

"Is it all right if I go first? I'm pretty grimy."

"Of course. I'll set up the bed while I wait for my turn," Parley said.

Zach nodded and grabbed a towel, setting it down on the toilet lid as Parley walked out, shutting the door behind him.

ZACH HAD retrieved their bags from the car while Parley was showering, and had set them out on the ottoman in the corner. He was just fluffing up his pillow when Parley walked back into the bedroom, the droplets of water still clinging to his hair. He was wearing the same clothes he'd worn earlier.

“You shower in your clothes, man?”

“Uh... no. I just didn’t have my pajamas to change into,” Parley said.

“Oh.” Zach realized Parley was much more modest than he’d ever thought. Zach had waltzed into the bedroom in nothing but his towel after his shower, not thinking anything of it.

“Your bag is over there,” Zach said, pointing.

“Thank you,” Parley said, walking over and unzipping it. He pulled back the flap and Zach could see the piles of meticulously folded clothes, the opposite of his own chaotic packing.

Parley pulled a pair of pajama pants and a T-shirt from his bag and laid them on the corner of the bed. He turned toward Zach and looked at him expectantly.

“What?” Zach asked. “Oh! Sorry,” he said, turning his back so Parley could get changed. He waited until he heard Parley clear his throat before he turned back around.

“Do you mind if... well, I just want to say my evening prayers.” Parley’s eyes were trained firmly on the floor.

“Oh! Sure, no problem,” Zach said. He sat on the edge of the bed, keeping his back turned, giving Parley at least the pretense of privacy, but Parley’s praying seemed to be silent. After several long minutes, Zach found himself zoning out and listening to the small sounds of the house, the infinitesimal creaks and groans of a building settling with age.

“I’ve finished,” Parley said, startling Zach from his reverie.

“Right. Well, let’s get some sleep.”

They both climbed into bed, keeping to their own sides, a vast space between them as Zach pulled the covers up over them. Zach wanted to reach out and touch Parley, to pull him into his arms and hold him close, as though that contact, and those touches, would erase the pain and trauma that Parley had spoken of earlier.

There in the dark, amid the quiet sounds of the house settling, Zach’s mind raced with the possibilities of what Parley had been subjected to. His heart ached for his friend. He listened to Parley’s breathing, slow and even as he drifted off, but it was a long time before Zach was able to fall asleep.

ZACH SQUINTED his eyes against the light pouring in through the dirty windows. It hadn't been the light that had woken him, though.

"What's that noise?" Parley asked, his voice rough with sleep.

"I dunno," Zach said, swinging his legs over the side of the bed and standing. He walked over to the window and peered through. "Airplanes."

"Really? It's louder than I've heard before."

"There's a bunch of them. And they're flying really low." Realization dawned on Zach. "I bet it's the air show. We could probably see from the yard. Do you want to go watch?"

"Yes, please."

Zach could feel the excitement building in his chest. His uncle had taken him to the air show when he was a kid. He'd gorged himself on cotton candy and dreamed of one day becoming a fighter pilot. The jets that created those precise formations were the coolest thing he'd ever seen in his whole eight and a half years. He hadn't been since then, but the memory of it was vivid in his mind.

The boys raced downstairs, a blanket draped over Zach's arm, and out into the backyard. The morning was beautiful, warm but not too hot, and the sky was cloudless. The perfect day for plane watching.

Zach spread the blanket out on the grass, pulling the edges so there were no lumps. Parley sat down, and Zach followed suit, lying down and putting one hand behind his head. They could hear the music from the air show quietly off in the distance, but the planes were in full view.

First up, they watched as two biplanes took off, dipping and gliding next to each other. They circled the sky, and they looked like they were dancing together. One flew faster, then the other, as they swapped positions and banked in perfect synchronization.

Next was the fighter jet that performed the daredevil stunts, flying vertically into the air, and then shifting into flips and corkscrews. Zach's stomach jumped just imagining what it would feel like to be sitting in the cockpit of that plane.

"I used to want to do that," Zach said.

"Fly?"

"Yeah. When I was a kid, I watched *Top Gun* at Jeff Cohen's house. When I saw Tom Cruise with his leather jacket and aviator sunglasses

defying gravity and not taking shit from anyone, I wanted to be a pilot more than anything.”

“You don’t anymore?”

“Nope. That summer we flew to see my Aunt Linda in Calgary. The sheer terror I felt when the wheels left the runway dashed all my hopes of flying professionally.”

“I truly believe you could do it if you wanted to. I think you’re capable of anything you set your mind to.”

Zach flushed with pride at Parley’s words. Of all the people on earth, his opinion was the one that meant the most to Zach. It didn’t matter that he was wrong. The fact that he believed it made all the difference to Zach.

“Nah, I gave up on that pretty much right away. It wasn’t what I was meant to be doing.”

“What are you meant to be doing?”

“This,” Zach said. “Exactly what I’m doing at this very moment.”

“Watching the air show?”

“No, escaping from my life and forging my own path. I want to make my own way in the world, to make my own decisions and become my own person.”

The Snowbirds took to the sky then. This was the part that Zach remembered. Nine jets flown by pilots of the Royal Canadian Armed Forces executed a variety of different formations before branching off and performing a series of tricks. Two of them flew in a barrel roll, their cockpits mirroring one another. Then five of them flew directly at one another, missing the other planes by what looked like inches before flying off in all directions.

The boys lay there, rapt with attention at the spectacle in the sky. Zach thought to himself that he’d never been happier. Miles away from his family, his obligations, and the goddamn expectations, he was lying next to his best friend, basking in the sun. His chest swelled with it. There was only one thing that could possibly have made that moment any better. He wished he could find some way to tell Parley how he felt. He wanted so badly to spill his guts all over the lawn. If Parley felt the same way... well, that would be fulfillment of every fantasy he’d had since meeting him.

Zach stretched his hands out against the blanket, his pinkie finger brushing up against Parley’s. His stomach flipped with that brief contact,

and then somersaulted when he felt the gentle brush in return. That simple touch was everything.

CHAPTER SEVEN

DAWN WAS staining the sky pink and purple when Parley awoke the next morning. He stretched slowly, savoring the pleasure of muscles relaxing. He sat up, stifling a yawn, and looked over at Zach.

Zach lay curled into a neat ball, his hands beneath his cheek, his eyelashes ghosting over his skin. His breathing was regular and even, and his dark hair was mussed and standing on end, reminding Parley of his baby sister. The pang he felt in his heart as Emma entered his mind was sharp, and Parley took a deep breath. Emma would forgive him. She had to. His whole family would forgive him. They'd understand. After all, hadn't they done a similar thing when they'd left the compound where he'd grown up and come to Vancouver?

Parley shook his head and pushed those thoughts away. He looked at Zach again and smiled. For several long, silent moments, he watched Zach sleep. How could this be wrong? He cared about Zach, loved him, and yet so many ministers and brethren preached that such feelings were immoral or unworthy, a sin punishable by God. Parley had read all the scriptures of his church, forward and even backward, several times, and he'd never been able to find a passage that told him his emotions were evil and would damn him. Oh, there were the verses about sodomy and the oftentimes hysterical ranting that accompanied their recitation from the pulpit that would occur on infrequent Sundays. But Parley by and large did not believe that love was a sin, and he didn't believe that when Jesus had said, "Love one another as I have loved you," he'd added a disclaimer about who should be exempt from love.

He took a great deal of comfort in that.

The light coming through the threadbare curtains grew brighter, and Parley slipped quietly out of bed and gathered up some clean clothes. He went into the bathroom, had a quick—and very cold—shower, and, shivering, his teeth chattering as he stepped out, dried himself off rapidly.

He tugged on his clean clothes and felt enormously daring for not putting on a tie with his shirt.

Back in the bedroom, Parley saw that Zach was still asleep, but he'd rolled over and stretched out, his arms now around Parley's pillow. Parley found that hugely endearing, and he watched Zach again for several moments, before he shook himself out of his reverie. He didn't want to be caught watching Zach sleep; his friend might take it the wrong way. So Parley quietly moved around the room and gathered up their dirty clothes, then stuffed his feet into his shoes and left the room, closing the door behind him.

He always felt good about himself when he did his chores, and here, just like back home with his family, those chores were simple. He went into the laundry room and filled the sink up with water, whistling to himself as he worked. Once the sink was full, he put their clothing into it, pushing down on the fabric to make sure everything was fully soaked. Then he went back into the kitchen to see about breakfast and find soap.

The pantry once again provided, and Parley wondered about the people who had left this place behind. He found a dusty box of Ivory brand soap, and that was more than good enough to wash the laundry with. In the far corner of the pantry, he found packets of instant oatmeal. There wasn't any milk, but water would work well enough. It probably wouldn't be a tasty meal, but it would be filling, and that was what was important. Checking the expiry dates on the oatmeal box, Parley was satisfied with what he saw.

He got to work on breakfast, this time humming as he worked. While the oatmeal bubbled away in its pot set over the small fire he had laid in the metal bucket, he cut down one of the bars of soap into slivers. When the oatmeal was cooked, he took the pot off the heat and set it on the side of the kitchen sink, then took the shaved pieces of soap into the laundry and stirred them into the washing. The shaved fragments dissolved quickly, and soon the water was full of bubbles and had taken on a milky color. Pleased, Parley left everything to soak some more and returned to the kitchen.

Parley went back into the pantry to see if there was anything resembling sugar—and coffee. He didn't drink it himself, but he knew Zach did, and he thought if he could find a jar of something, then Zach

would be able to have a cup of coffee with his oatmeal. It took him a little while, and in his searching, he found quite a few other items of interest, including a mop, a bottle of detergent, and a jar of honey that had never been opened and was still good to use. There was a bag of brown sugar, too, unopened but as hard as a brick, so Parley set that aside and grabbed the honey. He found boxes of tea bags and some old cookbooks, and then, finally, when he'd despaired of finding anything resembling coffee, there it was. A full jar of the stuff, dark brown granules that looked to him like dirt. No, he'd never understand the lure of it, not at all.

He took the honey, coffee, mop, and detergent back out into the kitchen, then rummaged around for bowls and spoons. His mind wandered as he washed everything as best he could, and he found himself thinking about one of the first Sunday school classes he'd gone to when he and his family had made their home in Vancouver. The Sunday school teacher, a kindhearted man named Laurie, had taught that they must all adhere to the laws of the land and keep the sacrament as well. Laurie had said it was easy to think they were above everyone else because of their faith, but that was wrong and smacked of pride, and pride was not a positive emotion. He had said it was important to live in the world and be in the world, but it was just as important to live a clean and good life while doing so, and it was not as difficult to do that as some might think. It had been a good lesson, and Parley had warmed to Laurie quickly, to his kindness and his good nature when he answered questions.

Parley dished up the oatmeal into two bowls and poured honey onto both servings. Then he went outside and sat on the stoop, eating his breakfast and thinking. Laurie had also taught that often people believed that thinking something sinful was just as bad as acting in a sinful manner, but that wasn't the case. "Action," Laurie had said, "is what leads us to sin. If we think about something long enough, let ourselves dwell on it, it becomes a fixation, and so we have to move beyond thinking and inaction into action. It's difficult to move away from something if we cross that line. Thinking about it won't get you into trouble; acting on it will. Things like theft, murder, lying to save yourself—these are bad and selfish things to do. Thinking about them before deciding whether or not to do them is your safety net. While you're thinking, you can seek counsel from someone else,

and that counsel—and the determination of right or wrong—can save you from committing a sinful and potentially illegal act. Never be afraid of your thoughts and never be afraid to seek advice because of those thoughts. No one is perfect here on earth. Jesus died for our sins, but that doesn't give us carte blanche to behave in a sinful way.”

Parley thought about that for a while as he ate and looked over the long, dry grass that seemed to stretch forever. Now that it was light and he wasn't rushed, he could see more of the property. The outbuildings around the house were dilapidated, but he imagined that with a bit of hard work, they could be salvaged, just like the house itself. And then, as they always did, his thoughts turned to Zach, and he wondered what Laurie would make of his feelings for his friend, and what Zach, in turn, would make of Laurie.

He'd said too much before; he knew he had. It had just slipped out, that revelation of part of his former life, living with his family in the compound. And why had he used the term “community” instead of compound? It wasn't a community at all, at least not in the way that Parley understood the word. It had been a place of fear and orders, where you had to obey the often contradictory and cruel dictates of the leader, and everyone lived in terror of what would happen to them. The catalyst for leaving, the scene at the giant tree, had been horrible and he knew he'd never forget it, but Parley also knew it had been the best thing to happen to them. It had gotten them out. Mom and Dad had talked in hushed tones about leaving for years. He could remember their conversations, hearing them whisper when they thought he and his brothers were asleep. He wished the violence and pain hadn't happened, but he was glad that it had spurred his parents to action and gotten them out and to safety.

Vancouver had been an eye-opener. Parley had never seen a city, let alone one as large as this one. It appeared to go on forever, buildings and people and trees and parks and, and, and. It had seemed like some amazing dreamscape as they'd traveled along, and everyone had been silent, made mute by the wonder of such a large populated place.

Parley wasn't sure how they'd come to live in the house that was now the family home or who his parents knew that had helped them, but he silently thanked those unknown people for their kindness and generosity now as he stood up and took his empty bowl into the kitchen.

Zach was still asleep, and Parley didn't want to wake him. They'd had a late night, and something about the country air always seemed to make a person sleep better and longer. So he left the coffee jar and the bowl of cooling oatmeal beside the sink, and went into the laundry to finish washing their clothes. Parley could see a washing line just outside the laundry room, its wires twisted and forming strange patterns. He pondered how to hang out their wet clothes and remembered a little trick his mother had taught him. Once he'd wrung out everything after rinsing them clean, Parley carried it all out to the line and began to hang things up. The sleeves of his shirts and Zach's T-shirts were twisted twice around the line as a means of holding them in place, and he used the weight of the wet towels to keep them hanging. He hoped that there wouldn't be any strong wind that day; it would be good to have everything dry quickly in the sun.

That done, he went back inside and quietly bounced up the stairs to the room he shared with Zach. Zach was awake now, looking bleary-eyed, and he yawned and waved as Parley entered.

"There's breakfast downstairs," Parley said with a smile. "And I found you a jar of coffee."

Zach's entire face lit up. "Coffee? Really? You found me coffee? You're my hero, Par."

Parley laughed, even though he felt himself grow warm from the praise. "There's no milk or cream, though."

Zach waved that off. "That's okay. I'll live."

"I did find sugar, but you'll probably need to use a knife to cut a bit off. It'll dissolve quickly in the coffee, though. Or there's honey."

"Yeah? That's awesome."

"I did the laundry too."

"Jesus, Parley, you're amazing."

Parley shrugged and smiled. "Not really. I just wanted to get those small chores done."

"What are you going to do now, then?"

"Brush my teeth, then go outside and start to work on the car, see if I can't fix it enough that we can get into a town or something and get a proper mechanic to take a look."

“Oh.” Zach ran a hand through his hair, making it even more mussed. Parley found that adorable. “Well, I’ll keep you company while you’re being a mechanic.”

“Okay.” Parley gave him another smile and then went into the bathroom and brushed his teeth. That done, he retraced his steps and went back outside and over to where the car was.

It wasn’t long before Zach joined him. Parley nodded to him as Zach sat down on the ground and pushed his sunglasses up his nose. Those were probably not a bad idea, Parley thought—the sun really was bright today.

“So where did you guys live before?” Zach asked.

Parley tensed at the question, then silently berated himself for reacting that way. He’d opened this door in the first place by telling Zach things he’d never meant to reveal to anyone. It was a few moments before he answered, and he hid behind the pretense of working on a particularly stubborn spark plug.

“East,” he said finally.

“You don’t want to say, huh?”

“Not really, if that’s all right.”

“Sure. It’s cool.”

Parley sneaked a quick look at his friend and saw that Zach was leaning back on one hand, and his hair was being ruffled by a light breeze. He was so handsome, Parley thought, then felt guilty for thinking such things. And then he was angry at himself, angry for feeling guilty, because he hadn’t acted on his thoughts, and love wasn’t a sin.

“It was in the woods,” Parley said. “There was a group of houses and barns, and we grew our own food, had some cows, chickens, ducks, that sort of thing. A lake was nearby, and one of the other men in the community had worked out how to pump the water from the lake to the main houses. We had a wood stove and used candles. There was no electricity. We had a windmill and a generator behind the main house, where the leader lived, but that was only for him and his family, and for when we needed to charge up car batteries, stuff like that.”

“It sounded nice until you got to the ‘no electricity’ part,” Zach said.

“Yeah, it was pretty. But it was lonely too. There weren’t many of us, really. Not like Vancouver.”

“I bet that was a shock when you saw it for the first time.”

Parley laughed. "Oh yeah. We had no idea people could live in such a huge place. And the house we ended up in had more things than we knew what to do with. It took us ages to figure out the microwave."

"Didn't your parents know what one was?"

"No. Dad was born in the... community. Mom came from a similar one but in Arizona."

"Huh."

"I know it sounds weird."

"A bit, but then to you, SpaghettiO's are weird."

Parley burst out laughing at that. "That's very true."

"So did you ever date anyone while you were there, in the woods?"

Parley snorted, amused at the question. "No. No way. Dating wasn't allowed. See, there were arranged marriages when kids hit eighteen, but that was it. And then when we came here, Heber and Reed were allowed to date, because they were seventeen, but the rules were still quite strict. No touching the young woman you're taking on a date, but you must open doors for her, which is just common courtesy, and then at the end of the date, you walk her to her front door, but there's no kiss good night or anything. You shake hands. Oh, and she has to be home by ten o'clock. Some parents say eleven, but it's usually ten. Except in group dates, you can be home by eleven thirty."

"That... is really, really weird," Zach said.

"So I understand." Parley paused to clean part of the engine. "But to us," he said after several moments, "it was unprecedented freedom."

"So your old home was really restrictive?"

"Yes."

Zach must have heard the tension in Parley's voice, because he changed the subject. Parley was indescribably relieved. He didn't really want to talk any more about his former home. Not yet, anyway.

"What did you want to do with your life before you came here, then?"

"I wanted to be a missionary and go to somewhere like Chad or Nigeria, preach to the people there, and help them with things like building new houses, repairing their cars, that sort of thing. There are a few missions that do that sort of work in quite a few African countries, so that was what I wanted to do with my life. Heber wanted to be a doctor; he

still does. Reed wants to be a journalist, and Parker hasn't made a decision yet."

"You figured you wanted to do that when you were what, thirteen?" Zach sounded incredulous.

"Yep. Religion was all I knew, remember."

"I don't want to offend you, but... that sounds a bit boring."

"I suppose. But I like studying and I like reading, so it didn't bother me. And there are some Bible stories and stories in the scriptures that I really like."

"Oh yeah?" Zach sounded skeptical now, and Parley chuckled to himself.

"You probably know the ones about Noah or Jesus or the Creation story."

"Yeah, I've heard them."

"Okay, so do you know the one about King David and Jonathan?"

"No. The King David I know of was the guy who beat Goliath."

"That's the same one. See, he had this really close friend named Jonathan. Jonathan was also his closest advisor and his most trusted confidant. They were closer than brothers, the Bible says. They met at the moment David was holding Goliath's head, after he killed him, and they took an instant liking to each other. Their relationship was one of the closest in the Bible. There's a quote from the first book of Samuel, chapter 20, verses 41 and 42, which says, 'And as soon as the lad was gone, David arose out of a place toward the South, and fell on his face to the ground, and bowed down three times; and they kissed one another, and wept one with another, but David wept the most.'

"And Jonathan said to David: 'Go in peace, forasmuch as we have sworn both of us in the name of the Lord, saying: The Lord shall be between me and thee, and between my seed and thy seed, forever.'"

Zach made a strange noise, and Parley looked over at him in concern.

"Dude," Zach said, "are you telling me that King David who killed Goliath was in a gay relationship with his best friend?"

Parley gaped at him. He'd never considered that interpretation before; he just knew that he liked the story of the friendship between the two men in the Bible very much. But Zach didn't know the story at all. He

hadn't been taught in Sunday school or raised in a tight-knit religious compound, and for him to see what Parley hadn't.... Parley was speechless.

"I mean, I don't want to insult you or anything—"

"You haven't." Parley found his voice. "I had never considered that as a possibility." He quickly ran through the story in his mind, with Zach's words thundering in his head. "I... I think you might be right."

"Dude, that's awesome! I mean, it shows that people in the Bible were gay, and David—he's like one of the biggest heroes in there, isn't he?"

"He is, yes." Parley was still struggling with it. Oh, he wanted to believe this so very much, but he couldn't quite bring himself to do so. But Zach's enthusiasm was contagious, and the more he thought about it, the more that Parley realized that he believed Zach was absolutely, 100 percent right. Wisdom did come from unexpected places after all.

Suddenly, the world seemed lighter, brighter, more colorful. A great many of Parley's worries fell away as he realized that his own struggles with his emotions were not so different from those of people in the scriptures that he admired greatly. He felt buoyed by the realization, almost ecstatic.

"How's the car?"

Zach's voice, and his question about practical matters, brought Parley back down to earth. Parley didn't mind, though. It was his friend, whom he loved as Jonathan had loved David, who was asking.

"Not too bad."

"Great!" Zach said, his voice sounding a bit strange. "Do you think we could get to the nearest town in it now?"

"I think so, yes." Parley felt invincible now. He was not dirty, he was not disgusting, and he was not evil or sinful. Zach had seen more clearly than Parley himself, and Parley was grateful. He knew he always would be. Nothing could possibly go wrong now, Parley thought. Nothing at all.

CHAPTER EIGHT

ZACH WATCHED as Parley, with his sleeves rolled up, tinkered under the hood of his lemon of a car. The feelings that churned through him were mixed. He loved the way Parley looked when he was concentrating hard, his eyebrows knit together and his tongue peeking out along his lower lip. It was adorable.

Zach hadn't realized how hot it would be to watch Parley fixing cars. Masculinity emanated from him, and he had absolutely no conception of how much it turned Zach on.

But the part of him that didn't want to run his hands underneath Parley's shirt, to feel the muscles bunching as he worked—that small part of him wished Parley would stop. Fixing his car meant that they would be leaving this place, and Zach couldn't think of anything he wanted less.

They'd only spent two nights in the house, but there was something about it that felt so right, Zach questioned ever leaving again. He knew logistically that wasn't a possibility. They'd at least have to go out for food and supplies if they ever hoped to survive, but this house felt safe. It felt like theirs, and Zach was reluctant to risk piercing that bubble of security.

There was something so domestic about being in the house with Parley, something that spoke so deeply to Zach. He couldn't put his finger on it, but he liked it and he never wanted to let go of that feeling.

"Give it a try," Parley said, wiping the grease from his hands on a rag.

Zach ducked inside the car, pushing his foot onto the brake pedal and turning the key in the ignition. It sputtered a few times before it started up, the grumble of the engine rough, but working.

The expression on Parley's face was one of a very satisfied, even proud, man. Zach jumped from the car, grabbing Parley in a bear hug and swinging him around in a circle. "You're the master," Zach said. As he put Parley back

down, he realized his error. He'd hugged Parley before, many times. But he'd never hugged him after spending two nights in the same bed together, after spending the morning watching the sky with him, and after that simple brush of their fingers.

Suddenly the innocent touches they'd shared before now seemed so much more meaningful. The feeling of Parley's body against his made Zach feel too warm, and like his skin was too small. He took a deep breath, willing his body's reaction to recede, and let go. Zach couldn't decipher the look on Parley's face when he backed away.

"Should we go get some supplies?" Zach asked. "That is, if you wanted to stay here? Or... we could find somewhere else? Get in the car and just drive...." Zach knew which he wanted, but hearing Parley's preference was important to him. Parley had a tendency to do as he was told, never really speaking up about his own desires. Zach wanted them to be partners, equal participants in their adventure—and in their friendship—and if that meant eliciting input from his friend from time to time, that's what he would do.

"I like it here," Parley said. "Very much."

Zach beamed. "Me too. Okay, let's see if we can find a grocery store nearby, grab what we need, and come back. We can just relax here, spend some time, and then make a plan a bit later on."

"That sounds good to me."

"I found a map in that junk yesterday. I stashed it with our stuff in case we ventured out today. Let me run and grab it." Zach dashed into the house, bounded up the stairs, and grabbed his phone and the map from where he'd left it in his bag. He glanced back at the bed where they had slept the previous two nights. For a brief moment, he let himself imagine what it would be like to really live with Parley in a forever kind of way. Maybe they could get a dog or a guinea pig or something. They'd make dinner together every night and go to bed together, cuddling under the covers when it got cold out, keeping each other warm.

Zach blinked rapidly, pulling himself out of his daydream. It did no good to imagine things that might never come to be. All he could do was appreciate the time he had with his best friend now, and worry about the rest later. Maybe things would come together for them, but they were young and there was lots of time to see how everything played out.

He powered up the phone, happy to see the bar was low, but still in the white zone. When he got back outside, Parley was already sitting in the car, ready to go. Zach piled in beside him, unfolding the map and studying it closely. They figured there had to be civilization within a few kilometers of the house, so they took off, Zach naming Parley the official navigator and hoping against hope the car would hold out long enough to get them there and back.

THEY FOUND the store with limited difficulty only a few minutes down the road, and it happened to be in the same shopping complex as a hardware store. After parking the car, Zach pulled his wallet out and counted the remaining bills. Parley did the same and together they had just over \$135. That would be more than enough money to last them at least the month if they were very careful.

They both climbed out and walked shoulder to shoulder into the store. Zach's mind slipped back to where it had been earlier that day, the place where they were together, doing their Sunday afternoon shopping together. Parley grabbed one of the plastic baskets from near the front door and they started in the produce section.

"What should we get?" Zach asked.

"Things that don't need to be cooked or things we're able to cook over a fire," Parley replied.

"See? That's why you're the brains of this operation."

Parley laughed. "I am not. You're the one who came up with this whole plan. We wouldn't be here if it wasn't for you. I'd still be at home with my parents."

"Yeah, and so would I. Isn't that an awful thought? I'd be sitting at the table, eating tuna casserole with extra peas, listening to my dad berate me for being who I am. No thank you. I'd rather eat expired cans of beans and be on my own than have to listen to that any day of the week. How about some tomatoes?" Zach asked, changing the subject.

"Yes please," Parley said, choosing a few and placing them in the basket. "We can make some fried tomatoes with our breakfasts, and they'd be good in sandwiches too."

"Definitely. We'll have to get some bread."

"It's a shame we don't have a working oven. I could have baked bread."

"You know how to bake bread?" Zach asked, incredulous.

Parley just shrugged and kept walking.

They wandered around the store, picking up items they thought they could use back at the house. Parley kept a running tally of the cost in his head so they wouldn't spend too much on the first trip. They took their items to the front of the store, lining up at the end to wait their turn.

"Oh my god," whispered Zach. "Is that Mrs. Anderson?"

"Where?" Parley asked, looking around frantically.

"Don't look," Zach ordered, shuffling Parley in front of him so their backs faced the store. "She probably won't recognize us. Let's just get out of here. Quickly."

Parley nodded his understanding and started emptying the basket onto the conveyor belt. He kept his head down the entire time. Zach crowded in behind him, smiling at the cashier, trying to look like he wasn't about to shit his pants for nearly getting busted.

The cashier rang up their items, and Zach handed over the money while Parley grabbed the bags. Once the girl gave them their receipt, they rushed out the door and threw the groceries into the trunk before climbing back into the car. Zach's heart was racing and Parley looked like a cat in headlights—skittish and ready to bolt.

"Do we dare go into the hardware store for coolant?" Parley asked.

Zach peered through the windshield, looking for Mrs. Anderson. He didn't see her, but that was worse. She could be anywhere. He took a calming breath.

"Maybe we're getting ahead of ourselves. Likely Mrs. Anderson doesn't know what we did. She'd probably just wave at us and keep walking."

"Perhaps."

"Why don't you stay here, and I'll quickly run in and grab what we need. Just tell me what I'm looking for."

"No, I'll go," Parley said. "I know what we need."

Zach nodded and handed Parley the cash, glancing side to side one more time for Mrs. Anderson. Satisfied she was nowhere to be seen, Parley got back out of the car and hurried into the hardware store.

Zach watched him go, feeling distinctly on edge the farther away Parley got. They were in this together, and Zach felt the loss of his friend, even though he was just running inside the store. He tapped his foot on the carpeted floor of the car, impatient for Parley to return. He would feel so much better when they were back at the house, locked up together, just the two of them.

The longer Parley was gone, the faster Zach's heart pounded. He took a breath in, his lungs filling impossibly, as he had forgotten to release the last breath he took. Finally, he spotted Parley crossing the parking lot carrying a gray plastic jug. Relief swamped Zach, and he turned the key in the ignition, mentally crossing his fingers that the car would start and they could get out of there.

The familiar rattling sound gave way to the rumble of the engine just as Parley ducked into the car, slamming his door behind him.

"You made it," Zach gushed.

"I made it," Parley affirmed. "Now let's get out of here."

"You got it!" Zach threw the car into gear and steered them out of the parking lot toward the house he had begun to think of as home. The boys were quiet along the way, Parley presumably taking in the scenery while Zach was deep in thought.

Since he'd met his friend, the two had grown closer and closer, but the last two days had cemented how Zach felt about him. Before now, he had hesitated to put a label on it, not wanting to think about it in concrete terms. But now, after the close call with their teacher, and the thought of being separated from his best friend, Zach knew beyond any doubt that he was firmly, deeply, and irrevocably in love with Parley.

He felt like his heart was going to come bursting through his throat if he didn't tell him. It was a risky move, but the dam had broken and there was little Zach could do to hold back his feelings. He bit his lower lip, the sharp sting of his teeth keeping him in check. He had resolved to tell Parley how he felt, but telling someone you love them for the first time wasn't a discussion that was best had in a moving car.

THEY PULLED into the driveway, Zach maneuvering the car back into the hiding spot they'd put it in before. Once he parked, Parley ran around the

back to grab the groceries from the trunk while Zach carried the jug of coolant. He placed it down on the back porch, then followed Parley into the kitchen to help him put away the groceries. They hadn't bought anything that needed to be refrigerated, so finding spaces for their purchases was quick work: everything went into the pantry.

Halfway through emptying the contents of the plastic bags onto the shelves of the pantry, Zach couldn't wait any longer. He felt like he'd been carrying the secret his whole life, and it wouldn't stay buried a moment longer. His pulse was racing and his palms were sweaty. When he'd decided to tell Parley how he felt, he hadn't realized how difficult it would be to form the words in his head, let alone out loud.

"Parley..." he started, stumbling over his friend's name.

Parley placed the tin of vegetable soup in his hand on the shelf and turned to face Zach, his eyebrows dipping in the center, his expression concerned. "What is it?"

"I need to tell you something... something I probably should have told you a long time ago."

Parley was quiet, his eyes trained on Zach, completely focused.

"You know you're my best friend, right?"

Parley nodded slowly.

"And you know how much I love you. I love you more than anyone else. You know that, right?"

"Of course."

"But I've never told you how... I mean... shit. I'm fucking this all up." Zach stared at the ground, trying to gather his thoughts. His emotions had swirled his words all around until he couldn't make heads or tails of what he wanted to say.

Parley placed his hand on Zach's arm. Zach looked up, locking their gazes. He took a step forward, wanting to know how Parley would react to him being so close. Mere inches separated them.

"Parley, I... Do you trust me?" Zach's voice broke.

"More than anyone," Parley said, the sound low and rough.

Zach reached forward, taking Parley's hands in his and linking their fingers together, palm to palm. He stepped toward him, nearly eliminating the space between them. His heart was pounding harder than it had before.

He didn't think he'd ever been this nervous. The next moment would be life altering one way or another.

Zach watched as Parley's eyes drifted shut, and in that moment, he knew he was going to go through with it. Kissing his best friend had been something he had wanted almost as long as he'd known him. He hadn't thought he'd ever get that chance, but here, in the quiet kitchen of their house, he was going to kiss a boy—the boy he was in love with—for the first time. Moving slowly, he brushed his lips against his friend's, just a whisper of contact.

A sudden loud banging caused both the boys to jump backward.

"RCMP. Open up," came the loud voice from the front door.

"Oh shit," Zach cursed pacing quickly back and forth across the small room. "What do we do?"

"I think we have to answer the door," Parley replied, his voice shaking.

"Goddamn it!" Zach swore again, walking toward the door like a man on death row.

He pulled it open, blinking twice at the bright sunlight that poured in from outside.

"Zachary Mayes and Parley Young?" the officer asked.

Parley nodded, but didn't speak.

"You'll need to come with me. Your parents have filed missing persons' reports for you both. I'll be taking you back to the station."

"How did you find us?" Zach asked, standing his ground.

"An anonymous tip was called in a few minutes ago. We'd already gathered the information on the make, model, and license plate number of the car you purchased. It wasn't difficult."

Zach's heart fell. Mrs. Anderson. "We've graduated. We don't need our parent's permission to leave home," Zach said.

"Well, that may be true for you, but Mr. Young is still a minor, and as such, his parents are responsible for him. If that were the only issue here, I'd be putting him in my cruiser and letting you go on your merry way, but I'm going to hazard a guess that you do not own this house, and I highly doubt you have permission to be here. So until we find the owners and figure out if they want to press charges for breaking and

entering, I suggest you do as I ask and come with me back to the station, or I will have to place you under arrest.”

Zach looked over at Parley, whose eyes had widened almost impossibly. Zach couldn't fathom what must have been running through his head at that moment. It was Zach's fault they were in this mess, and he hoped to hell Parley would forgive him one day. If it hadn't been for him, he never would have run away. He never would have been escorted down the front steps of a house they'd broken into and put in the back of a police car like some thug. And Zach could only imagine how Parley felt about their almost-kiss.

He'd gone from being the perfectly well-behaved, pious child to a rebellious, debauched heathen. And it was all because of Zach.

The police officer held the back door of the cruiser open for them as they climbed inside, Parley scooting all the way over to make room for Zach. At least they weren't in handcuffs, but guilt swamped him. The cop slammed the door once they were inside and climbed into the driver's seat, started the engine, and pulled out of the driveway, aiming them back toward Vancouver.

Tears pricked the backs of Zach's eyes as he watched their house and his perfect fantasy life fade away into the distance. He kept quiet, afraid of what Parley thought of him. He let his head fall forward and closed his eyes, trying to keep the overwhelming emotions in check.

The sensation of Parley's hand wrapping around his had Zach looking up.

“Once we get this all sorted out, you can go back. You don't have to stay. You're eighteen. They can't keep you,” Parley whispered.

Zach looked back at him. Never more sure of anything in his life, he said, “I'm not leaving you.”

Of course, life wasn't that simple.

CHAPTER NINE

THE DRIVE seemed to go on forever, and with every mile, Parley's inner turmoil grew. At first, it hadn't seemed real—to be collected by the police in such a way felt as if his life had suddenly become like one of those Hollywood movies his father had prohibited them from watching. But sitting beside Zach, clinging to his hand, made it very real.

Zach. Parley swallowed convulsively against the lump that rose in his throat. While his friend hadn't said the words, Parley wasn't stupid. He knew what Zach was getting to, and he had welcomed it, wanted it. To be so rudely interrupted... well, if it had happened to one of his brothers, Parley would have laughed long and loud and then teased them about it forever. Now that it was him, Parley wasn't sure it was funny at all.

Zach felt the same way about him as Parley felt about Zach. That was a prayer he had never dared to hope would be answered. It proved to him too that God was not as judgmental as some of the members of his church would believe. God was love after all, and they were taught that God's love was all-encompassing. There were no exclusions to God's love. And if God had a problem with how Parley and Zach felt about each other, then, Parley felt, God would have struck him down on the spot, not sent the police to get him because his family was worried.

So that was one thing less to worry about. What was a deeper concern was that his parents might figure out a way to keep him from seeing Zach again, and that had to be avoided at all costs. He would be a legal adult soon, so he had to keep his head down and his thoughts to himself until his birthday. Then he could leave and find Zach and everything would be okay. All right, perhaps not perfect. His family would disown him and he'd probably be excommunicated for sins of perversion, but Parley thought—hoped—that his family, at least, would come around. They weren't bad people. They were good, kind,

compassionate people, and once they understood this wasn't a phase or a case of Zach being a bad influence, they would accept it.

ALL THOUGHTS Parley had entertained on that long drive to the police station vanished as soon as he saw who was waiting for him. It wasn't his father or his mother. It was his brother, Reed, and Reed's expression was grim. Parley bit his lip as he watched Reed watch him. He saw Reed's eyebrows shoot up almost to his hairline when he took in Zach and Parley holding hands. And his heart plummeted to his shoes when Reed's expression changed to one of severe disapproval and disdain.

Parley let go of Zach's hand and took a step toward his brother, but Reed turned away and began to talk to the police officers.

"It'll be okay," Zach said in an undertone. It was the first thing he'd said since the RCMP had pounded on the door back at the house.

Parley shrugged. "I have a bad feeling about this."

"What can they do? You'll be eighteen soon, right? So they can't do anything to you."

Parley turned his head and gave Zach a small, sad smile. He knew it was sad, because he could see his reflection on a broad mirror that was behind Zach, but he knew his family better than Zach did. They hadn't relocated to Vancouver, leaving everything they had ever known, on a whim. No, they'd done it for preservation, for family, for religion.

"They could move us to another part of Canada," Parley said. "Or to the US. Mom's family's there. We could end up moving in with them."

Zach frowned. "Well screw that. I'll find you, Par. Don't worry."

Parley wanted to laugh. It was so very like Zach to be his defender, his protector. It was noble, and it was touching. Despite his earlier thoughts, Parley was too used to reality being cruel, and to there being a price for a happily ever after. He didn't want to burst Zach's bubble, though, so he swallowed the laughter and nodded instead.

"Okay."

Reed came over to them then. He completely ignored Zach. "Parley, come on."

"Wait a moment," Zach said.

Reed took Parley's arm. "We don't have time for this."

“Yes, sir,” Parley said automatically. He looked at Zach one last time. “Bye, Zach.”

“But...”

Parley let Reed propel him out of the police station and toward the parking lot.

“Par,” Reed said, his voice soft and full of more compassion than Parley had hoped for, “I understand why you did what you did. So does Parker, and Heber too, I think. But Mom and Dad are super mad. So I’m telling you this now, before we get to the car. I don’t blame you. I don’t hate you. I love you; you’re my brother. I will fight to the death for your happiness and safety, but... Dad overrode me.”

“What are you saying?” Parley slowed his step as they walked.

“We had a big fight about this. I said that if you wanted to travel with your friend, then that was your right. After all, we’d moved to Vancouver to be free. Parker said it was better for you to experience life in the full and certain knowledge of our faith and with God walking beside you, and Heber said you’d taken your scriptures with you, which you wouldn’t do if you were going to turn away from God. But Mom and Dad—they wouldn’t hear it. Dad said you’d been corrupted, and Mom said it was a mistake to come here, that we should’ve gone and bought a farm or something and been homeschooled.

“Dad made some calls late at night. I don’t know who he called, because Mom guarded the landing so we couldn’t come downstairs. But they’ve arranged something and they won’t tell us what. So right now, before the yelling starts, I want you to know that whatever happens, your brothers and I love you, and even if it doesn’t look like it, we’ve got your back.”

Parley felt as if he couldn’t breathe. He took a deep breath, feeling his heart pounding in his temples. “What about Zach?”

“It’s probably best he doesn’t come round for a while. Dad wanted to go and give his parents a talking-to, but at least Mom convinced him that wasn’t a good idea. I think Dad would have been quite shocked if he’d been arrested for causing a disturbance or something.”

Parley managed a strangled sort of laugh. “I can imagine.”

“So, if they ask you how you feel about Zach, if it’s not... if it’s in a way the church doesn’t agree with, you lie. Lie until your tongue falls out, P2.”

The use of his nickname made Parley feel sick. The shock at being advised by his brother to lie was one thing, but coupled with the family endearment, Parley realized just how serious this was.

“I’m not sure that I can.”

“Try,” Reed said. “Try real hard.”

They’d reached the family car and Parley could see that his whole family was inside it. His father was stone faced, his hands gripping the steering wheel so hard that Parley could see the whites of his knuckles. His mom was weeping, and that made Parley feel guilt so strong that he momentarily felt nauseous. And then there were his brothers, Parker and Heber, and their expressions were like Reed’s—compassionate, sorrowful, and worried.

This, Parley realized, was going to be a whole new kind of hell, far worse than anything he’d ever experienced in his life. His limbs felt as heavy as lead as Reed opened the back door of the car and Parley climbed in, squashing beside his sister’s baby seat and the window. Emma, at least, smiled and giggled as she saw him, reaching out with one chubby hand to pat his hair.

As soon as Reed was in the car, their father started it and drove. The drive was silent, aside from Emma’s noises, and Parley felt the dread growing within him. He focused on the memory of that short time he’d had with Zach, how comfortable it had been, how relaxed he’d felt. He thought about Zach’s mussed hair as he slept, how Zach laughed, the color of his eyes, and the warmth of his smile. And most of all, he thought about how it felt to be so close to Zach, feeling his body against his and not feeling any shame or guilt.

The interminable ride ended, as all things must eventually, and Parley got out of the car with his family. He turned to get Emma out of her car seat, and he carried her into the house, holding her close. Her soft baby scent, the smell of baby powder and shampoo filled his nose, and her hands holding onto him made him feel a little better.

All of that shattered as he stood in the living room with his family. His mother took Emma from him, and Parley finally faced his father. His father’s expression was still stony, a grim visage that gave Parley no hope

for anything good to come out of this. Parley licked his lips, squared his shoulders, and faced his father, presenting a calm façade of quiet determination, though inwardly he felt as if he were made of butter and that his heart was going to leap out of his chest and run away.

“Parley,” his father said, and his voice was tight, as if he were keeping a grip on his temper with great difficulty, “your mother and I have discussed at length what should happen here, but as with all things, we sought counsel and revelation from prayer and discussion with church elders. So this is your opportunity to explain yourself. Why did you run away?”

“I didn’t run away, sir,” Parley said. He was astounded at how calm his voice sounded. “I decided to go with Zach on a road trip.”

“You didn’t tell us about this plan. You didn’t ask us. You lied,” said his mother.

“Because I knew you wouldn’t let me go. I’m nearly eighteen—”

“But you’re not yet, and so you’re still under our rules,” his father said curtly. “This boy, this... Zach, is it? He doesn’t share our beliefs.”

Parley held his tongue, out of the corner of his eye seeing Heber give him a tiny shake of his head. He knew what his brother’s gesture meant—say nothing. Lie, lie, lie.

“What is the relationship between you and this boy?”

“We’re friends,” Parley said.

“Good friends?” his father pressed.

“Yes, sir.”

“And while you were with this... good friend... where did you both sleep?”

Parley licked his lips. He could see Reed mouthing the word “Lie” to him, but he couldn’t. He’d never told a lie in his life, and now, when it seemed the most important time to do so, Parley found himself paralyzed. And so he told the truth.

“There was one bed, sir, so we... we shared it. It was chaste,” he added hastily. “We wore clothes and we didn’t touch one another.”

His mother erupted into hysterics, stumbling back to sit on the sofa, weeping loudly as she held Emma. Emma, feeling the tension in the air and seeing her mother crying, began to cry too, her tiny face screwed up as she reacted to the atmosphere in the room. Parley gulped as he looked at

them, wishing he could take Emma from his mother and cuddle her, calm her, make her smile.

“Is this boy a homosexual?” Parley’s father demanded.

“I... no, sir.”

“But you said you slept with him. So I ask you again. Is he a homosexual?”

“He’s had girlfriends....”

“So he is a bisexual?”

“I-I guess so.” Parley felt his mouth go dry, and his palms were sweating. He clenched and unclenched his hands.

“Where’s your tie?” his mother suddenly asked through her tears.

“In my bag, ma’am.”

“God preserve us!”

“So this boy, who enjoys the perverse pleasures of both girls and other boys, has begun to lead you down the dark path of temptation. He has encouraged you to lapse in your manner of dress, to seek a life of indolence and immorality, living together and sharing a bed. Oh, to sleep in, you say, yet I am certain that soon he would tempt you to commit all manner of immoral acts.”

“Dad...,” Reed began, “Zach’s not....”

“Be silent!” Parley’s father fixed Reed with a hard glare and Reed shut his mouth. “Parley,” his father said as he turned back to him, “we did not raise you to be so loose in your morals, to consort with depraved and evil beings. We have taught you to recognize all of Satan’s works and that sometimes, the temptations of evil appear in the most pleasant of forms.”

That made Parley suddenly furious. “Zach’s not evil or an agent of Satan. Zach’s my friend. My best friend. He gave a damn about me, he asked me my opinion of things, and he actually talked *to* me, not at me. He didn’t think of me as something to marry off to the nearest girl in our church with the biggest childbearing hips. He’s my friend,” Parley repeated, “and he loves me. And”—Parley took a deep breath, even as he saw all three of his brothers mouthing “No” at him—“I love him.”

The silence that met his statement was so absolute, Parley wondered for a moment if he’d suddenly gone deaf. And then his father erupted. Before Parley knew what was happening, he felt a sharp, stinging pain in his face, and he realized his father had slapped him. Hard.

Wide-eyed, Parley stared at his father. He'd never been hit by either of his parents before. His father's face was mottled red with fury, and his mouth was contorted in an expression of disgust and horror.

"Heber," his father said over his shoulder, "go and pack a bag for your brother. Make sure there are suits and ties in it as well as bathroom necessities and his scriptures."

"Yes, sir," Heber said in a small voice. He almost ran out of the room.

"Parker, go into the dining room. Take your mother and sister, and support them while your mother makes dinner."

"Yes, sir," Parker said. Like Heber, his voice was small. Parley watched as his brother went to their mother and sister and helped them up from the chair and out of the room.

"Reed, you will accompany your brother and me," their father said.

"Yes, sir." Reed hesitated a moment. "Where are we going?"

"We'll be home quite late. Get an apple or something before we leave. It's a long drive to Sunbeam Farm."

"Sunbeam Farm?" Reed asked. "The place where...."

"Yes, son. They cure people who think they're homosexual."

Parley gulped. This, of all the things he'd expected, had never occurred to him. "Father...."

"Not one word," his father said. "I am very disappointed in you, Parley. But you're my son, and I love you. I will do everything in my power to help you and save your immortal soul. Remember that while you're at Sunbeam Farm. We are your family and we love you, and we're doing this to help you."

Parley had no idea what to say. He couldn't move. He felt as if his feet were rooted to the ground.

He would never see Zach again. He couldn't even get a message to him. He was doomed.

For a moment, Parley wondered if he could ask Reed to get a message to Zach, but then he dismissed it. He wouldn't get his brother into trouble—he was in enough trouble for all of them. He just hoped that his brothers would keep in touch with him somehow, and most of all, he hoped that Zach would forgive him. As Heber returned, carrying a

BRICK BY BRICK

suitcase, Parley took it from him with fingers that felt numb, and let his father lead him from the living room, and then the house, to the car. This was most certainly the end of his life as he currently knew it.

Sixteen Years Later....

CHAPTER TEN

“TESSA, HAVE you seen my....” Zach looked up to see his assistant standing in front of him, his keys dangling from her perfectly manicured finger. “Never mind.”

He grabbed the keys from her and shoved them in his pocket.

“Don’t forget you have to be to the Murphys’ house by four,” she reminded him, picking up the travel mug of coffee from her desk and handing it to him.

“I won’t.”

“They’re expecting you, and Paige Murphy is not a woman you want to piss off by being late. She wants her entire vacation home done in your furniture, so don’t fuck this up.”

“All right, all right. Jesus. Who are you, my mother?” Zach said.

“I resent that, Zachary Mayes.” She thrust her hands on her hips and looked at him defiantly.

“Sorry, Tessa. You know I love you more than I love my own mother. What would I do without you?” He leaned forward and brushed a quick kiss to her cheek. “You’re the best assistant—and friend—a guy could ask for. Really.”

She folded her arms across her chest indignantly. “You better not forget it.”

“I would never.”

“And while you’re never forgetting things, Murphys’ house. Four o’clock.”

“I’ll remember.”

“That promise doesn’t exactly fill me with confidence,” she said, one eyebrow lifted. “You get into that house and you just get lost. I don’t understand why you choose to live in that cramped shithole of an apartment upstairs when you own a beautiful house in the country.”

Zach did the same thing he did every time Tessa asked him about the house. He lied. "It's not finished. I don't want to move in until everything's done."

"You've been working on it for almost ten years. At this rate, it'll never be done. You'll live upstairs forever, and your testicles will shrivel up and fall off your body from lack of use. And then I'll work for a eunuch."

"How do you know you don't already?" Zach teased, deflecting the topic of the house.

"Because I've seen a couple of your bar boys sneaking out of here in the mornings after I get in, and because you're not very subtle about... ahem... adjusting yourself."

Zach shrugged, refusing to give her the satisfaction of appearing embarrassed by her observations. "Fair enough. I'm heading out. Call me if you need me."

"You got it," Tessa said, giving him a little wave as he pushed the front door of his workshop open and stepped out into the sunlight.

"Come on, Winston," Zach said, patting his thigh and signaling for his English sheepdog to follow.

Zach opened the door to his truck, letting Winston jump in first and cross to the passenger's seat before he climbed in and slammed the door behind him. Taking a deep breath, he gripped the steering wheel tightly, wringing his hands forward and backward over the soft leather. He didn't like talking about his house. Tessa was one of the few people who even knew it existed. And even that had been accidental.

He'd been going over the plans for replacing the stairwell when she'd walked into his office with coffee. He'd tried to shrug it off at first, but Tessa was nothing if not stubborn, and eventually he'd caved, telling her he'd worked every shitty job he could find from the time he left home until he was able to afford to buy the house.

She'd asked why and he hadn't had an answer for her. Telling her about Parley would have felt like a betrayal of trust, or a marring of the memory of him. Zach couldn't bring himself to give her the real reason, so he made up a story about his father instilling the importance of investing early on in him.

She'd seemed to buy it, and every time the subject had been brought up since then, Zach did his best to sway the topic of conversation to something else.

"All right, bud, let's get going," he said to Winston, who replied with a soft bark. Zach reached across and ruffled the fur on Winston's head, reminding himself that the dog would need a haircut soon before the fur blocked his vision completely.

He started the truck and put it in gear, pulling out of the parking lot of his little furniture studio in the quaint end of Aldergrove. He drove south, heading for his house.

The drive to the house was quick. Now that he was older and had a better lay of the land, he realized the house that was out in the middle of nowhere actually wasn't as remote as they'd originally thought. Aldergrove was small, and the outskirts were mostly farmland. It was only a fifteen-minute drive from his workshop to the property.

He parked his truck in the driveway and slid out, making the short walk from the driveway up the front steps. They had been lovingly replaced, the decay and rot chiseled away and replaced with solid wood, reclaimed from a barn down the road. Zach had carved the railings from the same wood and installed them with care. The boards no longer bowed beneath his weight as he climbed them, and the porch was sound and solid under his feet.

He unlocked the door and stepped inside, Winston close at his heels.

Zach couldn't walk into the place without being assaulted by the memory of that day with Parley. It had been so sweet and had turned so toxic by the end. The last image he had of the boy he loved was him being carted off to deal with his parents. Zach had been terrified for him—so much so he hadn't given any thought to what was going to happen to him—and as he watched him through the window of the crowded police station, he'd wondered if they would ever get their chance to really be together.

Zach had never heard from him again.

It wasn't that Zach had given up on him. Rather than leaving town again right away, he had spent the rest of the summer trying to see Parley. He'd gone to his house the next day, but Parker had told Zach that Parley

was gone. He'd gone back the next day and the next, but even when pressed, Parker refused to say where Parley had gone.

Eventually, Zach had stopped going by. The Youngs were never going to tell him anything, he realized. He was better off on his own. He'd find Parley one day. His own parents had been less than understanding about his reasons for running away in the first place. Although likely nothing compared to what Parley had had to endure, Zach's father hadn't stopped yelling for days. Worse than that, though, was his mother, who just didn't say anything.

He hadn't actually gone home, opting instead to crash on the couch of a friend from school and flip patties at Burger King until he could pay for his own place. The first apartment he'd rented was a dump near his old high school, but he'd only stayed there for a couple of months.

Although it hadn't been as exciting or felt as promising going it alone, Zach knew that Vancouver wasn't where he was meant to be. He took his car—he'd finally gotten it fixed—and drove back to near where he and Parley had been found.

Aldergrove was a small but quaint community, and he felt at home there. He found a little basement suite he could afford and picked up three part-time jobs, saving as much money as he could. He had two goals at the age of eighteen: to buy his house and to find his friend.

Zach had never stopped looking for Parley, but all traces of him seemed to have been erased completely. There still wasn't a day that went by that he didn't think about his friend. Being in the house brought the memories back more vividly than ever. That almost-kiss more than a decade earlier had stayed with Zach. He liked to think of that kiss as his first, although if you were being technical about it, Sarah Backerman had been his first. Parley had been the first that *mattered*.

He walked through to the kitchen and stood in front of the pantry, in the spot he had stood sixteen years earlier and confessed for the first time that he was in love. The walls had been painted and the shelves replaced, but the feeling Zach'd had all those years ago felt as potent now as ever before.

Every time he stood in that spot, he couldn't help but think of all the *what ifs*. What if Mrs. Anderson hadn't spotted them? What if they hadn't opened the door when the cop had knocked? What if he'd been able to see

Parley again after that day? Would they still be together? Would they be living in that house, with a dog and a guinea pig?

Zach liked to think so. He'd spent so much of the last sixteen years dreaming of what would happen if he ever found Parley again. Every so often he would Google his friend's name, but nothing ever popped up. It was like he'd never existed in the first place.

Zach walked slowly through the house, trailing his fingers along the surfaces of the furniture he'd built for the home, taking stock of every hour and every drop of sweat that had been invested into the building. He had taken the house from a dilapidated pile of waterlogged wood, stone, and broken tiles and turned it into something beautiful.

In the back of his mind, he'd done it for Parley. This was never meant to be Zach's house. It had always been for the boy he loved. He turned around and stepped out onto the balcony in the bedroom, the one that cropped out over the front door down below and offered a view of the surrounding fields. The breeze danced past him, cooling his skin and blowing the scent of raspberries to him.

He sighed. It had been so long. He knew that Parley wasn't coming back. He really should just sell. Although he'd told Tessa he wasn't finished with the renovations, in truth they'd been completed long ago. Now he just came out here to be quiet and remember. He'd take his tools and tinker with things, but for all intents and purposes, the house was nearly perfect.

Zach couldn't bring himself to sell, though. In his mind, the building wasn't really his to sell. There was too much history here, and the thought of someone else trampling on his memories made Zach feel ill. Somewhere in the recesses of his unconscious, he held out hope that one day he would find Parley and they would have their happily ever after beneath this roof.

He made his way out the back door and across the yard, stopping at the fence that surrounded the pasture. His six horses grazed happily on the grass there. The youngest, Willow, came galloping over to him, and then nuzzled him with her velvety nose.

"All right, all right," Zach chuckled, reaching into his pocket and pulling out the sugar cubes he always kept there when he knew he was

coming to visit his girls. Willow inhaled them, swallowing them down and looking at him as though she was asking him, “Where’s the rest?”

“That’s all I got, darlin’,” he said softly, patting her on the head.

Zach went into the barn, pulling out more feed and topping up the feeders near the shelter adjacent to the pasture. He liked to let the horses roam free during the summer when the temperature never dipped below seventy degrees. The girls loved it, prancing around and noshing on the buttercups that grew in the field.

He looked down at his watch, noticing that he’d already spent more than two hours just wandering around the house. He had to be at the Murphys’ place in less than an hour and if he was late, Tessa was going to kill him. Hiring her had been one of the best decisions Zach had ever made... or rather, one of the best decisions Tessa had made for him. They’d met one day when Tessa had passed by the storefront of his workshop and ducked inside. She’d been wearing bright pink heels, taller than he’d ever seen, and a black dress that looked like something he’d seen on *Mad Men*. She’d been looking for something for her boyfriend’s birthday, and she and Zach had immediately hit it off. She’d spent a good five hours in the store, followed by another three at the pub down the block.

He’d seen her another three or four times that month, and each time he found himself liking her more and more. During one of her visits, she’d followed him into his office at the back of the workshop, and when she laid eyes on his “filing system,” she’d declared that he was hiring her. He’d laughed, thinking she was obviously joking, but when she’d shown up the next morning, two coffees in hand, he was quickly proven wrong.

Zach did one more walk-through of the house, making sure everything was okay, and then headed out to his truck, double-checking that he’d locked the front door behind him. As ironic as it was, he didn’t want anyone seeing an empty house and thinking they could just walk in.

He’d barely turned the key in the ignition when the phone rang through his Bluetooth and over his car’s speakers. He clicked the button on his steering wheel to answer the call.

“Zach here.”

“You’d better be halfway to the Murphys’ house.”

“Hi, Tessa. I’m just leaving for there now.”

“Good. Mrs. Murphy called to make sure you were going to be there on time. That woman is strung tighter than a guitar string... and just as close to snapping. You don’t want her going off on you.”

“Got it, Tessa. Don’t worry. I’ll be there.”

CHAPTER ELEVEN

“UNCLE P, I don’t feel well.”

Parley looked in the rearview mirror to see his nephew of sorts, five-year-old Desta, looking decidedly green. He frowned, even as Desta’s sister, six-year-old Jiang, clutched his hand and turned to look at Parley’s own sister, Emma.

“He looks really sick, Auntie Em.”

“Par, I think he’s going to barf,” Emma said.

“We’ll pull over as soon as we can, kids,” Veronica, Parley’s best friend and business partner, said. She turned to look at the three in the back seat. “Hold on there, kiddo,” she said to Desta. “We’ll fix it.”

“If this bothersome traffic will cooperate,” Parley muttered.

Veronica, brunette and beautiful, her dark skin glowing as she laughed, said, “We’ll pray for it.”

It took him a few minutes to navigate, and soon he’d parked the car on the shoulder of the road. Typical, Parley thought. Now that his nephew was throwing up everything he’d ever eaten, there were no other cars—no other signs of human life. The almost mad rush of traffic that had dogged them on the drive up here from Vancouver had gone, disappearing beyond the horizon.

They were on the outskirts of Aldergrove, on their way home from a family outing chosen by Jiang. Jiang and Desta were Veronica’s two adopted children. Desta was from Ethiopia, Jiang from China. Jiang had just recovered from surgery to correct an extremely bad cleft palate—so bad that the craniofacial team at BC Women’s and Children’s Hospital had demanded of Veronica why it had taken so long to get her treated. Parley’s terse reply on her behalf about adoption laws taking time and perhaps if they talked less and operated more had been met with stony glares.

Now they were clustered around Desta, who looked much less green around the gills and was sipping from a bottle of water pressed into his hand by Emma. Parley couldn't stop the smile that sprung to his lips. These were the people he loved most in the world. Veronica, who understood him better than he understood himself, and had never pushed him to do anything; Emma, his baby sister, now eighteen years old and with hot pink hair, a black leather jacket, and piercings in both ears, her left eyebrow, and one nostril; Jiang, her lip still covered by gauze, wearing a purple T-shirt with an elephant on it and blue jeans; and Desta, his tight black curls framing his face, wearing a gray T-shirt and blue jeans. His family. His life.

Veronica came over to join him, bumping his shoulder with her own. She was nearly the same height as him, and quite probably the best friend he'd ever had. Aside from Zach, of course, but Zach resided in his memory, the wistful regret of love lost and never found that he would sometimes look at late at night and then cry himself to sleep over.

"You know where we are, right?" Veronica said in her soft, gentle voice.

Parley nodded. "Yeah. I'm trying not to think too much about it. I almost fell over when Jiang said she wanted to visit the zoo."

"You and me both, babe. It's a little weird that the Vancouver zoo is all the way out here. It's so far from downtown, but I suppose they needed the room." Veronica sighed and looked around them. "I can't see the house you told me about."

"It's a bit further south, closer to the border."

"Will you be all right?"

Parley shrugged. "I honestly have no idea. You might have to drive the kids back and let Emma deal with me if I have a panic attack."

Veronica swore. "That damn farm. Not that it was a farm; it was hell, and okay, sure, I wasn't there, but I know you, Par, and I know what you've told me. I've held your hand and hugged you when you have night terrors and..."

Parley looped an arm around her shoulders. "You've been the best friend I could ever have asked for. I know you want to go down there and blow the place up—"

"Just a lot!"

"—but you can't do that, so we'll just keep moving forward, okay?"

"Fine. But you'd better believe I've been writing to church authorities about that place. I haven't stopped and I never will, because it's cruel and inhumane. They teach that God is love. Well, they should practice what they preach and close the place down!"

Parley smiled. "You're our lioness, Ronnie."

"Damn right. Now, our two kiddos seem to be better and Em's washing off Desta's face, so shall we go on or head home?"

Parley looked over at the three young people. "Let's ask them."

Emma turned to face them then. "Par, Jiang still wants to go on, and Desta tells me he's just fine, though I'm not sure I totally believe him."

"I am! I swear, Auntie Em!"

Emma laughed. "Okay, okay. You're fine. I believe you, but thousands wouldn't, Scamp. Hop in the car."

"Okay!"

"And you, River-girl—" Parley smiled as he heard the English meaning of Jiang's name. "—you ready to rock and roll?"

"Yes, Auntie Em!"

"Good girl. Hop in with your brother."

"Okay!"

As soon as the two kids were in the car, Emma joined Parley and Veronica and fixed him with a look he knew all too well. It was a look that quite clearly said "Don't lie to me, you big fool, I love you and I care, so talk to me or else." It was the look she'd given him when he'd returned home three and a half years after he'd left for Sunbeam Farm, a look that was always older than her years.

For a moment, Parley thought about the day he'd arrived at that place. It was beautiful, located in a green valley, rows upon rows of vegetables lined behind in fields that were kept neat and tidy. The main house and dormitory had been made of dusky-colored stone, and for one brief, shining moment, Parley had thought that perhaps Sunbeam Farm wouldn't be quite so bad. And then he'd met Adrian, the head of the place, and been told what the rules were, and his hopes had plummeted down to his shoes. No books outside of scripture, no access to the telephone, no sending letters home, no communication with the outside world. Up at five each morning to wash, then have breakfast, then working in the fields until lunch. After lunch would be scripture study and then for two hours a one-

on-one consultation with one of the elders who lived there. If the session went well—by Sunbeam’s standards—Parley could go to dinner. If it didn’t, then he was taken downstairs and started immediately on therapy. If he was good, he had a week to adjust before starting therapy, but if not....

Parley shook himself and forced his mind away from the memory. He could still see the specter of Adrian towering over him, a man over six feet tall with iron-gray hair and piercing brown eyes who never seemed to smile. Adrian had haunted Parley’s waking life and his nightmares for years, and while he knew he was getting better, there were some things that he would never ever forget. But that was the past, and he was with good people now, kind people. He had to focus.

“I’m fine. I promise,” Parley said before Emma could speak. “I’m worried about Desta’s digestion, but aside from that, I’m good.”

“You sure?”

“Positive. It’s a bit odd seeing this part of the country again. Not a lot has changed. But so far, so good.”

“So far,” Emma said. She looked at Veronica. “You sure he’ll be okay, Ronnie?”

“Yeah, I think he will. I think this is as important for him as it is exciting for the kids.”

“Do you two mind not discussing me while I’m standing here?” Parley asked.

“Not really, no,” Emma said cheerfully. She lightly punched his arm. “This is what you get for having a best friend for a business partner and another for a sister, big bro.”

“I’m very blessed,” Parley said, and he meant it.

“You really are. Now let’s get back on the road, champ.”

They all got back in the car, and once Parley was satisfied everyone had their seat belts on, he started the engine and drove the car back on the road.

As he drove, everything became more and more familiar. It was strange that he wasn’t freaking out more, for he had thought that coming back here after so long would trigger a panic attack of the most epic proportions. It had last night; he had sobbed in Veronica’s arms, and although he hadn’t told her why, she had known. After all, he had told her all about himself the second

day he'd met her at church, and she had decided then and there that she would take care of him.

He remembered their conversation now as he drove them all past field after field. He had told her that he was gay, that the conversion therapy hadn't worked, and that, in the end, he had lied just to be able to leave that hellhole that had been his residence for over three years. He had told about Adrian, about the long sessions of therapy that lasted most of the night, the unyielding cold steel of the gurney beneath his back and the woven straps that held him there as diodes were stuck to his forehead and a heart monitor to his left index finger. He had told her of Adrian's foreboding voice as he lectured about the evils of being homosexual, as he had given long sermons about Bible lore upon which Parley and his companions were tested later. All of that and more, and Veronica had been a calm, empathic audience, not judging, not interrupting, and not trying to rationalize Parley's experiences. Most importantly, she had understood. Veronica had her own demons, and he respected that.

They both worked for a NGO children's charity and had gone to Ethiopia to work together there, both as missionaries preaching their religion and volunteers in one of the orphanages. That was where they had met Desta, and she had applied to adopt him. During the process, one of their coworkers had told them about a little girl in China, one of the so-called "China's Waiting Children," abandoned because of her physical deformity: a cleft palate.

While the process for adopting Desta went on, Parley and Veronica had flown to China. When they first saw Jiang, saw the extent of her cleft palate and how it affected not just her mouth but her nose, Veronica had applied to adopt her as well. Eighteen long months of forms, interviews, visits, and endless long nights of worrying later, Parley and Veronica had taken the two adopted children home with them. They'd been toddlers by then, and not so much walking as tottering, but to Parley, they were the most beautiful children in the world.

Emma, Parley's little sister, had moved in with them shortly after. She was too smart for her own good, Parley thought, and that was probably why she had so much trouble with his family, who couldn't understand her rebellious streak and hated her creative urge, her paintings that were of two men kissing or two women holding hands. Emma said

she painted scenes of love, and her muse directed her brush. Love didn't discriminate, and neither did she. Threatened with going to Sunbeam Farm, Emma had appealed to Parley and Veronica to save her, and so they had.

Parley had very little to do with his parents now. Oh, there were big celebrations like Christmas or Thanksgiving or Easter, but he had too much resentment to linger long in their company. His brothers were different—although they didn't understand him very well, they loved him unconditionally and supported him and Emma both, so when Veronica had announced that Emma would be moving in with them the previous Christmas, Reed, Parker, and Heber and their wives had supported her. Faced with the universal determination of all their children and their spouses, Parley's parents had let Emma go, but Parley knew they would never really forgive him for, as they put it, "poisoning our daughter with unnatural beliefs."

Parley blinked slowly and forced his mind to concentrate on the road rather than on memories and old grievances. He did not hate his parents; he never had. They had done what they thought was right, although they'd been very wrong about that. His brothers had taken care of him when he'd returned from Sunbeam Farm, broken, shattered, a shell of who he had been. It had taken years for him to recover enough to go outside the family house, and then he'd met Veronica. Veronica was his guardian angel, along with Emma, Desta, and Jiang.

"Uncle P!" Jiang's bright voice burst into his reverie like a bell. "Look at that pretty house!"

Later, Parley would be impressed that he didn't plow them all straight into a tree. He was stunned at the house that Jiang had pointed out.

It was their house—his and Zach's. And it was beautiful.

He slowed the car, then pulled over, and the kids and their aunt scrambled out to take a closer look. Parley stared, unable to believe his eyes. The promise of the old building—the old girl, he'd called her in his mind—had been more than fulfilled. Her woodwork was perfect, the paint fresh and bright. The ornate carving of the wooden lace that bordered the slope of the roof was exquisite and there was a sense of pride of workmanship in the place. The drive, made of pebbles, was long and curved in a slow arc, with lavender bushes, roses, and a large swath of various herbs bordering it. It

looked like something out of one of Veronica's home and garden magazines. The outbuildings, barns, and the like had been restored with what looked like loving care, old wood replaced with new, matching as closely as possible. A huge oak tree stood proud and tall in the field beside the house, and there was a flutter of fabric from a fully repaired washing line.

And then Parley's gaze fell on the car, and he felt his throat constrict, tears come to his eyes, and his pulse start to pound. He could hear his heart beating loud in his head, his temples throbbing, and his vision started to go hazy. His breath hissed between his teeth, and he gripped the steering wheel so hard that his hands hurt.

"Parley." Veronica's voice was soft, calm, and reassuring. "Breathe, babe. With me now. In. Out. In. Out. Keep going. That's it."

It took him several long moments, but the sensations passed, and he swallowed hard and gave her a rueful smile. "Thanks."

"Don't mention it. So this is the house, huh? It's beautiful."

"Yeah. I guess whoever owns it decided to restore it. I'm glad. It looks amazing."

"I had no idea it was so big. Your stories never did the size of the place justice."

"I sometimes wondered if I'd imagined how big it was," Parley admitted. "I was very young, after all. I thought my memory might have exaggerated its proportions slightly."

"And the car?"

Parley winced. Veronica was far too perceptive sometimes. "That's the same make and model car that Zach and I... that he bought."

"I thought it might be. So now I have a question for you."

"Oh?"

"Mm-hmm. Shall we go knock on the door and ask if we could have a look around? Now before you give me that bunny in the headlights look, I have a reason for suggesting it. You've got a lot of ghosts, Par, and this place is somewhere that you have fond memories of. I think it would be helpful for you to see it again, now, to be able to put some of those ghosts to rest and, at the same time, take away something good and beautiful about your teenage years."

Parley bit his lower lip as he thought about it. Part of him wanted to say no, to get his family back in the car and drive away, go back to Vancouver as

fast as the speed limit would let him, but a larger part of him agreed with Veronica. And, too, he was curious. He wanted to see if the interior matched the grandeur and beauty of the exterior.

“Uncle P!” Desta shrieked with delight. “There are ponies, Uncle P! Six Shetland ponies!”

“They’re so cute,” Emma called.

“I love them,” Jiang cried, clapping her hands together.

“Mom, can we see the ponies? Please?” Desta yelled.

“Well, then. The kids have made their decision,” Veronica said.

Parley shook his head, a little amused. “Demanding brats,” he said, though there was no rancor in his voice, only a deep love. “They take after their aunt.”

“And their mom and uncle. Lock up the car, babe, and let’s go see what the owner of this place says.”

“Mom! There’s a dog too! A big woolly dog, like a black-and-white sheep!” Jiang was crowing with delight.

“Now you have no choice,” Veronica said to him.

Parley sighed. “The kids know we don’t have the room for a dog or a cat....”

“That doesn’t stop them wanting one of each.”

“I know, I know. Okay, I’ll lock up the car, and we’ll go knock on the door.”

“Good.” Veronica prepared to get out and then paused a moment. “Remember, if you need me to get you outside, the code word is artichoke.”

“I remember. Why you chose artichoke, though, is still a mystery.”

“Because it’s not a vegetable you’d forget,” Veronica said. She opened the car door. “C’mom.”

“I’m coming.” Parley waited until she was out of the car and the door shut, then quickly took a look around to make certain that they had everything: the dressings and medicine for Jiang’s healing wound; bottles of water; snacks; and the sketchpad, pencil, and digital camera that Emma took with her everywhere she went. Satisfied he had everything, Parley got out of the car, closed the door, and locked it.

He caught sight of his reflection in the car window. Dark blond mussed hair, cut short, locks sticking out at all angles from the wind that had blown

into the car on the drive, pale skin, freckles on his nose and cheeks, and gray-green eyes that looked a million years older than Parley actually was. He gazed at himself for a long moment, seeing a man of just over thirty with the eyes of a man of ninety. At least, wearing the long sleeve T-shirt he'd chosen for the day, the scars from the nights he'd cut himself at Sunbeam Farm weren't visible.

He shook his head at himself. "I will not let that place continue to control me," he muttered to his reflection. "It and everyone who works there can go to hell and burn in the deepest, fiery pit that the Devil has." It felt good to say that, and Parley wondered why he'd never said anything like it before. But his attention was pulled away by Emma calling him, and so he walked away from the family car, the dark green station wagon that had driven many miles around Canada, and toward the happy, smiling little group.

"THIS PLACE is incredible," Emma said. She was taking photos of everything—even of the grass—and her voice sounded almost reverent. "I can smell life here, you know? It's as if you can see and touch and smell things growing, get a real taste of existence. It's amazing."

"I'll take your word for it," Parley said. "I can just smell cut grass."

"That too," she said, unmoved by his words. "But life, Par. Life!"

"Life, Em. Got it."

"Uncle P, my face is starting to hurt," Jiang said then, and Parley's attention was entirely on his niece.

"Let's get your mom over. She's got the first aid kit. Okay, sugar-lump?"

"Okay. When will it stop hurting?"

"Soon."

"Okay."

The way Jiang accepted his word as gospel never failed to make Parley feel both as if he were the tallest man on the planet and the most humble soul who had ever lived. He wondered if Zach had married and had kids, if he knew what their house was like nowadays and what he'd think about it. As Veronica came over to check Jiang's dressing and give

her the children's painkillers, Parley looked around and breathed in deeply.

He'd never really appreciated how beautiful it was out here. When he'd been with Zach, his thoughts had been only of Zach. When Zach had told him... the words... that moment in the kitchen when they'd nearly kissed, nothing else had mattered to Parley at all. He could have died the next minute and have been content, for Zach cared about him just as he cared about Zach. He was still in love with Zach, and Veronica and Emma both knew it, but neither pushed him about it.

Parley wondered what Zach would say if he showed up and saw their old car parked by their old house. It was a bit of a time warp, the past mingling with the present. Though Parley was enormously grateful to see that the old girl, their house, had been healed. Just like his niece, he suddenly thought. And his sister, who even now was drawing the building, her pencil flying over the page of her sketchpad. And his nephew, whose eyes were as round as saucers as he stared at a large ginger cat nuzzling the black-and-white sheepdog. And, of course, Veronica, who hated the touch of a man but tolerated his hand in hers, who held him when he had nightmares, who gave so selflessly of herself in order to make life a little bit better for those around her.

He was so very lucky, and he thanked God every day for that. Even though he was sure that Zach had moved on with his own life, Parley hoped that his old and first and only romantic love had found family who cherished and blessed and enriched him like Parley's own did. He hoped that very much, because even though he still loved Zach and probably always would, Parley wanted him to be happy. He wanted Zach to feel the sweet, innocent love of a child, to know how it felt that in that child's worldview, the names "Mom" and "Uncle" were the names of God; that a teenage sister depended on him and respected him because he didn't judge her; that a best friend with her own broken pieces felt safe and secure enough in his presence to be herself and to let herself heal. Parley hoped very much that Zach had experienced all those kinds of love and, perhaps, the more intimate romantic love that came with physical expressions of it.

He would forever be celibate, he knew, but Parley was generous enough to hope that Zach had found his own great love story, complete with sexual intimacy, even though it wasn't with Parley.

“Come on, old man,” Emma said. “Stop thinking. You’ll wear your brain out. Let’s go knock on the door of this awesome house.”

“All right. And I’m not old, you young whippersnapper!”

She laughed, bright and joyous, and Parley smiled at her, as he walked beside her, his best friend and her children beyond, toward the drive and the front door of the house that he and Zach had once called theirs.

CHAPTER TWELVE

THE MURPHY consult went better than Zach had anticipated. He arrived ten minutes early, which seemed to delight Mrs. Murphy. He'd done his best to school his features when she'd answered the door, standing in front of him like a woman who was better suited for Beverly Hills. Despite the fact that she lived in a very affluent neighborhood, Zach had been surprised at the extent to which she had gone to make herself look attractive. And the word 'attractive' was used ironically in this instance.

Her overly processed blonde hair was practically shellacked into place, not a strand moving regardless of the stiff breeze that blew outside. Her hot pink lipstick was the exact shade of her skirt, which couldn't have been more than eight inches long, and her cleavage billowed out over top of her absolutely constrictive top. She looked like an older, careworn version of Barbie.

Ushering him inside, he took in the features of the house, immediately confused as to why he was there in the first place. Her style was very sleek, everything in white leather and chrome. She obviously didn't have children, and if she did, he pitied their lives. Everything was glass and so fucking cold. Not at all what he would have chosen.

His furniture would have stuck out in the room like a hillbilly at a royal gala.

They'd sat together on her uncomfortable barstools at her glass and chrome dining table as she outlined what she expected of him and when he was to have the pieces finished. It wasn't how he normally worked, preferring to find a piece of wood and let it speak to him about form and function. Maybe that was a bit fluffy, but it was a method that worked for him.

This lady wanted an entire houseful of furniture, and she wanted it by the end of the month. There was no way he could deliver on that. He

told her so, but she waved him off, telling him he would be compensated for his efforts.

Zach hated people like that, people who thought money was the solution to every problem they encountered. Although his bottom line would take a hit from refusing her business, he began to do just that, giving her an ultimatum. Either she was patient and worked with his schedule or she could find someone else to furnish her summer home on the lake. In the end, she decided that his talents were more important than her deadlines and signed a contract for custom creation of all her pieces.

Zach walked back out to his truck feeling quite satisfied with himself. He'd managed to score a huge client, and he hadn't had to sacrifice any of his values in the process. He called that a win. Winston was in the bed of the truck, sitting obediently and basking in the sunlight until he saw Zach walking across the yard. His butt lifted in the air and his tail started swishing back and forth with enough force that Zach was surprised the leaves on the trees behind him stayed attached.

The sun was still high in the sky. Zach loved the summer when the days stretched out. It was still early, and although he had a pile of new pieces he needed to work on, his fingertips weren't itching to get started the way they normally did. He decided to put it off and head back to his house instead. He'd fed the horses earlier, but hadn't spent much time with them, and even though there was a group of them, he felt like they were lonely without him. He called Winston, who jumped into the cab through the back window as he started up the truck. He made the drive back, listening to the radio as he went, the Fox playing his favorite song as he turned back onto the highway for home.

ZACH WOKE up to a stiff neck and an aching shoulder. He realized he'd fallen asleep on the couch in the den and hadn't actually left the house the night before. After he'd spent some time with Willow and her sisters, he'd gone back inside and ordered himself a pizza, which he ate in the den while making plans for the Murphy pieces.

It was the first night he had spent there since the failed attempt at moving in seven years earlier. When he bought the house, he'd had every intention of living in it while he renovated. His original plan was to fix it

up while he was tracking Parley down, and to present it to him as a gift when he found him again. After everything that had happened, Zach blamed himself. It had been his fault Parley had run away, and his fault they'd been caught. Worse than both those things was the fact that it had been Zach's fault that Parley was sent away.

He'd never found out where Parley had gone, but he had a sick feeling in his stomach every time he thought about it. It couldn't have been a good place. He'd met the Youngs, and after the little that Parley had told him about the old community he'd lived in before Vancouver, Zach doubted very much that they had sent him away on vacation.

When the deal on the house had been finalized, Zach had shown up with his duffel bag and a sleeping bag, intending on spending every night from then on sleeping in their house. At first it had gone well. He'd gone in and he could have sworn he could almost smell Parley in there, the memory of him was so potent. He'd fixed himself a cold dinner and retired to the bedroom where he and Parley had spent their two nights together. As he lay on the floor, thoughts of that night flew back into his mind. The more he let the images take over, the more upset he became, until he couldn't lie there one more second.

He'd gotten up, rolled his sleeping bag, and marched downstairs to the driveway where he'd spent the night crunched up in the back seat of his car. The next morning, he drove back into Aldergrove and negotiated with his old landlord for his basement back. Not long after that, Zach had found his workshop and opened up the doors to his own business.

Zach stood, stretching his arms above his head and feeling the pull of his stomach muscles as he leaned back, trying to work out the knot that had taken up residence between his shoulder blades. He took a deep breath, then lowered his arms when he heard a knock at the front.

Never in his seven years owning the house had he ever had a visitor. Groaning and giving a silent prayer that it wasn't a Jehovah's Witness trying to save his soul, he turned on his heels and made for the front door.

Nothing on earth could have prepared him for what he saw when he opened it.

Nothing.

Standing in front of him like a ghost from his past was Parley Young.

Zach's vision narrowed in on him, and for a moment, the rest of the world dimmed and fell away. All he could see was Parley. He stood there as minutes ticked by, just staring at him, taking him in. He looked almost the same. Zach couldn't believe his eyes. He'd grown a bit taller and broadened out. His hair was cut in a slightly different style—a little shorter and less church boy—and he had faint creases around his eyes that hadn't been there sixteen years before, but it was Parley.

He stepped forward, throwing his arms around his friend and pulling him close. He buried his face against Parley's shoulder and used every ounce of self-restraint he had to keep from bursting into tears. The feelings swamped him and threatened to sweep him under: happiness at finally having his best friend back after all those long years, and sadness at all the time they had lost. The emotions were so potent that he almost didn't realize how stiff Parley felt in his arms.

He let go, backing up two steps. Parley's face was colorless, as if the blood had drained completely away, his eyes wide and glassy. He looked absolutely terrified.

"Shit, I'm sorry," Zach said.

And then he noticed the tiny person standing next to Parley, holding his hand.

"Shit," Zach said again. "Sorry. I didn't mean to swear in front of the kid."

"Kids," a woman said, stepping forward and smiling at Zach. She obviously hadn't seen him hug Parley like he had or, Zach thought, her reaction would not be quite so warm and friendly. "Sorry to barge in on you like this. We were just driving by and the kids really wanted to see who lived here. I hope that's all right."

"Of course," Zach said, stepping to the side. "Please, come in."

The kids barreled through the door first, followed by the two women and then Parley.

An awkward silence fell over the adults as the kids launched themselves at Winston, petting his head and scratching behind his ears.

"I'm Veronica, and this Jiang, Desta, and Emma. Obviously you and Parley are already acquainted."

Zach didn't know which piece of information to process first. The fact that Parley had married, that he'd married a woman, that they'd had

children, or that the little girl who used to laugh uncontrollably when he'd blow raspberries at her was now a grown woman with pink hair and piercings, standing in his foyer. In the end, he went with the most innocuous.

"Holy... sh—sugar, Emma. I can't believe how much you've grown."

Emma looked thoroughly confused, her gaze shifting rapidly between him and Parley. "You know me?"

"This is Zach."

It was Parley who spoke, and his voice was so quiet it was almost imperceptible. Veronica's eyes widened in realization and Emma's mouth hung slightly agape.

Zach observed the reactions carefully. Clearly Parley had told Veronica and Emma about him if the twin looks of shock were anything to go by.

"Why don't you all come in and have a seat. I think I have some decaf tea kicking around in the kitchen somewhere. I'll put the kettle on."

Zach led them to the living room and motioned for them to sit while he ducked into the kitchen to boil the water. It was mostly an excuse to grab a moment alone to gather his thoughts. The last thing he had expected when he'd heard the knock at the door was to see the only boy he'd ever loved standing on the other side of it. What was more surprising was that he'd brought his wife and kids for the reunion.

Zach turned the tap on, filling the kettle with water as he tried to wade through the tangle of thoughts that were tumbling around in his head. What was the protocol for this? When he'd seen Parley, his heart had leapt at the thought that they might pick up where they'd left off. Obviously that was not going to happen.

Zach placed the kettle on the stove and turned the burner on, hearing it click until the gas ignited. He lowered the flame and set about finding the teabags. As he rummaged through his pantry, he became increasingly flustered.

Where were the goddamn fucking teabags?

He began pulling everything out, piling boxes and cans on the floor as he searched.

"Zach?"

He whipped around to see Parley standing meekly in the doorway. Zach's features immediately softened. He wanted nothing more than to pull Parley into his arms once again. Parley stepped forward, crossing the kitchen and came to stand in front of Zach.

Zach looked down, realizing they were in the same spot they had been in sixteen years earlier, the day he'd told the man standing in front of him that he loved him. The first time he'd touched him like he'd always wanted to touch him.

"Zach..." Parley said in barely more than a whisper. His head was bowed. When he looked up, his eyes shone with the unshed tears that had collected there. "I'm so sorry."

"Parley, it's okay," Zach said, his voice breaking. He ached to reach out and pull him close.

Parley shook his head. "No, it's not. It was never okay." He blinked then, the tears spilling over his cheeks. Zach couldn't have stopped himself if both their lives had depended on it. He stepped forward closing the space between them and gathered Parley into his arms. He slid his hand into Parley's hair and held him against his chest as his own tears flowed. He kissed the top of Parley's head and neither man said a word, the understanding for each other after more than a decade of hurt flowing between them. They stood rooted in place, holding each other as they sobbed.

Zach pulled back, hands on either side of Parley's face, tilting it up so he could look at him. He wiped one of the tears away with his thumb. He wanted so much to lean in and kiss him, to erase the years of pain, but he couldn't.

"I missed you," he whispered.

"I missed you too," Parley admitted.

Zach dropped his hands and Parley wiped his eyes with the back of his hand. A noise from near the door drew their attention and they turned to see Veronica walk into the room. Zach took one more step back from Parley, realizing how this would look, especially if she knew what they had once meant to one another.

As much as Zach's heart still beat for his best friend, he was married. He had children. And Zach would never ever want to come

between Parley and his family. Veronica didn't look angry, though. In fact, the little smile that played at her lips confused Zach.

"Would it be all right if Emma and I took the kids out to visit with the horses? It would give you two a chance to catch up a little," she said.

"Of course," Zach replied. He rummaged through the mess he'd created on the floor and found the box of sugar cubes. He held it out to Veronica. "They can give them some of these; just make sure they hold them out palm up, fingers outstretched." He demonstrated what he meant.

Veronica moved closer, taking the box from Zach before she wrapped his hand in hers and leaned in close so she could whisper in his ear. "I'm happy he found you," she said. And then she was gone from the kitchen and once again it was just Parley and Zach, alone in this place that meant so much to them both.

"I guess we should talk," Zach said, walking across the kitchen and pulling a chair out for Parley at the table. He thought it best if they sat, and having a wide piece of furniture between them probably wasn't a terrible idea either. Parley sat as Zach poured the boiling water from the kettle into the teapot. He placed it on the table along with two teacups, some sugar, and milk.

Once upon a time he had known how Parley liked his tea, but he had no idea if the years apart had changed such a tiny detail. Zach had never really cared for tea growing up, but when Parley had left, he'd taken to drinking it as a way of remembering. The delicate scent of the decaf Earl Grey always reminded him of Parley's gentle spirit.

"Do you want to go first?" Zach asked. A part of him was terrified of what Parley might tell him, but he had to know. All those years wondering what had happened to his friend had worn on him, and now here he was. It was surreal sitting with him in the kitchen that was meant to be theirs, his wife and children only a few yards away at the edge of the pasture.

Parley was quiet, seemingly lost in his head. Zach was patient. After all, he'd waited all this time; he could wait a few minutes more as Parley gathered his thoughts.

"After that day... my parents arranged for me to be sent to a farm. Sunbeam Farm, out near Chilliwack."

Zach wrung his fingers together to keep from slamming them into the table. The mere mention of the name of that place and the thought that

his hateful parents had sent him there tipped Zach over onto the precipice of a fit of rage. He felt sick to his stomach, and the calm and even tone Parley maintained while talking about it made it all the worse.

Zach knew Parley. Even after sixteen years apart, he knew. Time didn't change a person's soul. Zach understood that Parley would have suffered in silence. He would have been truthful about how he felt, even if it meant punishment. The only way Parley would have gotten out of that place was if they'd successfully broken him. Zach felt the tears pricking the backs of his eyes once more.

"I was there for three years before I had passed their program."

"So..." Zach faltered to a stop. He didn't quite know how to ask Parley what had happened to him in all those years. Half of him wanted desperately to know and the other half was terrified of what he'd learn.

"My brothers," Parley began, filling in the silence with his soft voice, "all told me to lie that night I got home from the police station. I've never been good at lying, and so I didn't. So I ended up down at Sunbeam. It was... unpleasant." He shifted a little and looked toward the window. "Anyway, after I got back to my family, my brothers had all moved out, gotten married, had kids. I moved in with Reed for a while. I didn't want to stay with my parents by myself, and Emma was living with him too.

"I lived with Reed and his family for eight months. We all went to church together, and that's where I met Ronnie. Her family had moved up from New Orleans, and she and I became friends. Ronnie, I think, knows more about me than I do myself. Her own past is... well, it's not for me to say. It's not good; let's leave that there. Anyway, she made me an offer one night, and I took it. We moved in together, to keep each other sane, and to be able to adopt the orphans. Sometimes, I think she's a saint. She doesn't ask anything of me. She's *there*. I can't.... Anyway," Parley rushed on, "we went to Ethiopia with a church NGO and worked in one of the orphanages. That's where we met Desta, and Veronica applied to adopt him. That was five years ago now. Four years ago, we were told about Jiang, which meant a dash in an ancient plane over to China. Once all the paperwork was sorted out, we brought them home, and Jiang's just had the last of her surgeries to repair her cleft palate. It was extraordinarily bad. So today's outing was her idea. And here we are."

“Wow,” Zach said. He didn’t know what else to say. He had tried to avoid staring at Jiang and to avoid asking questions that might be taken the wrong way, feeling as if he were walking on eggshells the entire time but knowing no other way to behave. Having Parley spell everything out for him answered the questions in his mind, but not the most pressing one. He wanted to ask more about Parley’s marriage, but he knew Parley well enough to be aware that Parley wouldn’t say a word. If he wanted those answers, he’d have to ask Veronica. Or Emma. Or both.

“Yeah. So, tell me about your life,” Parley said.

Zach shrugged. After the realization of what Parley had lived through since they’d last seen each other, his life seemed... mundane. “There’s not much to tell, really.”

“Are you married?” Parley asked, conspicuously glancing down at Zach’s left hand.

“No. Not married. Never even been close.” He wanted to add that he’d only ever loved one person, but he bit his tongue.

“And you live here.”

Zach shook his head. “Not really. I mean, I own the house, but I live in the apartment above my shop downtown.”

Parley’s face lit up. “You have a shop?”

The sight of Parley’s smile warmed Zach from the inside out, like that one small expression was everything he’d been waiting for.

“I do. I make custom furniture for people. I make my own designs too, and sell them in the storefront attached to the workshop,” Zach said, smiling around the rim of his cup as he sipped his tea, now that it had cooled enough to drink.

“That’s wonderful. How long have you been doing that?”

“Just over ten years. I love what I do. I build furniture during the week and on the weekends I come here. I’ve been working on this house since I bought it. There are still a few projects left to complete, but overall I’m pretty happy with how it turned out.”

“You should be, Zach. I am so proud of you. This place is beautiful.”

“You’ve barely seen any of it. Would you like a tour?”

“Yes please,” Parley said.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

EVERY CORNER of the house seemed full of memories. Shadows and ghosts of things long gone, summer days and dreams now only dust motes. Parley found the house to be an almost overwhelming dichotomy. On the one hand, it was beautifully restored and each panel, each cornice, had been done with loving care. On the other hand, this had been his first home away from home, and the site of his biggest personal epiphany, that yes, he was gay, that being gay was nothing to feel guilty for, and that, most importantly, Zach felt the same way about him. The almost-kiss had become something of a watershed moment in Parley's life: the moment he knew beyond a doubt that he was never going to be what his parents wanted and that he was actually okay with that.

They were on the landing of the second floor now, gazing out of the broad, double-glazed windows that overlooked the miles and miles of fields beyond, full of wheat and sunflowers, a colorful mixture of plants that mingled with long, tall grass. The plants undulated in the breeze like a giant serpent, just as Parley remembered. The sky was clear and blue and the sun shone down brightly, lighting up the chrome of Zach's car, which was parked by the house. It glinted off the windows of Parley's own family car, spots of radiant gold that made Parley blink rapidly and look away.

There was another sensation too, one that Parley couldn't remember feeling before. He felt lighter, as if some great stone had been removed from his shoulders, and he thought about Sunbeam Farm and Adrian's cold, unwavering gaze, he realized that the face of his primary tormenter no longer filled him with dread. It wasn't an instant thing, Parley knew; there was no such thing as instant recovery from trauma of any kind. It was simply that here, in a building that reminded him of simpler, happier times, times of innocence and joy, of revelation and peace, the darkness that had accompanied him when he'd left Sunbeam Farm had started to

dissipate, to fade to pale gray shadows. It had been a long time coming but he felt relieved. And it was partly due to Zach, who had once again reached out so selflessly and helped Parley regain his own feet.

He looked around for his family, and soon saw Veronica patting one of the ponies as the two children held out their hands, palms up and flat, just as Zach had instructed. The pony seemed to be extremely happy with its luck, devouring one sugar cube after another, its tail gently swishing back and forth, flicking away the flies. Emma stood a short distance away, her camera on its strap around her neck and her sketchpad in hand. She was drawing, her pink hair vibrant against the green of the paddock, her lips pursed as they always were when she was concentrating.

"I had no idea Emma was an artist," Zach said.

Parley nodded, not looking away from his sister. "She paints, mostly. But when we go places, she always takes that camera and her sketchpad. She likes to record things she might want to put onto canvas later. Mom and Dad never approved of her subject matter, though."

"Oh?"

Parley turned to look at Zach, keeping his expression as solemn as he could. "Yeah. She painted gay couples kissing and lesbians in love."

Zach choked and Parley grinned. "Didn't expect that answer, eh?" Parley said.

"No! Holy shit, your parents must have had conniptions."

"No doubt. They wanted to send her to Sunbeam Farm too, but my brothers and I... we all put our feet down and said no way in the world would that ever happen. She came to live with Ronnie and me instead."

"Damn." Zach shook his head. "How does that place still exist?"

"Fear." Parley turned back to the view of his family. There was another pony with his kids now, obviously come up to join the first and get its own share of treats. "A lot of people can't comprehend differences. They can't understand the idea that if God made humanity in His own image, then that means that part of God must be gay, lesbian, transgender, bisexual, Black, Asian, Latino, Indian, and more. They don't want to admit that their reason for hate or bigotry is based on their own perceptions and interpretations of scripture."

"I guess." Zach sighed. "But Par, that place... you know it's been raided by the cops, right?"

“Mm, yes. Several times, I’m told. They keep the name and just change location. It’s all very hush-hush. I have no idea where in BC it is now, but it’s still there, still doing the pray away the gay and other things.”

“Electroshock therapy,” Zach said flatly. “Psychological experimentation. Solitary confinement. Drugs.”

“That too.” Parley shrugged. “Sometimes fear makes people do some nasty things.”

“That’s putting it lightly. Don’t you hate them?”

“No, not really. I feel sorry for them. I feel even sorrier for parents like mine, who think—no, who *believe* this method really is a cure for something that isn’t a disease, just because of their own upbringing in more extreme elements of religion. Fear, ignorance, control—that’s how these places like Sunbeam and the compound where I spent my childhood operate.”

“You’re enormously forgiving, Par,” Zach said.

“Talk to Veronica. She wants to blow the place up.”

“Now that’s more like it!” Zach chuckled.

“Excuse me.” Veronica’s voice cut through their conversation. “I don’t mean to interrupt....”

“You’re not,” Parley said, giving her a warm smile.

“Debatable, babe. Anyway, the kids want to know if they can ride a pony.”

“Oh sure,” Zach said. “They can ride Willow.” Zach pointed toward the pony. “She’s the most gentle and she’s also strong enough to carry two light kids. I’ll come down and help.”

“I can go,” Parley said.

“I was just going to suggest that,” Veronica said. “I’d like to get to know Zach.”

“Great.” Parley reached out and lightly gripped Zach’s arm for a moment, and then he turned and went down the stairs.

“I REALLY didn’t mean to interrupt you,” Veronica said as she joined Zach by the window. “I know how long it’s been since you’ve seen each other. You’ve probably got a million things to catch up on.”

“It’s fine,” Zach said. “I wanted to ask you some things anyway.”

"I rather thought you might. How much did he tell you?"

"Just how you met, that you made a deal of some kind, went to Africa, adopted the kids, came back here."

"Well, that covers the meat of the matter. So what did you want to know?"

Zach was silent for several minutes, and Veronica wondered what was going through his mind. She couldn't begin to imagine how unreal this must be to him after so long, thinking that Parley was lost to him forever. To open his front door and find them all standing there must have been an enormous shock. When he did finally speak, his voice was low and strained, and Veronica felt a great surge of empathy for this handsome man that Parley was still in love with.

"How is he?" Zach asked finally.

"Better," she said. "Sunbeam did quite a number on him. He still has night terrors and PTSD flashbacks. He sees a therapist in the city, and he keeps a diary—the simple act of writing down his thoughts and feelings seems to be a very soothing activity for him. He has what he calls his 'spells,' which are when he seems to be looking at you, but what he's seeing is someone or something from long ago. We have breathing exercises I lead him through to get him past those. We deal with it as it happens. When we first met, he had nightmares every night, followed by panic attacks, and sometimes he'd lock himself in the bathroom. I'd hear him sobbing and muttering to himself. Emma was only a kid then, so she'd be asking what was wrong with her brother, and Reed and I wouldn't know what to say to her."

"Goddammit," Zach muttered.

"I know. I can tell you about it, but no matter what I say, no matter what words I use, it doesn't make things any easier. Seeing it and experiencing it... there's no way to really prepare a person for that. He *is* better, though. Having Desta and Jiang helped heal him in ways that nothing else could. I think because these were children who needed him and who couldn't advocate for themselves in any form, and Parley has always been the great champion of the helpless."

"He was always very generous," Zach said.

"He told me he used to tutor you back in high school."

Zach laughed at that. “Yep, he did. I wasn’t that great a student, but he helped me as much as he could. And then,” he sobered, “I repaid his friendship and kindness by bringing him here and setting off the chain reaction that got him sent to Sunbeam Farm.”

“No, Zach, that isn’t your fault. Please don’t blame yourself. Parley doesn’t. He’s told me all about that brief time you two were in this house and how happy he was. I think that with you, he felt safe enough to be himself for the first time in his life. Oh, he always had the connection with Emma, but a small child can’t understand the agony that goes with hiding the truth of oneself from the world. A peer, especially someone like you, who loves him and cares about him, can do more with a smile and a kind word than anyone else.”

Zach looked thoughtful and Veronica smiled slightly.

“It must be weird to see him all grown up,” she added.

“Damn right. It’s bizarre to see him again, period. I hate to admit it, but I’d almost given up on finding him, and then there he appeared, out of the blue on my doorstep.”

“You looked for him?”

“Every day since the day I saw him last. I had this awful feeling something terrible had happened to him, and the feeling just worsened over the years.”

“You must care about him very much.”

“*Very* much,” Zach repeated, heavy emphasis falling on his words.

“I’m so pleased you have found one another again—proof that miracles happen every day.”

Zach nodded. “A miracle, fate, whatever you want to call it, I’m just happy to see him again and happier still that he’s in such a good place, that he has a family who loves him. Parley deserves a good life. It was something I was never able to give him.”

“You never had the chance,” Veronica said.

“No. But I wanted desperately to be that person for him....” Zach’s voice trailed off as though he were deep in thought.

Veronica smiled at him. “You are back in his life now, Zach. You have the opportunity now that you’d been missing all those years.”

Zach looked at her quizzically but didn’t say anything.

"Thank you for being so kind and for letting my children ride your pony. You've given us all a day we're not likely to forget anytime soon."

"Your family is always welcome here."

"Thank you," Veronica said, rising from the couch.

"You're welcome," Zach said.

"I think we'll be down with the ponies for a little while. I can't see my daughter wanting to leave them too quickly, but I'll make sure Parley comes to say good-bye."

"Okay," Zach said. He looked more than a little stunned.

"Okay," Veronica agreed. She reached over and gave his shoulder a light squeeze, just as Parley had done only a short while earlier. Then she left Zach standing on the landing and went downstairs to join her family.

PARLEY LOOKED up to see Veronica walking toward him, a smile playing at her lips. "What's wrong?"

"Nothing's wrong. I'm smiling!"

"I know, but you look like the cat who got into the cream."

"I think you should go give Zach your phone number," Veronica said. "Give him your cell and our home line numbers and give him your e-mail address as well."

"Huh?"

"He's so clever sometimes," Emma drawled.

"Hush," Parley muttered absently.

"That man cares about you a whole lot and you feel the same. It'd be criminal to keep you two from ever communicating with each other again. Go and talk to him, babe. Give him the keys to unlock the doors to that communication."

"That was very poetic," Emma said.

"Thank you, sugar."

Emma wrinkled her nose at the endearment, Parley saw, but she was also smiling. He felt a little as if the women in his life were taking control of everything and that he had no other options.

Truth be told, though, he didn't really want any other options. He was enormously grateful to her for suggesting he give Zach their contact details, however, and he pulled his wallet out from his jeans pocket and

opened it, rifling through it for a minute until he found a copy of his business card. It had his cell number on it, and he grabbed Emma's pencil from her fingers and wrote down his home phone number and e-mail address as well. Handing the pencil back to his sister, he took a deep breath.

"Onward ho, Christian soldier," Emma said.

"I'm not marching off to war," he retorted.

"You look as if you're about to, you know. It's a very similar stance you've got there. He's not going to eat you, you know."

"Emma, this is hard," he said. He ran one hand through his hair, feeling the prickle of nerves like the passage of ants beneath his skin.

"I know. I get that. So does Ronnie, I bet. And if the kids were old enough to understand, they'd get it too. But we can't hang around this paddock forever. We'll have to go home for dinner at the very least. So you've got a small window of opportunity right now. Take the damn thing and go!"

Parley stared at her, looking at her pale, pierced face, her hot pink hair, her kohl-rimmed eyes. He saw only love and understanding in his sister, and he nodded once and turned to look at his best friend. Veronica's expression was very similar to Emma's—her dark skin was smooth and soft, her rosy lips turned up in a warm smile and her dark eyes full of support. Parley took a deep breath.

"Okay. I'm going."

"Good. We'll get the kids to the car," Veronica said.

"Let me take a few more photos first," Emma said.

Parley watched them both for a moment, and then he shook his head and turned away, walking back toward Zach's house.

Zach's house? It had been so long that Parley had thought of it as *their* house that thinking of it as only belonging to Zach seemed amiss somehow. And yet, it did belong to Zach. He had bought and paid for it, fair and square, all legalities taken care of, the deeds in his name alone. At least one of them had bought it, Parley thought as he walked to the neat wooden fence that enclosed the paddock. It would have felt wrong if someone he didn't know—and didn't like—were the owner and living in it.

He saw Zach standing by the old barn, now restored and repaired, the old wood and the new matching almost seamlessly. The quality of the work spoke louder than words about the skill of the craftsman and the pride he took in that work. Parley was again proud of Zach, thrilled to see how talented he was and how he understood that preserving history didn't mean erasing it.

"Hey," Zach said as Parley drew up to him.

"Hi. So, ah, here." Parley held out his business card.

Zach took it and looked at it. He nodded and smiled then looked up at Parley. "Thanks."

"You're welcome. I hope you'll use it."

"To call and catch up, sure. Most definitely. I'm not sure I need anything from an international orphans NGO, though. By which I mean I don't have kids, so... nothing against what you do," Zach said hastily.

Parley laughed softly. "I understood what you meant."

"Okay, good. Did the kids like Willow?"

"Oh yes. Jiang wants a stuffed pony now. She's telling us all that she's going to name it Willow, after yours."

Zach made an "aww" noise. "That's adorable, Par."

"Right? She and Desta often get that reaction out of me and Ronnie. Sometimes out of Em too, though she'd never admit it, because she's too cool for that sort of thing."

"Veronica is incredible."

"She is, isn't she?" Parley said.

"Definitely. Here comes your family, so I'll let you go and I'll give you a call."

"Please. Please do that. Call me, I mean. Or e-mail. Or both."

Zach nodded. "Absolutely. You can count on it."

Parley felt as if he were standing on air. Joy bubbled up inside him, a joy he hadn't felt for a very long time. "That's wonderful to hear."

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

ZACH'S HANDS shook as he held up the card Parley had given him. The corners were bent from how much he'd handled it in the forty-eight hours since he'd seen his friend. He picked up his phone, then punched in the numbers once more. He'd gone through this routine more times than he cared to count, and every time he ended up putting his phone back down.

Was it too soon to call? Maybe Parley and Veronica were just being nice. It had been so many years, and Zach had imagined their reunion so many times... maybe he'd imagined their receptiveness as well.

A large part of him clung to the insecure thoughts that tore through his mind, but as nervous as the thought made him, he knew he could put off calling only so long. Even if he could never have the relationship with Parley he so desperately wanted, having him in his life in any capacity was well worth the anguish it would cause Zach not to be able to love Parley the way he wanted to.

"Whatcha doin'?" Tessa asked, stepping into his office and breaking him out of his thoughts. He stashed the card in the top drawer of his desk, trying to look as nonchalant as possible.

"Nothing. Just making a mental list of what I have to do today," he replied, hoping she bought it. The last thing he needed was Tessa poking around in his head. He was scattered enough.

She stood in the doorway with her hip cocked to the side and her arms crossed. In her high heels she towered over him sitting at his desk. "You wanna try that again?" she challenged.

"Seriously, nothing," he said.

"You're so full of shit. You've been moping around here for two days. Something happened. And you're going to tell me what it was."

Zach sighed. "I am a grown-ass man. I don't need a babysitter."

"Clearly you do. What stupid thing have you done now?"

Zach dropped his head and stared at his hands, folded in front of him in his lap. It was useless trying to deflect Tessa. She was the most stubborn person he knew. “Parley’s back.”

He looked up to see her jaw drop open, and for the first time, Zach saw what Tessa looked like when she was speechless. After a moment of stunned silence, she’d apparently gathered her thoughts. “Like, the man you’ve been in love with for over a decade? The guy you’ve been searching for, for years?”

“That’s the one,” Zach confirmed.

“Well fuck,” she said, dropping her arms to the side. “What are you going to do?”

“I don’t know. He gave me his card and told me to call him, but he’s married. He’s got kids.”

“Oh.” She sounded terribly disappointed, but not more than Zach had been. He was happy Parley was happy, but for years he’d harbored a fantasy of finding him one day and kissing him stupid the moment he laid eyes on him. Wife and kids kind of put a kink in his plans.

“Yeah. It was a shock on top of a shock. He showed up on my doorstep, family in tow.”

“Are you going to call?” There was no judgment in her voice, only concern.

“I think so. As much as it’s opened up an old wound—and in a way I feel like I’ve lost him all over again—I’d rather have him in my life than not at all.”

“You’ll take him any way you can get him?”

“Pretty much,” Zach admitted. “It wasn’t the circumstances I’d been hoping for, but I loved Parley as a friend first, and those feelings have never faded. As much as I’d like to have him in my life romantically, his friendship is worth just as much to me.”

“Well, get to it, then,” Tessa commanded briskly, turning on her heels and walking out of Zach’s office. Zach thought for a moment before he pulled Parley’s card out of his desk and dialed one last time. He took a breath and, before he could think twice, hit the Send button, held the phone to his ear, and waited for Parley to pick up.

Although Zach was expecting Parley to answer, it still caught him off guard when he heard his friend’s voice on the other end of the line.

“Uh... hey, Parley, it’s... uh... Zach.” He sounded like a fucking idiot who didn’t even know his own name. What was he? A dumb fucking teenager who let his uneasiness get the best of him? He’d *never* been nervous around Parley before, yet suddenly the anxiety was sinking in, making up for lost time.

“Hi Zach. I’m so glad you called.”

Zach could hear Parley’s smile through the phone. It was like a balm for his frayed nerves.

“Hey Par,” Zach said, feeling the familiarity of their friendship settling back into him. This didn’t have to be weird or awkward. This was *Parley*. “How’s it going?”

“I’m doing well, thank you. How are things with you?”

“I’m good. Just getting ready to go over some orders, and I thought I’d give you a call before I got started on that. Hey, are you guys busy this weekend?”

“I don’t believe so. I can check with Veronica to make sure.”

“Yeah, you should. I thought maybe you guys could come out to the house again. We could go for a picnic near the creek at the back of the property.”

“There’s a creek?” Parley asked.

“Yeah,” Zach chuckled. “I guess we never actually explored to the property line when we were there before. It goes back a lot farther than we thought it did. There’s a creek and a little hill that crests behind it and gives an amazing view of the area.”

“That sounds wonderful,” Parley said, his voice a little dreamy.

“It really is.”

“We’d love to come. Thank you for the invitation.”

“You’re always welcome, Par. You know that. My home is your home.” Zach could feel the blush creeping into his cheeks and was thankful no one was there to witness it.

“Thank you, Zach.” The way he said Zach’s name was almost reverent, like the word held weight for him. It sparked a joy in Zach that he hadn’t felt for a very long time.

“Saturday? Around noon?” he asked, excited at the prospect of seeing Parley again so soon.

“We will be there.”

“See you soon.”

“Good-bye for now,” Parley said, and with that, the line went dead. Zach couldn’t help the wide grin. When Parley had said good-bye, Zach knew it was temporary, and that was the best feeling in the world.

“A picnic this weekend, huh?” Tessa asked from the doorway, a knowing smirk on her pretty face. “Can I bring anything?”

“Firstly, I’ve told you to stop eavesdropping on my phone conversations.” That earned an eye roll from his assistant. “And secondly, you’re not invited. Knowing you, there would be some underlying scheme. This is too new, too fragile, and not going to go where you’re thinking anyway.”

Tessa plopped herself down in the chair across from Zach, her long limbs at awkward angles as she leaned back, exasperated. “I understand that, Zachary. I would never jeopardize your newly rediscovered friendship, but please, please let me come. I’ll be good. I promise. Besides, you know you can’t cook for shit, and it’s going to be embarrassing when you show up to the picnic with bologna and mustard sandwiches.”

“Fine. If you promise to be good, you can come,” Zach conceded. He was actually a little grateful that Tessa would be there. She felt like a sister to him—a very annoying, very overbearing sister—and it would be nice to have someone in his corner to take some of the pressure off. He wanted the afternoon to go off without a hitch, and Tessa, despite her abrasive way with him, was actually very charming to everyone else. He’d often wondered what made him so special that none of that charm was reserved for him, but he loved her nonetheless.

ZACH SPENT the rest of his week working on filling orders. He’d never spent as many hours working as when he was trying to keep busy enough not to replay every moment from the weekend before in his mind, and not to imagine every moment from the following weekend either. It turned out that working with his hands did little to occupy his mind and as much as he would have liked to concentrate on what he was doing, he spent more time redoing the measurements he’d already taken once he realized his mind had been elsewhere.

Finally Saturday morning rolled around. Zach launched himself out of bed only a few minutes after six. He'd opted to spend the night at the house rather than in his tiny apartment to give himself more time in the morning to prepare for company.

Really, he knew he was excited and likely wouldn't be getting much sleep no matter where he was, so being at the house was just as good an option. Besides, since Parley had reappeared in his life, somehow being there didn't feel like such a violation of their friendship. He knew it was unlikely he and Parley would ever live under that roof together, but knowing he'd be there in a few hours, even if it was just to spend an afternoon, felt right.

He picked up his phone and dialed Tessa's number.

She picked up on the third ring, her voice groggy from sleep.

"Did I wake you?" Zach asked, already knowing the answer.

"Dawn hasn't even broken yet. Of course you fucking woke me."

Zach chuckled. "You said you wanted to come to the picnic. I need your help. I want to make sushi."

"Are you fucking kidding me?" came the terse reply. "That is idiotic on so many levels I can't even begin to explain."

"Try me."

"Well, first off, you can barely manage to construct a sandwich. How in the world are you going to manage something as complicated as sushi? Second, you're feeding *kids* today. Kids don't eat that stuff."

"One of them is Asian...."

Zach could hear the exaggerated sigh from the other end of the line. "Pretty sure that was racist. And it doesn't matter anyway. You're going to haul raw fish in a basket down to the creek in eighty-degree weather and let it sit in the heat for hours before anyone eats it? Would you like some sashimi with a side of salmonella? Why do you want to make sushi anyway?"

Zach was quiet for a moment. Tessa was going to make fun of him if he told her the truth.

"Come on. Out with it," she commanded.

"They're cultured. They've been all over the world. I can't feed them bologna and mustard sandwiches."

"You know I was kidding about that, right?" Tessa said gently.

"I guess. But I just don't want to seem like this dull, dimwitted construction guy who has never been out of the province. The guy who knows nothing about the world."

"You're not a dull, dimwitted construction guy. You don't even do construction."

"You know what I mean."

"I know what you think you're getting at, but you're wrong. You're incredibly talented and bright. You're clever and the greatest friend a person could have. Parley was lucky to know you when you were a kid, and he'll be lucky to know you now."

"Tessa?"

"Yeah?"

"Thank you," Zach said.

"You're welcome, but I'm taking back what I said if there's not coffee made when I get there."

"Deal."

With that, the line went dead, Tessa having hung up. Zach chuckled as he set his phone down. She was right. Maybe homemade sushi was trying a bit too hard. He ducked into the kitchen to survey the contents of the pantry and tried to formulate a plan.

He reached for the coffee, grinding the beans and filling the coffeemaker before setting it to percolate in time for Tessa's arrival.

Not long later, he heard the front door open and the clicking of Tessa's heels on the hardwood.

"I'm back here," he shouted as he grabbed a mug and poured her a cup of liquid caffeine.

Tessa toddled into the kitchen a moment later, her arms laden with bags of groceries. Zach placed her coffee down and rushed over to help her before she fell over sideways into the table. He grabbed the bags from her, setting them down on the counters.

"You're going to kill yourself wearing those heels one day," he scolded.

"Maybe, but at least my ass will look perky. You're welcome, by the way."

"I was getting to that part. Thank you. You didn't need to pick up groceries, though. I could have gone out."

"It was nothing," she replied. "I stopped at Safeway on my way down. I picked up some meats and cheeses, and some PB&J for the kidlets. There's pudding too."

"Pudding?" Zach asked, suddenly a lot more interested.

"Not for you. For the kids."

Zach pouted.

"I got some fruit too. I thought we could do a fruit salad," Tessa said as she started unloading the items from the bags and spreading them out along the countertops.

"That sounds fantastic," Zach said.

"I know it does. Now help me wash these and we'll get everything sliced and diced before your guests arrive."

Zach nodded and did what he was told, then grabbed a large bowl from the cupboard for them to mix up the salad in. Tessa showed him the easy way to dice the watermelon and the trick to keeping apples from going brown—squeezing lemon juice over the white flesh of the fruit.

They worked well together, in perfect synchronicity, Tessa chatting at him as they worked. It helped him keep his mind off Parley and his eyes off the clock as the morning wore on. He knew that if he'd been alone, he'd have been constantly checking the time, counting down the minutes until they arrived.

Tessa did a good job of distracting him.

AT TWELVE o'clock on the dot, the doorbell rang, just as it had a week earlier when Parley had walked back into his life. This time, however, Zach knew who was on the other side of the door. He paused, wiping his hands on the tea towel on the counter.

"You got this," Tessa said with an encouraging smile as Zach took a deep breath and went to answer it.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

THE EXCITEMENT of the children had the effect of distracting him from his nerves, and by the time they'd all arrived at the house, Parley felt as if he could quite happily have a long nap. Desta's words tumbled out over each other, his enthusiasm making him start new sentences before he ended the previous ones, and Emma was laughing, tickling him and then Jiang and making both kids howl with laughter. Jiang, her face now clean of dressings and bandages, couldn't stop smiling, and for a moment Parley looked at her and felt awed by her beauty, her strength, her childlike joy.

"Be strong," Veronica murmured to him.

"Can I be strong and have a nap?" he asked, smiling at her.

She laughed at that. "You must be getting old, babe. You can nap tonight."

Parley heaved a theatrical sigh and then he chuckled. "I just forgot how tiring excited kids and teenagers can be, that's all. And it's not a bad sort of tiring, just a sense of wow, they really are full of beans, and where are my beans so that I can keep up?"

Veronica patted his shoulder. "I'll buy you a rocking chair."

Parley snorted in amusement. "Thanks. You're so kind."

"I really am, aren't I?"

The door opened then, and there was Zach. Parley felt his weariness fade away, to be replaced with a quiet happiness, a relief to see Zach smiling, his gorgeous face framed by his soft, dark hair, his kissable lips....

Parley cleared his throat. Too much of a tangent, he told himself.

"Hi. Come on in," Zach was saying, and the kids went rushing into the house, calling to each other, Emma only a few steps behind. Veronica lightly tugged Parley's hand and he nodded, indicating she should enter first.

"It's lovely to see you again," Veronica said to Zach. "You chose a glorious day for a picnic!"

"Good to see you too," Zach said. "I'm really glad the weather cooperated, that's for sure."

"Hello, Zach," Parley said. He forced himself not to extend his hand for Zach to shake. It was a reflex action, born of many years of greeting people with a handshake. Zach was too close to Parley's heart for such a formal greeting, and Parley wasn't quite sure what he'd do if he touched Zach again now. He needed to breathe a little.

"Hey, Par. Come in."

Parley nodded and did so, following everyone down the long, broad corridor to the kitchen. He paused on the threshold, staring at the woman who was leaning against the sink. She was tall and slender and wearing very expensive clothes and a pair of high heels that made him wonder how on earth she managed to walk without breaking her ankles.

"Hi, I'm Tessa," the woman said, smiling warmly. "I work with Zach."

Oh. *Oh*. Parley felt a wave of relief flood him. On the heels of that came a rush of annoyance at himself. Zach had told him there was no one in his life, hadn't he? Parley had no reason to assume the worst—that this woman was Zach's girlfriend—and to feel jealous. He mentally shook himself and, feeling like a fool, stepped into the kitchen, holding his hand out for Tessa to shake.

"Parley Young. Pleasure to meet you. This is Veronica, Emma, Desta, and Jiang."

"Hi there. Zach's told me about you."

Parley quirked an eyebrow at her. "Did he?"

"Nothing bad. I promise," Zach said, coming into the room.

"No, no. It was all good things," Tessa said.

"I see. Well." Parley cleared his throat and looked around. "We brought some food and drinks...."

"Yeah, lots of food and drink," Emma said. "Ronnie always caters as if she's feeding an army."

"I was raised to make sure everyone had a good meal," Veronica said. "Though you're one to talk, missy." She laughed. "Emma put her

order in as soon as Parley told us about the picnic. I had to make extra Cajun chicken for her.”

“I love your Cajun chicken,” Emma said.

“Thank you, dear.” Veronica smiled and patted Emma’s shoulder.

“Mr. Zach”—Desta began, and Parley hid his smile as he saw Zach’s eyes grow wide as saucers—“will the pony be coming too, sir?”

“Well, Desta, she just might. But you don’t need to call me Mister; Zach’s just fine.”

“Are you sure, sir?”

“Positive, kiddo. Same goes for you too, pretty lady,” Zach said to Jiang, who moved closer to her mother and smiled a shy little smile.

“Okay. Thank you!”

“No worries.”

“Well then! Why don’t we get started and head on down to the creek?” Tessa suggested.

PARLEY WALKED at the back of the little group, listening to the conversations as they ebbed and flowed. Veronica was in deep discussion with Tessa about the wholly incomprehensible subject of fashion, and Parley smiled to himself as they talked at length about Manolo Blahnik and Christian Louboutin and their amazing shoes. The kids walked beside Emma, who was photographing everything around them, and Zach followed along. Parley, bringing up the rear, wished he could capture this scene forever—not just the image of it, but the sense of coming home that he felt, the camaraderie, the happiness.

It had been so very, very long since he had felt so completely relaxed. To be sure, Veronica and Emma had helped him enormously, but just being in Zach’s presence felt like a homecoming and Parley savored every second of it. As they walked, Zach whistled, and the Shetland pony that the kids had petted the first time they’d visited came cantering up, her ears pricked forward. Running at her side was the dog, and Parley realized that he had no idea what all of Zach’s pets—aside from Willow the pony—were called.

Once the pony and the dog had joined them, Desta and Jiang grew even more animated, Jiang walking beside the pony, her small hands buried in its thick mane. Desta shadowed the dog, patting its head and

ears, and the two animals behaved as if this was quite normal and regular treatment.

Zach dropped back a little, joining him. "The kids really love the animals," he said.

"Yes, they do. We can't have pets at our current home. The joy of renting," Parley said, wrinkling his nose slightly.

"You rent?" Zach sounded surprised.

"Yes. It's easier for us. Well, it was. When we were traveling between here, Ethiopia, and China, it made more sense to rent rather than to buy. I guess we just settled into the habit."

"What about school for the kids?"

"Desta's homeschooled for the moment. We want to research the schools and choose one that suits his needs. He's very intelligent but he has a short attention span, so we want him to go to a school that can stimulate him and keep his interest. We want a school where neither of the kids will be teased or bullied or anything like that because their family is such a blend of nationalities. Plenty of folk stare now, and some of the questions we get asked can be quite invasive. I understand the curiosity, but the kids don't, not yet anyway. They're not old enough."

Zach grunted. "Yeah, sometimes people can really suck."

"Your friend Tessa—she's quite a character, isn't she?" Parley changed the subject.

Zach laughed. "That's definitely one way to put it. She came in to buy something one day. The next minute she'd taken over the filing and the orders and had become my personal assistant. I had no idea I needed one until she took it all over. She sort of adopted me. I sometimes feel like she's the sister I never had."

"Oh, I see."

Zach shot him a look that Parley couldn't quite decipher. "Were you... did you think something else?"

Parley rubbed the back of his neck. "For a moment, I thought she was your girlfriend."

Zach's reaction was not what Parley had expected. The loud burst of laughter was more of a guffaw, coming from deep inside Zach, and it took him a few moments to control it.

"Did I say something funny?" Parley asked.

"Oh, Par, I love you," Zach said, and for a moment he froze. Parley's eyes widened, but he didn't say anything. He didn't dare. And then Zach went on as if he'd never spoken those three loaded words.

"Tessa's got her own life. She dates... I can't actually remember the guy's name. But she knows I'm bi, with a definite lean toward men."

Parley nodded, mentally flailing for a new subject, for something—anything to discuss other than those words. He was saved by Emma.

"Hey Zach, where's this creek, dude?"

"Oh! Just keep going down the path for another five minutes. It turns a bit and then flattens out. There are trees, grass, and a little beach is visible when the tide goes out. I have no idea how far away the main river is, but the creek behaves as if it's the Amazon."

"How cool! You should've said—we could've all gone swimming."

"Not Jiang, though," Veronica said. "Her healing hasn't quite finished yet."

Emma sighed. "I forgot for a moment. That wouldn't be fair. Maybe next time, then."

"That'd be a great idea," Zach said.

"Count me out," Tessa said.

Veronica nodded, her expression very serious although her eyes were sparkling with mirth. "I quite understand, dear. You couldn't swim in those heels."

"Damn right," Tessa said, and then both women laughed.

"I have no idea what they're talking about," Parley said to Zach. "When Ronnie starts talking clothes, it's as if she's speaking ancient Greek."

Zach nodded. "Know the feeling. Tessa and her clothes are a whole other language to me."

They followed the path, which flattened out as Zach had said, and they were presented with a space that defied anything Parley had imagined. It was green and shady, and calf-high grass was dappled with sunlight that shone down through the tree branches. The sound of the creek bubbling away as the water ran was a sound of true merriment, and the birds that sang lustily from their perches in the giant oak tree that stood beside the creek, shading the area, were bright and happy.

"This is incredible," Parley said.

“Right? I was so happy when I found this spot. It’s such a great place to relax and think. Sometimes I come down here and design or read, and Winston and Willow love it. Macaroni comes with us sometimes, but he tends to stay nearer the house.”

“Wait, wait—Winston is?”

“Oh sorry. Winston’s the dog, Willow’s the pony, and Macaroni is my cat.”

“You called your cat Macaroni?”

“Mmm-hmm.”

“Why?”

“Because he’s the color of mac and cheese, of course.”

Parley burst out laughing. “Of course,” he agreed.

“See? Everything has a very good reason,” Zach said.

“You’re absolutely right.”

THEY SET up the picnic blanket and sat down in a loose circle, Tessa and Veronica laying out the food because, Tessa said, “You men would make a mess of it.” Parley didn’t necessarily disagree with her, mostly because he had his lap full of Jiang. As soon as he’d sat down, Jiang had moved to cuddle him, and now he held her close, resting his chin on the top of her head.

“You okay, peanut?” he asked her softly.

“Yes, just my face hurts a bit,” she said.

“Okay, let me get Mommy for you, and she’ll have the cream that numbs the pain.”

“Thank you.”

Parley sighed. “She was born with a cleft palate, which I told you about. Her adoption was contingent on the guarantee that she’d be treated in a Western hospital as soon as possible.” He shook his head. “It was... a bad one. I’m generalizing because...” He indicated that he didn’t want to be too specific with Jiang in hearing range. “And so we got back to Canada and took her to a specialist right away. It’s been a long journey, and now it’s nearly finished, so she can eat without pain.”

“I was messy,” Jiang said. “I hate being messy!”

“She really does,” Parley said. “She scolds us if we’re untidy.”

"You're not really messy," Jiang said.

"Thank you, peanut. Ronnie?" Parley called. "Jiang needs some of that cream."

"Sure thing, babe." Veronica came over and picked Jiang up off Parley's lap, taking her back to sit with her beside Tessa. Parley watched them for a moment and then turned back to Zach.

"When we went to the orphanage," he said in an undertone, "we were told that unless she had craniofacial surgery and treatment, she'd die."

"It was that bad?" Zach looked shocked.

"Yes, it was. They had to reconstruct half of her face, not just so she could eat, but so she could breathe properly. It was touch and go for a while, but she's a fighter, and we weren't going to let her down."

"Goddamn," Zach breathed. "You guys are amazing."

Parley was surprised. "Why?"

"Because you're all so selfless and help these kids. A lot of folks wouldn't do that."

Parley shrugged. "Perhaps, but I think everyone is worthy of love and respect, and these children had no chance for that. We were able to offer them a chance, and we've made sure to educate them in their culture and birth country languages and traditions as well as English."

"Again, a lot of folks wouldn't do that."

Parley smiled faintly. "You would."

Zach stared at him. "How do you figure that, Par?"

"Because you're a kind man, a giving man, a man who feels empathy and compassion, and I know that if you were in a third-world country and presented with a child that you knew would die of malnutrition and disease if you left them behind, you'd take that child home with you."

Zach pursed his lips, looking thoughtful. "I don't know," he said.

"I do." Parley was convinced and he nodded.

"Okay, well, I'll take your word for it, I guess." Zach shook his head and looked over the spread of food. "And we have a ton of food. I hope we don't overeat!"

"Leftovers are good," Tessa said from opposite them.

“They sure are,” Emma agreed. She had been sketching and taking photos and Parley hadn’t noticed. “I got a great photo of Zach and you with Jiang, Par.”

Parley swallowed hard and managed a smile. He wasn’t sure he wanted photos like that. They were too much of a reminder of things he’d never been able to have and a love that had been snatched away from him by fear and misunderstandings. But he didn’t say any of that, instead looking again at the food.

“Should we say grace?”

“Sure,” Zach said.

“I will, if you like,” Veronica said.

“Thanks, Ronnie.” Parley smiled at her and she gave him a quick wink and a look that spoke volumes about how she understood his conflicting emotions and the memories that welled up within him.

There was so much to think about, Parley mused to himself as Veronica said the brief prayer of thanks over the picnic. So many emotions to examine, so much he wanted to have but felt he’d lost. He wanted his family and he wanted Zach. Lord have mercy, he thought, how he wanted Zach. But he didn’t want to put a strain on his relationship with Veronica or the kids or his sister or Zach himself. Could there be a way to make things work? Could he have his cake and eat it too, have his long-dreamed-for happily ever after?

Parley didn’t think it was possible. And so, with a quiet sigh of regret, he forced himself to think of other things as he said the soft “Amen,” at the end of the prayer and pretended that nothing more pressing than eating a good meal was on his mind.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

ZACH LOOKED around the group as everyone was laughing and eating. Tessa and Veronica seemed to be getting along amazingly well, and the kids were happily munching away on large wedges of watermelon, the juice running down Desta's chin while Jiang looked on scornfully. She ate hers with tiny bites, conscientiously, daintily.

His eyes landed back where they always had, on the man who held the other half of his heart. It was absolutely surreal that here Parley was, sitting in front of him, on the property they'd discovered together as though they'd never been apart.

But they had.

They'd been apart for so long, and so many things had changed. Life had taken a different path than he'd once thought, following twists and turns that Zach, as an idealistic teenager, could never have foreseen. It was difficult for him to reconcile this new image of Parley with the one he'd carried around with him for all those years.

He looked happy, and that was what mattered most to Zach. It was difficult to sit here across from him, though, and not touch him. Even the smallest touch would feel wrong in front of his wife and children. The urge to be alone with him was overwhelming, but Zach bided his time. They were all enjoying a nice lunch, and he didn't want to interrupt for his own selfish reasons.

Finally everyone was finished and Tessa was packing the leftovers into the basket. As though the women had read his mind, Veronica piped up, "Hey Zach, Parley was telling me how much work you've put into the property. Why don't you guys go for a walk? You can show him all the places he hasn't seen yet."

Zach hadn't ever shown any true interest in kissing a woman, but suddenly, he wanted to lay one on Veronica.

"Ronnie, are you sure you're okay with the kids?" Parley asked.

She gave an exaggeratedly playful sigh and rolled her eyes. “Go on. We’re going to have a scavenger hunt.”

The kids squealed with glee. Zach stood, waiting for Parley, and together they headed for the edge of the creek. They turned, meandering along it for a while before either man spoke. Zach was happy just being in Parley’s presence, and when they were alone it felt like everything clicked into place. For a moment he was able to imagine that they were together, that no one had found them and they’d been living in their house all these years, that they were in love and life was easy and uncomplicated.

But it wasn’t, and reality pushed in around the edges of Zach’s fantasy world. He looked over at Parley, who was looking at him with a strange expression on his face.

“Everything okay?” Zach asked.

“Yes. It’s so much more okay than I thought possible. I am so glad to have found you again.”

“Me too,” Zach said. “I know I’ve already said this, but I’ve missed you so much.”

Zach turned toward his friend. The temptation to lean and in kiss him was so strong that he almost caved into it. But he couldn’t. Parley was married. He had a family—one that Zach was not a part of. He needed to remember that.

“I’m so glad you all came out today. It’s nice to spend time with all of you. Desta and Jiang are beautiful, Emma is spunky, and Veronica is just... well, she’s just amazing, Parley.”

“She is. She’s been urging me to rekindle a relationship with you.”

Zach’s eyebrows lifted. Relationship? He wasn’t sure what kind of relationship. A deep part of him hoped she recognized how Zach felt about her husband and to what lengths to which he’d go to make Parley happy. Another part of him tamped down that hope. How many women would encourage their husbands to have affairs?

Parley hesitated a moment, as if he was unsure if he should go on. “Is there a chance for us?”

Zach licked his lips and shifted from foot to foot, carefully deliberating how to respond. What he wanted to do was grab Parley, haul him up against the large oak tree next to them, and finish what they had

started sixteen years earlier, but he wouldn't. To hear Parley ask that question, he wanted there to be a chance for them, and it was more than Zach had ever dared to hope for.

"I like to hope there is. I like to hope there will be, if there isn't just yet. But that's not up to me. At all. You understand, don't you Par?" Zach said after a few moments, making sure that he didn't choke on the words. His heart was pounding so hard that the sound of it in his ears drowned out most of the background noise.

Parley nodded solemnly and stepped forward, just a half step, but Zach didn't hesitate, reaching out and pulling him into his arms. Parley buried his head against Zach's shoulder and Zach tightened his arms around Parley, holding him close. He breathed him in, surprised to discover he still smelled exactly the same as he had when they were kids.

He could feel the wetness of Parley's tears soaking through his thin T-shirt and the shuddering of his body as he sobbed. Zach wasn't surprised to feel wetness on his cheeks as well. Under normal circumstances, he wasn't an overly emotional guy. But then, these weren't normal circumstances.

"I don't know how to do this," Parley whispered. Zach barely heard him over the sounds of the river and his own heartbeat.

"We're going to take it one day at a time," Zach murmured in hushed tones. Parley looked up at him, his eyelashes wet and sticking together. "This is a difficult situation, though, Par. Our decisions in this affect more than just us, and that complicates things. I won't lie to you: I love you. I've loved you for a very long time, and I want to be with you—completely with you—more than I've ever wanted anything in my life. But I am not going to come between you and your family. I am not going to break up a marriage and tear a husband away from his wife and children. No matter how hard I love you, your family has to come first."

Parley pulled back a little farther and stared at him. "Marriage?"

"A marriage means something to me and I know it means something to you. I'm not going anywhere, Parley. If all I can have is your friendship, I will gladly take it. And if there's a chance there can be more, I will wait until the end of time for you. I've already waited sixteen years.

I'm good at the waiting." Zach quirked a smile, trying to lighten the mood a little with a joke.

It fell flat.

"Zach," Parley said, his voice quiet and his eyes intense. "I'm not.... Veronica's not my wife."

"What? But you live with her.... The kids...."

Parley nodded. "We live together. We have for a long time. We're best friends. Desta and Jiang are hers, and Emma and I help raise them. Yes, we're a family—they're my family—but I'm gay. And I've been in love with you since I was seventeen years old."

That was all Zach needed to hear. Suddenly every barrier he'd constructed, every fear, and every moment of hesitation he'd ever had were wiped away by those little words.

He pulled Parley into his arms and claimed his mouth in a bruising kiss. He poured sixteen years of love, heartache, and wanting into that kiss. Parley hesitated for a moment, not moving. Zach almost pulled away, fear suddenly gripping his heart, but then Parley opened to him, kissing him back with everything he had.

Zach moved his hands, sliding them up Parley's back and over his shoulders to cup his face as he kissed him, reluctant for it to end. It had been everything he'd ever hoped it would be.

The kiss ended and they clung to one another, breathing hard, resting their foreheads against each other's, their eyes fixed on one another. Zach tried to calm his heartbeat; his mind was racing. What did this mean? Where did they go from there? How soon was too soon to ask him to move in? Instead, all he could say was "Wow."

Parley nodded, looking a little stunned.

Zach leaned forward once more, pressing his lips against Parley's, reveling in the warmth and easiness of it. He couldn't believe it was really happening. He smiled against Parley's mouth and felt Parley smile back.

"Come on. I want to show you something," Zach said, pulling away and taking Parley by the hand. Parley walked with Zach, close enough their shoulders brushed together as they stepped over rocks and branches along the creek.

They made their way downstream to a copse of trees that jutted out into the water.

"I've always wanted one, and I know you did too, so I built this," Zach said, standing in front of the low treehouse of sorts he had constructed.

"Why is it raised off the ground?" Parley asked.

"I didn't want to make it too high, but I needed it up just in case the creek rises. I didn't want it flooding and rotting out the wood."

Zach pulled him toward the stairs and together they climbed up and crawled across the wooden floor to sit in the center. "Lay back and watch this," Zach said, pulling on a rope that was wound around an anchor on the wall. Slowly, the roof of the clubhouse parted in the middle, lifting open to the side, exposing the sky above, framed around the edges by the leaves of the surrounding trees.

"Amazing," Parley said.

"Thanks. I wanted to be able to camp out here and still see the stars."

Zach rolled over, propping himself up on one elbow. Parley turned to look at him, his eyes shining. He looked happy, peaceful. Zach wanted to live in this moment forever. He leaned down and kissed Parley again. Parley kissed him back, his mouth warm and inviting as Zach slid his tongue gently along Parley's. Zach angled himself, bringing their bodies into alignment and pulled Parley impossibly closer.

Years of pent-up frustration and longing took root deep inside and spurred him on. He groaned, his hands roaming along Parley's sides, his erection pressing insistently against his zipper. He wanted Parley so badly.

Parley pulled back, gently pushing Zach away. Both men were out of breath and panting.

"Zach... I don't.... I can't.... We need to slow things down, just a little. I've never done this and as much as I want to, it's a lot to think about. There's so much that has happened and I want to tell you.... I just—"

"Fuck, Par, I'm so sorry," Zach interrupted. "I didn't even think.... I let my hormones take over. I'm sorry."

He backed off and gave Parley the space he needed. Parley lay next to him, staring at the sky through the open ceiling. Zach did the same. He smiled when he felt Parley's hand clutch at his.

"This place is amazing, Zach. This is like every little boy's dream. I love it here," Parley said.

"You know who else would love this? Jiang and Desta."

Parley smiled, his eyes crinkling in the corners. "They really would."

"Maybe later this afternoon we could bring them down here, or next time you all come out and visit."

"You want to have us all back?"

"Definitely. I love you. I want you here always, and your family is important to you, so they are important to me. Besides, I think Tessa and Veronica might have bonded a little too tightly to keep them apart."

"They were getting along well, weren't they?"

"They were, and trust me when I tell you that Tessa isn't the easiest person to be with sometimes. She's fucking bossy when she wants to be."

Parley laughed. "Maybe you need someone who will keep you in line."

Zach shot him a look of mock indignation. "That's what she said too."

"We should probably go back. They're likely wondering where we are."

Zach was reluctant to leave. Spending time with Parley alone was a lot easier than in a group setting. It wasn't that Zach didn't like Parley's family. He was just so comfortable with Parley, and it was difficult to translate that when there were others around. Not to mention how much Zach wanted to kiss him again. He would wait, though, respect Parley's boundaries. He knew the other man had been through so much and had come out the other side a little banged up.

Zach pushed himself back up off the floor with a groan, lowered the roof, and wrapped the rope back around the anchor on the wall before they climbed down the steps and set out along the creek back toward the others.

WHEN THEY arrived back at the picnic site, Desta and Jiang were playing hide-and-seek with Emma, and Veronica and Tessa were chatting away about the boutiques on Granville. Zach couldn't quite believe that although they'd spent hours together that afternoon, they hadn't exhausted the clothing topic. Women baffled him. It was a damn good thing he was in love with a man. So much easier to understand.

Veronica smiled brightly when she saw them draw near. Tessa took a different approach, waggling her eyebrows and making her eyes so wide that Zach was surprised they stayed in her head.

“Did you boys have fun?” Veronica asked.

“Yes. It was nice to go for a walk, and Zach showed me the treehouse he built down the creek a bit. It’s beautiful and has a roof that opens so you can see the sky.”

“It sounds wonderful. Zach, you’re a very talented man,” Veronica said.

“Too bad he lacks the motivation to use that talent in any kind of efficient manner,” Tessa teased.

Parley turned toward her, his body suddenly rigid. “Have you seen what he has done with this place? Perhaps you didn’t see it before he started the work. Zach, I believe, is one of the most motivated people I know. Not just anyone could do what he’s done. The house, the barn, the outbuildings, the landscaping, everything. It’s incredible.”

“Whoa, Par,” Zach said, resting his hand on Parley’s bicep. “It’s okay. She’s just busting my balls. It’s kinda her favorite pastime.”

“I’m sorry, Parley. I didn’t mean anything by it.”

Parley looked sheepish. “I’m the one who should be apologizing. That was my mistake. I don’t understand the nuances of your relationship. I shouldn’t have made assumptions....”

Zach didn’t know what had just happened. He’d never heard Parley snap like that before, and more shocking still was the apology from Tessa. In all the time he’d known her, she’d never backtracked like that before. He didn’t know if that was a good or bad omen.

“Maybe we’ve all just spent a little too much time in the sun,” Veronica supplied, easily pacifying everyone. “It’s late anyway. We should gather the kids and get going. Jiang will need to rest. It’s been a big day.”

“It has,” Parley agreed. He turned to Zach. “Thank you so much for having us out here. We all had so much fun.”

“Kids, come say thank you and good-bye to Zach.”

The children ran over, out of breath from chasing one another through the field. “Thank you for having us,” they said in unison.

Zach bent down to their level. "You are very welcome. You're welcome here any time you'd like to come."

"Can we come see Willow again?" Desta asked.

"You bet," Zach answered.

Everyone grabbed a blanket or a bag to carry back to the house, and a few minutes later they were all hugging and saying their farewells. Zach noticed that Parley hung back as though he wanted to be the last to say good-bye.

Parley hugged him, lingering just a few moments longer than necessary.

"Thank you again," he said, and Zach knew there was more behind his words than simple gratitude for an afternoon picnic.

"Come back soon," Zach said, and Parley promised they would.

After they'd left, Zach retreated inside, Tessa close on his heels.

"So that was Parley," she said, sitting down in a chair across from where he'd collapsed on his couch.

"Yep. That was Parley."

"I can see why you've been pining away for him all these years."

Zach gave her a half smile, suddenly exhausted. All he wanted to do was crawl into bed and sleep for the rest of the weekend.

"I kissed him today."

"What? You did? Why didn't you tell me?" Tessa squealed.

"I just did," Zach replied sardonically.

"How was it?"

"Amazing. Perfect. Fucking insane, until he pushed me away."

"He what?"

"It's not like that. I was barreling down this road with him and he wasn't ready for it. He's been through so much, and he's got some issues he needs to deal with before we can truly be together, I think."

"What are you going to do?" Tessa asked.

Zach leaned forward, his elbows resting on his knees as he dropped his head into his hands. "I have no fucking idea. Well, no, that's not true. I do have a fucking idea. I'm going to let Parley call all the shots."

"What do you mean?"

Zach looked back up at her. “Just what I said. We’re going to go at his pace, take things slow until he sees what I already do: that he belongs here.”

“I understand,” Tessa said.

Zach didn’t hear her. “So I’m going to sit back and spend time with them, and have my heart ripped out of my fucking chest every time he leaves, but I’ll keep inviting them over, I’ll keep spending time with them, and I will be patient if it kills me.”

“Well, now who’s being a touch melodramatic?” Tessa scoffed.

“You don’t get it, Tess. He’s the only person I’ve ever loved. I’ve waited for him for *sixteen years*, and he saunters back into my life and all I want to do is get down on one knee and beg him, *beg him* to be mine forever, but I scared him off with a kiss.”

“Men are such idiots sometimes.”

“Well, thank you. That makes me feel so much better,” Zach growled.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

“ARE THE kids asleep?”

Parley smiled as he joined Veronica on the plush, comfortable sofa. “They sure are. Desta’s even snoring, which is adorable. I had to force myself to leave his room.”

Veronica chuckled. “I can imagine it.” Her expression grew serious and Parley found himself tensing. It was an old habit, one he had not been able to break, born of too many years watching people’s expressions to determine what punishment he would get for this or that infraction.

“You need to talk to Zach.”

Parley stared at her as if she’d spoken to him in Swedish. “Come again?”

“Par, I love you. You’re the best man I know, and you treat me like a princess. You dote on my kids and you adore your sister. You’re kind, honest, considerate, and you still have faith in God, even after everything. You’re intelligent and interesting, and you rarely get angry. But you can be stubbornly selfless on occasion, and this is one such occasion.”

“She’s right, bro.” Emma came into the living room and sat down in her favorite armchair.

“Well, I’m glad of that, but what, pray, is she right about?” Parley’s confusion grew as he watched the two women exchange glances, Emma rolling her eyes dramatically.

“You should be with Zach,” Veronica said.

“What do you mean?”

“I know that we are your family and you love us, you take care of us, and you’ve been there for us, always putting us first every time, but you need to think about you here. Or more accurately, you and Zach. I’d always held out hope that you would find each other one day, and I knew if that happened, that was where you belonged. We love you. We’ll always love you, but you should be with him.”

Parley licked his lips and looked down at his lap. "I'm frightened, Ronnie."

"Oh, hon."

Parley felt her move closer to him and then there was the gentle touch of her hand on his arm. He looked up and gave her a smile that he hoped wasn't too shaky.

"Give him a call," Emma suggested.

"That's an idea. Telling him over the phone won't be difficult. You've got that distance between you and that should help."

Parley mulled that over for several moments. Finally, he nodded. "All right. But you need to do something for me."

"Anything," Veronica said.

Parley took a deep breath, feeling himself shaking uncontrollably. He hated confrontation, ever since that night so many years ago when his father had banished him to Sunbeam Farm. "I need you to tell him. Make the call now and tell him everything. Then I'll take over."

Veronica made a sound like a surprised huff of breath, and he looked at her closely. Parley realized that she hadn't even considered that option, but he felt as if he couldn't breathe. And even with the safety net of doing this over the phone rather than face-to-face, he still needed Veronica's—and Emma's—strength to help him.

"Makes sense, Ronnie," Emma said, as if reading his mind. "It'd be a good way to break the ice, get the ball rolling. Plus, I think if it came from you, Zach'd be less likely to misunderstand. Par, I love you, but you're a big softie and don't express yourself properly because you want to be liked too much."

"I resent that, Miss Emma. I'll have you know I have quite a few muscles and am not at all soft," Parley retorted.

Emma blew a raspberry at him and then she laughed and the tension in the air was broken.

"All right," Veronica said. "Let's do it now."

"Now?" Parley parroted. "Why?"

"No time like the present," Emma said. "I'll go grab the phone. We can put it on speaker."

Parley felt his heart begin to pound and he barely registered Emma putting the phone on the coffee table or Veronica finding Zach's number

in her cell phone. He listened, made mute by trepidation, as she dialed Zach. The phone began to ring, and he gulped as Emma sat beside him on the carpet, resting one hand on his knee, a touch of reassurance and support he mentally clung to. When Zach answered the phone, Parley almost bolted, but Emma's hand and Veronica's gentle voice kept him in place.

"Hi Zach, it's Veronica here. I was wondering if we could talk a bit."

"Hi. Sure. Of course. Is everything okay?" Zach's voice sounded worried.

"Everything's just fine. We had a bit of a family meeting here, and Parley asked me to do something for him. He asked me to call and tell you the nature of our situation. When I've done that, I'll hand the phone over to him. He's right here, and we've got the phone on speaker, so if he wants to say something while I'm talking, he can."

"Okay...." Zach's voice now sounded guarded, cautious.

"All right, then. As you know, Parley and I met at church. My now-ex-husband was... well, he was a bad man. Let's leave it at that. Parley helped me a very great deal and told me a lot about himself and his life in the process. We became very close, and so I proposed we share an apartment and he suggested we go overseas and do work with our church NGO. While we were there, people commonly thought we were married. It was easier to let it go than explain, and so while we shared a room, we never shared a bed.

"There are things in my past that I still have not yet healed from. And there are things in Parley's past that he hasn't healed from. Parley has some issues regarding his body that he can tell you himself, and you and I can both thank Sunbeam for that. Even if he didn't have those issues, he's still a gay man who happened to cling to his friend, because it was safer and easier for the both of us than to be alone and try to cope without any real support or understanding.

"I have always wanted kids, but after my parents and I moved to Vancouver, I realized adopting would give me as much joy and fulfillment as having my own children. Parley loves kids, and he told me once that there were too many children in the world without anyone to love them and if we could help even one of those children, he'd be a happy man. So we helped two. I adopted Jiang and Desta."

"Ronnie..." Parley's voice was soft and he touched her shoulder.

"I'm fine, Par. You okay there, Zach?"

"I'm okay."

"Good. I'm sure you can appreciate that this isn't a regular situation."

"You can say that again. I'm not really sure what to do here, Veronica. Everything seems so complicated. On the one hand, I want Parley to be in my life very much. I'd love it if he were here, with me, but I can't take him away from you, Emma, and the kids. I can't be selfish and insist things work on my terms."

"This doesn't need to be as complicated as you think, Zach. It can be simple. How do you feel about Parley?"

"I'm in love with him."

Parley closed his eyes at the admission. He couldn't quite believe he'd heard the words, the words he had ached for years to hear. He had daydreamed about those words, hearing them said by Zach, hearing the emotion in them that he could hear now. He clutched Emma's hand tightly, and she hummed softly, moving closer and resting against his leg, her thumb rubbing the back of his hand in silent support and understanding.

Veronica took a breath and continued. "Then that's all that matters. Everything else is just details that can be worked out in time. Love doesn't care about proprieties. I love Parley, Zach. He loves me. But ours isn't a romantic love. It isn't hearts, flowers, dates, kisses, snuggling, or sex. It's a love founded in friendship, trust, mutual respect, and dedication to the kids and families. He's my best friend and my closest confidant. But our love is nothing like the love you and he have for each other. Yes, he does still love you. I don't think he ever really stopped."

Parley made a small noise at that and Veronica shot him a quick look. "You got that spot on, Ronnie," he said to her.

Veronica smiled at him. "I know you very well."

"You really do."

"But..." Zach's own voice was now sounding strangled, as if he didn't know what to say or how to say it. Parley could imagine that his face was beet red and that he was waving his free arm in the air, in a fruitless gesture of confusion and bewilderment.

“But nothing. This is how he is. This is how we are, he and I. Emma knows, because Emma is clever and is very talented at reading between the lines and picking up on what isn’t said as much as what is. I think Reed and Heber suspect, but I don’t think Parker is any the wiser. In his whole life, Parley has felt that deep, enduring, romantic love for one person, and that person is you.”

“Emma’s also right here, just so you know,” Emma added.

“Oh my God,” Zach said.

“Aren’t you an atheist?” Veronica asked.

“Yes! Holy shit!”

“Zach, if there’s one thing I can ask you?”

“Of course. Anything.”

“Be gentle. Parley’s been hurt a lot. We both know it. But more than that, he’s very shy. His natural shyness has amplified over the years, I think. So don’t expect miracles. But in saying that, don’t be surprised if you get them.”

“Okay.”

“It’s a strange thing to sit calmly by and listen to this, you know,” Parley said, but he wasn’t angry or upset. On the contrary, he was grateful that Veronica had been able to say clearly how things were, when Parley knew that the words would stick in his throat or not come out the way he wanted them to. Veronica shot him a quick, fond smile and continued talking to Zach.

“I can hear I’ve given you an awful lot to think about. I’ll hand you over to Parley now. Thank you for being so kind to my children, and for being so good with Parley.” She picked up the phone receiver, deactivated the speakerphone, and then held it out to Parley.

Parley took it with trembling fingers and lifted it to his ear. “Hello, Zach,” he said.

“Par? Jesus, Mary, and Joseph. I have no idea... what the... holy shitfuck!”

Parley laughed at that. He couldn’t help it. “That’s a new one.”

“I had no idea what else to say!”

“Are you at the house right now?” An idea had come to Parley and he felt almost as if this was a piece of divine revelation, something that was so blindingly right in his mind that he knew he had to do it. He had to

go to Zach now, tonight, and talk with him, see his reactions with his own eyes. He didn't need the benefit of the distance of a telephone call. He needed to see and speak to Zach in person. Now.

"No, but I can be there in less than ten minutes. I just have to take Winston out to use the little puppy's room first...."

Parley laughed again. "I haven't heard that term for a doggy toilet before."

"Tonight, I seem to be on a roll of weird things to say."

"I guess so. Well, I was thinking, if it was all right, I could drive up now."

"Hell yes! I mean, sure, by all means, if that's okay with everyone."

Parley looked first at Veronica, who was nodding and smiling, and then at Emma, who was making "mush, mush" gestures with her hands. He had the sudden urge to tell her this wasn't the Iditarod, but he restrained himself, feeling too confident now and too buoyant to do anything other than drive out to Zach's—no, to *their* place.

"They're fine with it," Parley said.

"Great! Then I'll see you soon?"

"You got it. Bye, Zach."

"Bye, Par."

Parley ended the call and took a deep breath. A moment later, he found himself engulfed in the hugs of Veronica and Emma, and he awkwardly hugged them back, feeling their pride in him, their happiness for him as something solid and real, benevolent and right.

Veronica pulled back first, wiping at her eyes with the back of her left hand. "While you head over there, I think Em can help me with something."

"Yep, can do. What's up?" Emma sat back.

"I think we should start looking for somewhere to rent near to Zach and Par's house."

Emma let out a long "Ohhh" and then she'd moved, bouncing over to hug Veronica tight. Parley gazed at the pair of them, stunned once again by his enormous good fortune.

"I am so lucky to have you two," he said to them. "I am blessed beyond my ability to say."

"We love you," Emma said. "Isn't this what people do when they care for one another?"

"Absolutely it is," Veronica said. "And even though ours is a strange situation, it's an honest one, and that is the most important thing."

"I love you both very much," Parley said. "And I love Desta and Jiang."

"We love you too. Now get to your car and drive like you've never driven before," Emma said. "Without breaking any traffic laws," she added.

Parley got to his feet. Everything had a sense of inevitability now, overlaid with a sort of unreality, a touch of magic. He didn't believe in magic, but he did believe in spirit and in God, and blessings, and this felt to him like a benediction, a gift for enduring as much as he had and for providing a home and giving his love to people who most needed it.

"I'm going," Parley said. He picked up his cell phone and pocketed it, and then his car keys. "I'm afraid I don't know when I'll be home...."

"Don't worry about that," Veronica said. "If you're not back tonight, Em can help me with the kids."

"Absolutely. No problem," Emma said. "Now go!"

"I'm off." Parley didn't need to be told again. He made his way to the front door, still amazed at how the events of the evening had transpired. Veronica had been able to tell Zach what Parley knew he couldn't because the words would have stuck in his throat. Veronica had opened the gates, though, and now all Parley wanted was to see and talk to Zach.

He couldn't remember how he got to the car or started driving until he was on the road, the high beams cutting bright paths into the night. There was little traffic and the trip seemed to take less time than usual. While that probably wasn't true, Parley was delighted to see the hulk of the house appear as a distant shape on the horizon, lit up by outside lights that were, to his eyes, a beacon of welcome.

As he saw it, he felt the last vestiges of darkness from his memories of Sunbeam Farm fade away into shadows, still present—as they always would be—but less likely to engulf his mind with horror remembered. The house, and most importantly, Zach, had helped Parley to burst out of his

inner prison of pain and memory and take a step forward to face the light of the present and future.

He pulled into the driveway and cut the engine. He got out of the car and made sure the doors were locked, and then he walked over to the steps that led to the wraparound porch. He climbed them quickly and, his heart in his throat, he stepped up to the front door and knocked firmly three times.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

ZACH PACED around the front room of the house so much he thought he was going to wear through the varnish with his footsteps. Winston barked at him. Even his dog knew he was behaving like a crazy person. He knew that racing over to the house hadn't been necessary. It was going to take Parley a while to get there, even with the lighter traffic post-rush hour, but hanging around the apartment wouldn't do any good. He'd be impatient and on edge no matter where he was. At least if he was at the house, he knew he'd be there when Parley arrived.

Half an hour felt like a repeat of the sixteen years they'd spent apart. Zach thought he might actually be eighty by the time Parley showed up. He stalked to the kitchen and put the kettle on. He didn't want tea, and he doubted Parley did either, but it was something to do. He had to occupy his hands or he was going to start tearing his hair out in large clumps.

Just as the gas flame clicked and caught, Winston hopped up from next to Zach and bounded toward the front door. Zach turned the stove back off and followed. As he neared the front, he could hear the crunch of tires on the gravel driveway. He pulled the door open to see Parley parking his car next to Zach's truck.

He clenched his hands, willing himself to stay in one place. He didn't know how Parley would take to being mauled the second he exited his vehicle. In fact, Zach wasn't sure how Parley was feeling at all. The conversation they'd had earlier had left Zach feeling scared, worried, hopeful, and horny all at the same time.

All he wanted was Parley in his arms.

And moments later, that's exactly what he got.

Parley all but ran up the steps to him, and without hesitation, Zach pulled him in, holding him close and breathing in his scent. He'd known he was coming, but it was difficult to believe he was really there, standing

with Zach on the porch—their porch—and they were finally free to be together.

Parley lifted his head, tilting his face up to Zach's to kiss him. Zach gave himself over willingly, pressing his lips against Parley's. They kissed like that for a long time, halfway in and halfway out of the house, the cool night air wafting past them as they licked and nibbled at each other's lips. Parley's mouth was warm, but the heat radiating off his body made Zach's head spin. And they were fully clothed. And outside.

Zach was swept up in the fantasy of what would happen when they were alone, hidden away from the world inside their house, naked together under the blankets of their bed. It was their house, their bed. Zach was never letting Parley go again.

He stepped back half a step so they could catch their breath.

"We should go inside," Zach said. "My neighbors aren't nosy, but that doesn't mean I want to put on a show for them. I want you all to myself," he added, kissing the tip of Parley's nose.

Parley took his hand as they walked across the threshold, through the foyer, and into the living room.

"Parley," Zach started at the same time Parley said, "Zach."

The two men laughed, the tension Zach hadn't noticed easing slightly.

"I'm sorry...", Parley began again.

"What could you possibly be sorry for?" Zach asked, sitting down on the plush couch and pulling Parley with him. No space existed between them and Zach played with Parley's fingers as they talked, still in awe that this was really happening. He felt protective, too, and worried, the scars that spoke louder than words about Parley's suffering made Zach want to punch something or someone—preferably whoever or whatever had been the reason for such behavior. But now was not the time for such thoughts, so Zach pushed them firmly away.

"I'm sorry I didn't tell you everything before. Earlier. I should have told you."

"You have nothing to be sorry for, Par. You went through hell. I get that. There are scars I can see," Zach said, lifting Parley's hand and pressing a kiss to the jagged white line that bisected his wrist—leftovers from Sunbeam that Parley would carry with him forever. "And there are

scars that I can't see. I get that too. You're my best friend. You've always been my best friend. But we've been apart for a long time. It's going to take a while for us to get to know each other again. Things have happened in our lives, and we'll share it all, but it'll take time."

Parley looked hopeful. "I have time."

"We both do. We have all the time in the world, now that we're together. Nothing is going to ever separate us again. We'll take things one step at a time—baby steps if we need them—and if there's something happening that's too much or too soon, you just let me know and I'll slam on the brakes for us, okay?"

Parley nodded and licked his lips. He was trembling slightly, whether from nerves or fear or what, Zach had no idea. All he knew was that he wanted to make it right, to give Parley all the love, support, happiness, and freedom that he possibly could.

"There was something I said on the phone, and I've wanted so badly, for so many years, to tell you in person. I know I said it down at the creek, but I want to say it again, now that we're alone, here, in this house. I love you, Parley. I've loved you for as long as I've known what love meant. I can't imagine another day of my life without you in it."

Tears began to well in Parley's eyes. "I love you too, Zach. I always have. I always will."

Zach kissed him then, a sweet, slow kiss meant to seal the impromptu vows they had just made. The kiss built, picking up speed and desire, cresting over them and pulling them under like a wave. The intensity amplified, and soon they had shifted, Parley laying back against the cushions and Zach over him. His hands roamed over Parley, exploring the soft skin of his stomach as he lifted Parley's shirt up to give him better access.

Parley arched his body into Zach's touch, which only served to spur Zach along more. He'd had no idea Parley would be so sensual, so tactile, or so noisy. The soft groans and whimpers that fell from his mouth became louder as Zach moved, mouthing the sensitive skin of the side of Parley's neck.

"Do you want to come upstairs with me?" Zach whispered between kisses. He held his breath. If Parley said no, he would stop. It might kill him, but he would stop.

“Yes,” Parley said, almost too quietly for Zach to hear. He pulled back and looked at him.

“Yes?”

Parley nodded. “Yes, please.” His eyes were wide and slightly glassy, and his expression was, to Zach’s eye, an adorable combination of astonished, hopeful, and aroused.

Zach stood, adjusting his erection to a less painful angle, and pulled Parley up with him. He took his hand and led him upstairs, turning him and pulling him into his arms when they’d reached his bedroom. Zach understood how important this moment was, for both of them.

He kissed Parley again, the slow and languid easiness of earlier returning as he took his time, making sure Parley was comfortable and as turned on as he was. He brushed his hands down the small of Parley’s back and slid them down over Parley’s ass, pulling their hips flush together. The trembling that Zach had noticed earlier had intensified, and he paused, not sure if he should stop or continue. He wanted so much to go on, but stronger than that was his desire not to hurt Parley, not to upset him or shock him. It was one thing to have urges, to feel desire, and to act on those desires and urges late in the night, in the darkness, one’s hand wrapped around one’s cock, stroking and fighting back the instinct to make some noise, but to be here, with another person....

“Are you okay?”

Parley nodded once again. “I think so. I mean, I have thought about this a lot. I’ve wondered what it would be like, especially after that kiss we almost shared when we were first here all those years ago. The reality of it is... amazing. I don’t know how to put it into words.”

Zach smiled at that, his heart filled with warmth and love for the man before him. “I know what you mean there. This is—you are incredible.”

Parley colored slightly. “I don’t know how incredible I am, but you, Zach, you are... a gift. A gift to me, a blessing. I love you.”

He’d never been called that before, and it was difficult not to feel a bit of an ego-boost at being described as a blessing, but Zach could definitely understand Parley’s last words. “And I love you, Par.”

“Just... slow.” Parley looked down at the floor for a moment.

“Of course. Anything you want, any way you want it. I promise.” Zach pressed a soft kiss to Parley’s forehead, then to each of his cheeks. Parley leaned into him with each gentle touch, each loving gesture, and when Zach kissed Parley’s mouth, Parley’s lips parted to his tongue almost immediately. Parley pressed closer, his hands fisting in Zach’s shirt. The kiss deepened, growing harder, hungrier, and it took everything in Zach not to push Parley. Instead, he followed Parley’s every signal, each soft whimper, sigh, gasp, every nibble, lick, caress.

Zach could feel Parley’s cock straining in his pants, hard and full against his own. He canted his hips forward slightly to gauge Parley’s reaction. He almost came on the spot when Parley moved his in return, creating a maddening friction over their clothing.

Zach couldn’t suppress his groan, and Parley kissed him harder. He tugged at the hem of Parley’s shirt, stepping back just long enough to pull it up and over his head. Zach removed his own shirt next and then stepped forward, bracing his hands at Parley’s back as he lifted one knee to the bed and gently lowered Parley back onto the soft duvet.

Zach, who had never had issues with performance anxiety, was suddenly nervous. Even though Parley was the man he was most comfortable with, the idea that this was going to be Parley’s first sexual experience was heady and terrifying all at once. The pressure to make it good built in Zach’s chest until he felt the wisps of panic start to take hold.

Parley looked up at him. There was so much trust in those eyes, so much love. That was all Zach needed to know. It would be okay. He would make this good for Parley; he’d show him what it was like to be wholly loved. And with the trust and the love, there were other things—things that Zach could only describe as wonderment, astonishment, and hope. The hope he could definitely understand—it was something that he felt too, a hope that this night together would be the first of many, and a hope that their relationship would only grow and deepen with each passing day.

The wonderment and astonishment, though, gave him pause. Zach wasn’t exactly inexperienced, but he’d never seen those emotions in anyone, not in any part of his life. He realized with a sudden flash of insight that for Parley, a lifetime of daydreaming and fantasizing was becoming a reality and that reality was both better than he’d expected and

also exactly what he'd most hoped for. Zach knew that Parley would never have even considered watching porn of any kind or reading erotica or anything similar; he would be fueled only by his private daydreams, and so his fantasies would be very intense and very private.

"You are so handsome," Parley said, his voice a little rough, interrupting Zach's thoughts.

"Nowhere near as handsome as you," Zach said. "Is this.... I mean, are you okay?"

Parley nodded, sliding his hands up and down Zach's side. "Yes. Yes, I think so. This all feels so much better than I had imagined. Thank you, Zach."

Zach felt his cheeks heat up. "You don't need to thank me, y'know. I feel pretty good too."

Parley laughed at that, and Zach grinned in return. "I suppose you do," Parley murmured. He reached up with one hand and curled it around the back of Zach's neck, his long fingers warm and soft against Zach's skin and sending little shivers of delight down Zach's spine.

"Kiss me? Please?"

"Anything you want," Zach murmured, and he closed the distance between them, pressing his lips against Parley's own.

They kissed until Parley was arching up beneath him, his hands tracing desperate patterns on Zach's skin. He wanted to do this right and he knew that slow was the only way to do it. He kissed down Parley's chest, his mouth trailing behind his hands as his fingers mapped the gentle contours and hard lines of Parley's body. He hummed his happiness as he moved, committing every inch of skin to memory.

He unbuckled Parley's belt, sliding the soft leather from the metal enclosure, and then popped open the button that held his pants closed. Parley's breathing was strained, and when Zach looked up to see his face, the image he was met with made him dizzy with the intensity of it. Parley was staring back at him, his cheeks flushed, his lips a little swollen from their kisses. His mouth was slightly open, but the look in Parley's eyes was what undid Zach—pure wonder and deep love.

He tugged at Parley's pants, pulling them down and off, his underwear next until he was completely bared to Zach.

"My god, Parley, you're so fucking beautiful," Zach murmured as he looked on.

Parley began to squirm, obviously uncomfortable with the blunt appraisal of his naked body. Zach understood and quickly shucked the rest of his clothing, then climbed back on the bed beside Parley.

"Can I touch you?" Zach asked, part of him terrified that Parley would say no, but instead Parley drew his bottom lip between his teeth and nodded slowly.

Zach kissed him, easing the tension out of him before he reached a hand between them and slid the tips of his fingers along the underside of Parley's shaft. The quick intake of breath let Zach know how Parley was feeling, and getting a bit bolder, he wrapped his hand firmly around Parley. Creating a tight fist, he began to move, jacking Parley slowly, deliberately.

Parley groaned, and Zach swallowed the sound, kissing his best friend deeply as he picked up the pace.

"Zach," Parley ground out, his voice low and desperate.

Zach moved, shifting his body until their groins were lined up. He moved his hand, enveloping both of them, jacking them off together.

"Zach, I can't... it's too much... I'm going to... you know... if you don't stop."

Zach didn't stop. He kept going, maintaining the same unhurried pace. "I'm just gonna take the edge off, Par. I've wanted you—this—for so long that if I don't, I'm gonna go off the second you're buried inside me, and I want your first time to last."

A couple more strokes and Parley was coming, wet heat splashing out over Zach's fist as Parley clung to him, crying out and shuddering through his orgasm. Zach followed him, pushed over the edge by the sight of Parley, so much more beautiful than he'd ever imagined.

It took a few minutes for them both to come down from the intensity of their shared pleasure. They touched and tasted, kissed and stroked until the oversensitivity had subsided.

"Are you okay?" Zach asked, making sure this all wasn't too much for his friend. It was a lot to take in. Sixteen years of waiting, culminating in a night together. He didn't want to push, didn't want to take too much or make Parley uncomfortable.

“Yes. I feel wonderful,” Parley said. His voice was filled with happiness and that same wonder that Zach had seen in his eyes earlier.

“We can stop if you want, if this is too fast.”

Parley took Zach’s face in his hands. “I’ve been waiting my whole life for this. I trust you. I’m nervous. Of course I am. But I trust that you won’t hurt me, and I trust that you’ll make me feel wonderful.”

Zach grinned, then kissed down Parley’s body once more and gently lifted Parley’s soft cock, licking at it tentatively. Parley hissed, a noise of surprised enjoyment, and the subtle lift of his hips told Zach to keep going. He lapped at Parley’s cock, pulling it into his mouth and sucking gently, pleased with himself as he felt Parley’s cock begin to fill once more.

He pulled off with a soft pop and reached over into his bedside table to grab lube and condoms. He clicked the top off the bottle and poured some liberally onto his fingers. Reaching around, he quickly prepared himself. He didn’t need much, just enough to ease the way for Parley, before he rolled onto his back, pulling Parley with him. He could see that Parley was unable to stop staring, his eyes wide as saucers, and Zach realized then that this too was entirely new for Parley, that he had never considered that preparation was just as important as everything else.

There was so much Zach wanted to show and teach Parley that he momentarily felt dizzy with it, with the urge to do everything all at once. He wanted to give Parley the moon and the stars, to show him all the intimate delights that existed in sexual pleasure between two people who were not just attracted to each other but were also heart-stoppingly, utterly, completely in love.

He felt a tentative touch to his groin, the tips of Parley’s fingers just above his pubic hair, and the flash fire of arousal that tore through Zach made him ache with the myriad of emotions and physical desires that crashed into him. This was *Parley*. This was the only person Zach had ever loved, loved with such an intensity that it had stayed with him for sixteen years, undaunted, unbroken, unwavering.

God, he loved him.

And he wanted him. Badly, desperately, his balls aching with it, his cock seeming to throb with the need he felt. Zach bit his lip and tore open the condom wrapper and rolled the latex down over Parley’s cock.

“Are you sure about this, Zach?” Parley asked, his hands braced on either side of Zach’s shoulders as he looked down at him.

“Never been more sure of anything in my life, Par,” Zach assured him as he slicked him up with lube and guided him to his entrance.

Parley pushed forward slowly, cautiously, as if unsure he was doing this right, an expression of wonder and bliss on his face as he breached the tight ring of muscle and slid home. As he became fully sheathed inside Zach’s body, Parley’s expression changed, the wonder growing even more obvious, even as bliss writ itself large on his pale face, lighting up his eyes and coloring his cheeks pink.

“Zach,” Parley ground out, that one word so filled with reverence it made Zach fall even deeper in love with the man above him.

Parley began thrusting in earnest, slowly and carefully at first, then building his speed gradually. It didn’t take long for him to find a rhythm as instinct overtook his obvious caution and inexperience, and Zach felt more love and more desire with each thrust, each grunt, each moan. Zach rose up to meet him, his hips lifting and his back arching as Parley moved deep inside him. Parley groaned, his head falling forward, sweat dotting his forehead.

Zach’s hands roamed across Parley’s back, his fingers gripping tightly.

“I love you, so fucking much,” Zach panted. He wanted to make this last, but the friction on his cock, caught between their stomachs, was pushing him closer to orgasm by the minute. He wasn’t going to be able to hold on much longer.

“I love... you too,” Parley said, his words ending on a ragged moan as his rhythm faltered, and then he stilled as he came, spilling himself inside Zach. Zach followed him over, clutching him close, come shooting between them.

Parley collapsed on Zach, his breathing ragged. Zach held him, shifting them so they were lying side by side. Zach kissed him, bringing them both back down to earth until Parley hummed happily and nuzzled into his shoulder.

“Stay put. I’ll be right back,” Zach said finally, gently extracting himself and taking care of the condom before rolling off the bed. He hated to

leave Parley, and the cold air made him shiver as he dashed into the bathroom to grab a warm cloth.

He returned to sit on the edge of the bed, cleaning them both with care before he tossed the cloth on the floor and climbed back into bed with Parley. He wrapped his arms back around Zach and cuddled in.

“I had no idea it would be like that...,” Parley said, his voice sleepy.

“Me neither.” Zach said, pressing a kiss to Parley’s temple. Before long, both men were fast asleep.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

PARLEY AWOKE to the sensation of something wet touching his foot. He jerked up in surprise as he looked down toward the end of the bed and saw Zach's dog licking him. Pulling back his foot, Parley took a look around the room, seeing that the door was ajar and the dog was sitting by the bed, gazing at him with large, patient eyes.

"Sorry, I'm not your master," Parley said. He was alone in the bed, he saw, and he wondered where Zach was. Had he upset him somehow? Had last night not meant as much to Zach as it had to Parley?

Parley bit his lower lip as that thought entered his head. He was very inexperienced; he knew that, and he had thought Zach of all people would understand. Had he misunderstood Zach? Parley dismissed that thought instantly. Zach would never hide things from him, especially when it was about the two of them and such a personal thing to them both.

Zach wasn't in the bed, though, and Parley wondered where he was. He leaned back against the headboard and frowned to himself, his mind presenting him with all manner of awful suggestions as to where Zach was. It didn't take long for Parley to have worked himself into a knot of worry, imagining that Zach had been taken away from him somehow, that after all this time, their one night of passion was to be their last and that Parley had been instrumental in getting Zach killed.

The bedroom door opened then, the hinges creaking a little, and Zach stepped through, carrying a large tray with two plates, two mugs, a milk carton, and a teapot on it. He was wearing a pair of sweatpants that sat low on his hips and his hair was mussed. He was smiling and his eyes were full of warmth and good humor, things Parley would always associate with this man, the man he loved above and beyond all others. The relief Parley felt at the sight of Zach was almost physical, as if he'd been punched in the stomach with it, a rush of adrenaline that made the room tilt on its axis as Parley blinked rapidly to clear his head.

"Morning," Zach said.

"Good morning." Parley forced himself to smile and squashed down his earlier panic and ensuing relief. "I wondered where you were."

"I thought I'd get us some breakfast. Did Winston wake you up?"

As Zach set the tray down on a bedside table that Parley hadn't noticed the previous evening, Parley nodded.

"He did. He licked my foot."

Zach laughed. "Sorry about that. Let me put him out of the room. I'll be right back." He bent down and kissed Parley's forehead, then straightened. As Parley watched, Zach stood and whistled to the dog, who trotted happily over to him. Zach led the animal to the door and gently pushed him out, then shut the door firmly behind him. Then he returned to the bed and sat down beside Parley, giving him a look that Parley knew very well from their school days together.

"You okay? You look a bit pale."

Parley debated with himself for a moment whether or not to tell Zach about his paranoias. He decided that yes, he would. It wasn't fair or right to hide them from Zach for one thing and for another, he didn't want to start off this new phase of their relationship with secrets. So he took a deep breath and plunged into it.

"I-I was scared for a moment that you'd gone. That you'd left."

Zach let out a soft breath, and for a minute, his expression was stricken. Then it cleared and he took Parley's hand in his own, twining their fingers.

"I wouldn't do that. Not to you. Never to you."

"I know. Logically, I do know. It's just..." Parley paused and took a deep, shaky breath. "Sunbeam drilled it into me—us, the whole group who was there—that gay people are only interested in sodomy, and once they get what they want, they will leave you behind in the dirt."

"I know that's not true. I do know it. People are people, and their sexuality doesn't determine how they react to things. It's just sometimes, the stuff they put into our heads there comes up and it's not rational. It's not even possible, some of it, but it's just... they did a lot to our psyches, I think, that we never really knew."

"Oh, Par." Zach's expression was a study in conflicting emotions. He looked murderous and protective, fond and loving.

"They would tell us every day, before and after every meal, when we woke up in the morning and when they let us go to bed each night, that loving someone like this was not only against God but it was against nature. One of the girls there, she said that dolphins and some other animals had been proven by science to be both homosexual and heterosexual." Parley paused. When he went on, his voice was soft. "They told her that science was wrong, that science wanted the world to believe that God did not create the universe, that God did not, in fact, exist. Science was wrong about that, they said, so naturally, it was wrong about homosexual animals. And then they beat her, tied her to a post and whipped her, telling her to pray as they did it, and we had to pray too, watch it all without protest or complaint."

Zach's expression was grim. His grip on Parley's hand had tightened, and his cheeks were pale. Parley knew that Zach was fighting with himself internally, and he felt warmed and soothed by that knowledge, relieved that Zach was so determined to protect him. It was a comforting thing, to feel that, to know that. Apart from his brothers, and later, Veronica and Emma, Parley had not felt such comfort with another human being since he had been sent to Sunbeam Farm.

"Are you positive I can't go down there and blow the place up?" Zach asked.

Parley chuckled, although it sounded strained to his own ears. "I am."

Zach took a deep breath. "Par, please believe me when I say I will never leave you. The only way you'll get rid of me is by telling me to go, and even then, you'll have to explain to me why you want me out of your life."

Parley shook his head. "I don't want you out of my life."

"Good," Zach said. "Then I have something for you." He reached into his pocket and pulled out a small box wrapped in a blue ribbon. He handed it to Parley, who took it and held it in both hands.

"May I open it?" Parley asked.

"Of course. I've been waiting forever to give this to you."

Parley pulled at the end of the ribbon and it fell away easily. Opening the box, he was pleased to see a key nestled inside.

"I know your life is complicated, but I want to be with you, always, and part of that is living here. I've always thought of this as our house, and

you'd make me the happiest guy ever if you'd consider living here with me."

"Yes. Of course, yes!" Parley said, wrapping his arms around Zach's neck.

Zach leaned forward and rested his forehead against Parley's own. "You mean everything to me."

"I love you," Parley said. He had no other words.

"HELLO?"

"Hi Veronica, it's Parley." He cleared his throat.

"Parley! How did it go? Are you two together? Is it awesome?"

The excitement in her voice made Parley smile. He shifted the phone from one ear to the other. "It went well, I think. And yes, we are. 'Awesome' is definitely one way to describe it."

"I'm so glad. Really, I am. I know how much he means to you, and I think it's wonderful you two have found each other again."

"You're not angry? I should have asked you this ages ago...."

"No." Veronica cut him off sharply. "I have always known your heart belonged to another. And when we met, I knew you were destined for someone else. You and I, Par, we're bound by love too, it's true, but not love like you and Zach share. We're all family in the end, although it's not what people think of as a traditional family. But family is more than what tradition decrees. Family is about love, trust, hope, support, and friendship. And that's what you and I and Emma have. That's what you and Zach have."

Parley swiped his eyes with the back of his hand, moved by her words. "You're so good to me, Ronnie."

"You can have me nominated for sainthood if you like."

He laughed at that, feeling the tension in his shoulders ease a little. "I'll get to work on that straightaway."

"Good to hear. So the kids are asking when they can go for pony rides again, and Emma's started working on a new piece. She and I spent most of the evening looking at rentals around the general area of Zach's and your house. There are a few possibilities that we're going to go and have a look at on Monday."

"You're serious about that?" Parley was surprised, although he didn't really know why. Veronica rarely said she would do something and then let it fall by the wayside. She always followed through on her plans.

"Of course. It makes sense. There's a private school nearby too that I want to visit. They have a terrific language curriculum and class sizes are small. I think this is almost divine providence that you and Zach found each other, and Emma and I found some nice places we could rent and a potential school for the kids. Take it as a sign, if you want to. A sign that this, you and Zach, is meant to be."

"Thank you." Parley felt joy bubble up inside him. After his panic that morning, Veronica's words were a balm.

"Did you sleep all right?"

"Like a baby. I haven't slept so well in years."

"Another sign this is meant to be."

"If we choose to, we'll see nothing but signs that support what we want."

"That's your father talking, Par, not you."

Parley huffed a little but then he sighed. "I know. Sorry. Old habits."

"Don't apologize. It's all right."

"Anyway, I just wanted to let you know that I'll be back tomorrow morning."

"All right. I'll tell Em and the kids."

"Thanks, Ronnie."

"You're welcome, hon. I'm so glad you and Zach found each other." Veronica's voice was full of light and happiness and Parley felt himself smile as she spoke. "You deserve it."

"Thank you. Anyway, I'll see you tomorrow."

"All right. Have fun, and we'll talk soon."

Parley ended the call and set aside his cell phone. He turned to look at Zach, who was gazing at him expectantly.

"She's okay with this?"

"Oh yes. She's glad we found each other again and thinks this is a sign that things are meant to be this way. She and Emma found a school to check out for the kids and they're going to look at a couple of rental properties this week too."

"Oh?"

“Yeah. Not far from here. She didn’t say where exactly.”

Zach shook his head, his expression slightly stunned. “She’s amazing, your Veronica.”

“She really is. I’m so lucky. Not just because of her and Emma and Desta and Jiang, but because I have you. Because we’re together again after so many years.”

Zach moved closer and took Parley’s hands in his. “Par, there is nothing I won’t do for you.”

Parley smiled. “Thank you. You know it goes both ways?”

“Sure. But I don’t need to be tutored in math anymore.”

Parley couldn’t help it. He pasted on a wholly innocent expression as he said, “But I do think you need some tutoring in English; I’m not sure some of the words you said last night are actually real.”

It took Zach a moment, but then he blushed crimson and gasped. “Parley!” He burst out laughing and moved closer, drawing Parley into a tight hug. “I was a bit affected by the moment,” Zach said.

Parley hugged Zach tightly. “So was I,” he admitted. “I hope... what I mean is, perhaps... will there be...?”

“There will always be another night. Tonight, tomorrow, and all the nights forever,” Zach said.

Parley pulled back out of the hug just enough to look into Zach’s eyes. Reflected there, he saw all the things he himself was feeling—all the hopes, fears, anxieties, desires, and dreams, and, most wonderful of all, a boundless love. Parley leaned in and kissed Zach then, emboldened by their previous night together and the emotion they shared. He slid one hand up to tangle in Zach’s hair, something he had always dreamed about doing, delighting in its softness, even as the kiss deepened, growing more passionate.

Zach made a soft purring sort of noise into the kiss and the sound skipped Parley’s ears entirely and went straight to his groin. He was a little surprised with his own body, Parley thought fuzzily. He had no idea so many things could cause such a reaction. But then, these were things Zach did or said, and Parley was convinced now that Zach could read his grocery list to him and Parley would be putty in his hands.

At that moment, they were sprawled on the couch, the bay windows thrown open and letting in the warm air of the late morning. Parley lay

back, pulling Zach with him, wanting nothing more than this, the joy of touching and kissing Zach, feeling Zach pressed against him from tip to toe, and knowing without a shadow of a doubt that his love was returned in full.

CHAPTER TWENTY

A WEEK had gone by since their first night together and Zach had never been happier. It was the middle of the afternoon, and they had spent a wonderful morning kissing and talking, taking a break for a bite of lunch. They had gone outside and sat on the veranda, so close that Zach hadn't been sure if there was any space between them. Now they were sitting on the back steps, side by side, watching Winston trying to get the cat to play with him.

"I love having you here with me so much, and it'll be wonderful to have your family all living so close," Zach said sincerely.

"It will, won't it? I've loved being here too, but it's been difficult being so far away from them. I know that must seem silly," Parley said.

"Not at all. They're your family. You've been together forever. I feel badly that it's taking so long to get them moved out here."

"It's only a few more days until they take possession of the new house," Parley said.

He moved a little closer and Parley rested his head on Zach's shoulder. Zach slipped his arm around Parley's shoulders and he let out a contented little sigh. "I like these moments."

"I like all the moments we share."

"You said it best. Hey, did you ever find out why the people who owned the house abandoned it all those years ago?"

"I did, actually," Zach said. "When I was making the purchase, I had my agent inquire about the history of this place. I'd wondered about it for so long. It's kind of a sad story, actually. It was a couple who owned the house, a husband and wife who had been together for nearly fifty years, but while they were away on vacation together, the wife fell ill and never recovered. She died in the hospital and the husband couldn't stand the thought of coming home without her, so he didn't."

"That is a terrible story," Parley said.

“It is. Heartbreaking. It makes me that much more grateful to have you in my life. I’m so lucky to have found you. I will never let you go.”

“I feel the same.”

“Par, you know I won’t ever be able to forgive those people, right? The Sunbeam Farm people. And... I’m not sure I’ll ever forgive your parents.”

Parley shifted a little so that he could see Zach’s expression. “I had thought as much. But why my parents?”

Zach heaved a sigh. “I know they meant well, but you know what they say about that: the road to hell is paved with good intentions, and as far as I’m concerned, they sent you to hell when they took you to Sunbeam. They tried to change you into what they wanted you to be, not accept you for who you are. They preach all this ‘love one another’ stuff, and all that crap about loving thy neighbor as thyself, but they don’t practice it. They’re hypocrites, Par. I’m sorry, but it’s the truth. And they took you to that place, knowing damn well what it was like and what went on there, even after what happened at the compound or whatever it was where you lived before coming to Vancouver.

“They should have known better. They had seen terrible things happen to you and your brothers, and that bit you told me all those years ago... that compound place was another kind of hell. So I won’t forgive them for sending you straight back to hell when you didn’t fit into their worldview. They did to you what the folks at the compound did to them, only worse, because you’re their son. Their own flesh and blood.”

Zach was clenching and unclenching his hands into fists. Parley was silent, obviously considering Zach’s words.

Finally, Parley sighed and nodded. “I understand how you feel,” he said. “But I can’t do that. They’re my parents. They didn’t know any better; they still don’t. They’re scared of what they don’t understand, and they’re getting older now. Hate is such a depressing emotion to me, Zach. I’d much rather forgive them and move on with my life. All right, they won’t be too thrilled about you and me, but to be honest, I don’t tell them much about my life at all these days.” He chuckled humorlessly. “Neither do my brothers, actually. And definitely not Emma. She won’t talk to them at all.”

“Your baby sister is a damn genius,” Zach growled.

“Don’t tell her that. She’ll get a big head.” Parley laughed, and a moment later, Zach joined in. “But don’t think I don’t appreciate you,” Parley went on. “I do. I appreciate and love your protectiveness, your determination, your integrity. You hold onto your beliefs and ideals far more nobly than some religious folk. In some ways, you’re my hero.”

Zach snorted. “Hero? Seriously?”

“Sure. You bought this place and fixed it up. You put it back together, brick by brick, piece by piece. And perhaps it’s a little silly of me to say it, but now, being back with you after so long, feeling myself to be so broken, I think you’ve started to heal me too, brick by brick, piece by piece.”

Zach was quiet for a very long time, thinking about what Parley had said. It was a lot to process, and he had some serious doubts that Parley saw him too clearly, but the love he had for the other man made him want to be worthy of the image in Parley’s mind.

“I don’t deserve you, Par,” Zach said softly. “I sometimes think that I’m dreaming and I have to pinch myself to prove that I’m awake. From the moment we met at school until right now, and probably into the future, I’ve always thought you were too good for this world. But you know what? The world can’t have you. It can fuck off. I’ve got you, we found each other again, and now I’m not letting you go.”

Parley shifted to face Zach and nodded. “I feel the same way about you, Zach.”

Zach didn’t say anything. He leaned forward and kissed Parley instead, wrapping his arms around Parley’s shoulders and pulling him onto his lap. Kissing Parley was the most amazing thing Zach had ever experienced. After waiting so long for the right person, it turned out that made all the difference. The sex was up there too, and oh, he was looking forward to doing that again, but there was something about Parley’s kisses that made Zach feel weak and light-headed and strong enough to take on a lion with his bare hands all at once.

Parley made him feel as if he could climb all the mountains in the world, take on an army, and stop a runaway freight train. Zach craved Parley’s touches, cherished each and every one. Perhaps it was because of Parley’s upbringing, but Zach had discovered his need to be touched. He loved the way Parley responded to him, leaning into him almost

unconsciously, like they were naturally drawn together. Parley was so responsive and so full of passion.... And perhaps too it was the way Zach touched him with gentleness, reverence, and love, not with hate and fear, that made the difference. All Zach wanted was to make sure Parley felt cherished and loved for the rest of his life. No one deserved it more.

The kiss deepened and Zach gave himself over to it completely, happily losing himself in the man he was pressed against, the man who had taken possession of Zach's heart from the moment he'd said hello back in high school.

If there was no tomorrow, then Zach would be content. Everything he had ever dreamed of had come true and he was, for the first time he could remember, completely and utterly happy.

"I love you, Parley," he said between kisses, delighting in the way he felt when he said the words, how euphoria seemed to bubble up inside him and how the world seemed to be colored with light, joy, and pure happiness.

"I love you, Zach," Parley said, and his voice was soft, deep, and full of emotion.

Zach's heart felt full, and he had no more words, just kisses, as he and Parley sat together on the back steps of the house. The sun began to set and its warmth caressed Zach's hands on Parley's back. There was no more perfect a moment than this, Zach thought, no more perfect a place or a person to be with. In the distance, he could hear the sounds of ducks calling to each other, and the occasional sound of a pony whinnying, or the bark of Winston. But most of all, he could hear Parley, the sound of his breathing, the tiny little whimpers and moans that came from him as they kissed and touched.

This was heaven on earth.

CATE ASHWOOD wrote her very first story in a hot-pink binder when she was in the second grade and found her passion for writing. Her first successful foray into romance writing came five years later when she wrote her best friend, who was experiencing a case of unrequited love, her own happily ever after.

Cate's life has taken a number of different and adventurous roads. She now lives a stone's throw from the ocean just outside of Vancouver, British Columbia, with her husband, her son, and their two cats. Her life is filled with family and friends, travel, and, of course, books.

Cate loves to hear from readers. You can find her at:

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L.J. LABARTHE is a French-Australian woman who was born during the Witching Hour, just after midnight. From this auspicious beginning, she went on to write a prize-winning short story about Humpty Dumpty wearing an Aussie hat complete with corks dangling from it when she was six years old. From there, she wrote for her high school yearbook, her university newspaper, and, from her early teens to her twenties, produced a fanzine about the local punk rock music scene. She loves music of all kinds and was once a classical pianist; she loves languages and speaks French and English and a teeny-tiny smattering of Mandarin Chinese, which she hopes to relearn properly very soon. She enjoys TV, film, travel, cooking, eating out, abandoned places, urbex, history, and researching.

L.J. loves to read complicated plots and hopes to do complex plot lines justice in her own writing. She writes paranormal, historical, urban fantasy, and contemporary Australian stories, usually m/m romance and featuring m/m erotica. She has won a Rainbow Awards Honorable Mention and another award for Best Historical Gay Novel.

L.J. lives in the city of Adelaide and is owned by her cat.

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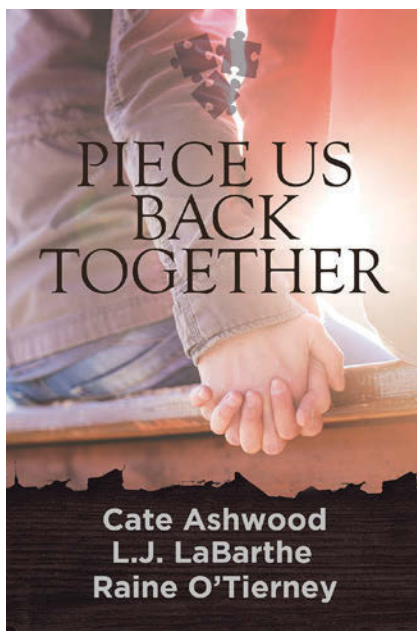
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Piece Us Back Together

By Cate Ashwood, L.J. LaBarthe, and
Raine O'Tierney

Life can seem bleak for people suffering devastating injuries or illnesses of the mind and body, and every day can be a struggle. But sometimes, when hope seems in short supply, they find a reason to keep up the fight. The men in these stories face some of the most difficult challenges imaginable, but fortunately they won't be facing them alone, because when everything seems darkest, a point of light appears. With compassion, understanding, and love, these hurt souls have a chance to piece the broken parts of their lives and themselves into something strong and beautiful. Love might even be able to mend the most serious wounds of all—those of the heart.

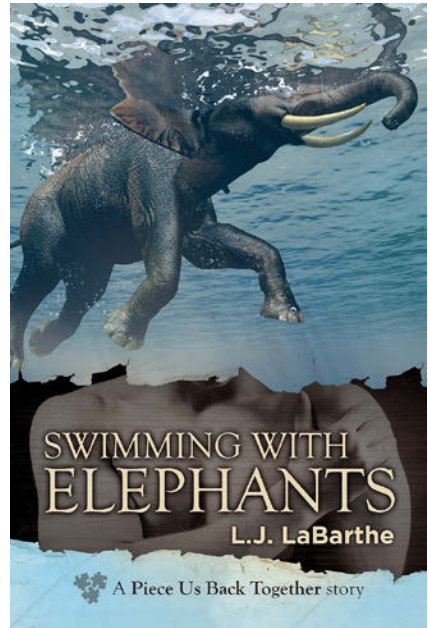


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Swimming with Elephants

A Piece Us Back
Together Story

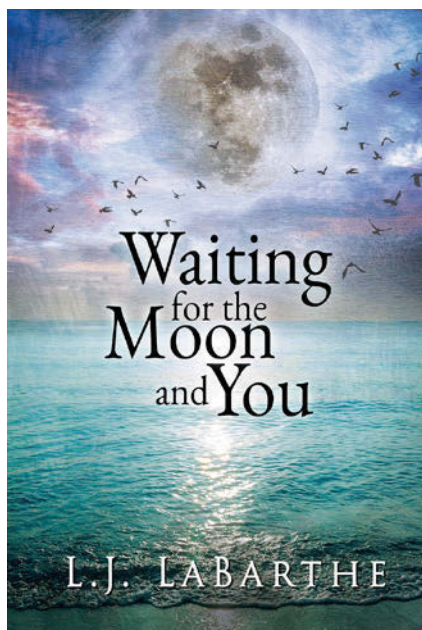
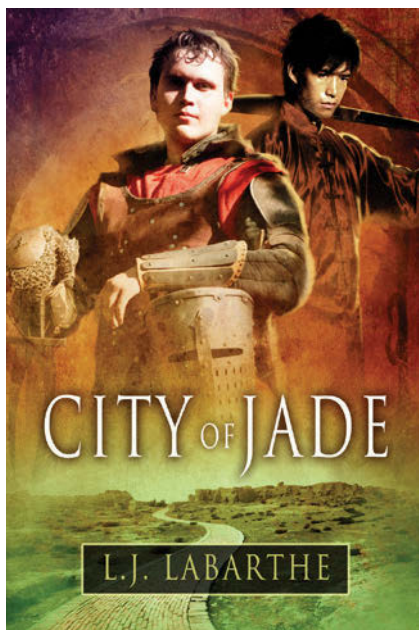
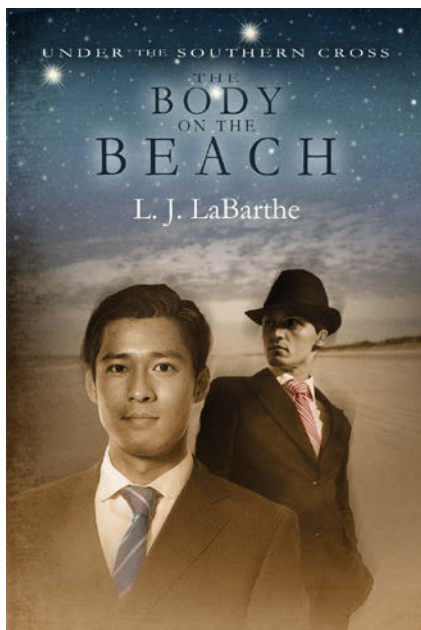
By L.J. LaBarthe



After suffering a torn rotator cuff in his left shoulder, Garrett believes his life is over. Depressed, bereft, in pain, and unable to return to the career he loves as an arborist, he sees no hope or future for himself. But a trip to Havelock Island in India turns his world upside down. He meets Jai, an Indian nurse, and becomes smitten with him. Near the end of his trip, while swimming with an elephant, he tells Jai how he feels.

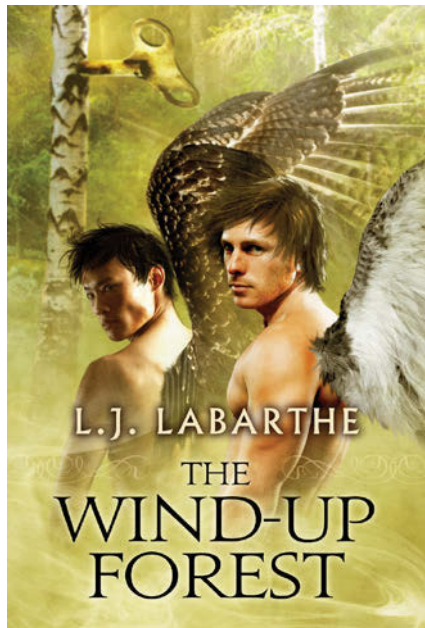
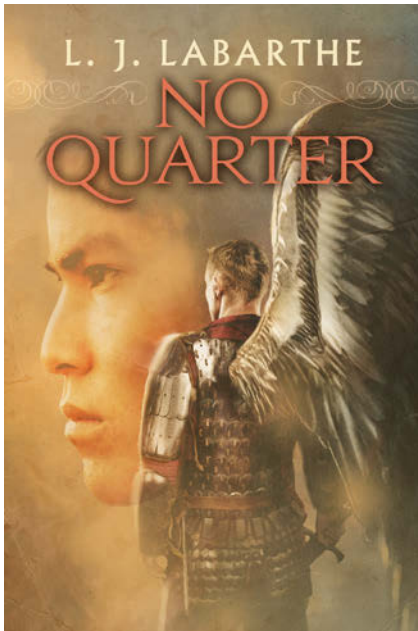
After Garrett returns to Australia, he wonders if he can ever be healed of all his pain—physical, emotional, and mental—and fears that love and romance will never be his again. But then Jai turns up in Perth and brings with him astonishing news.

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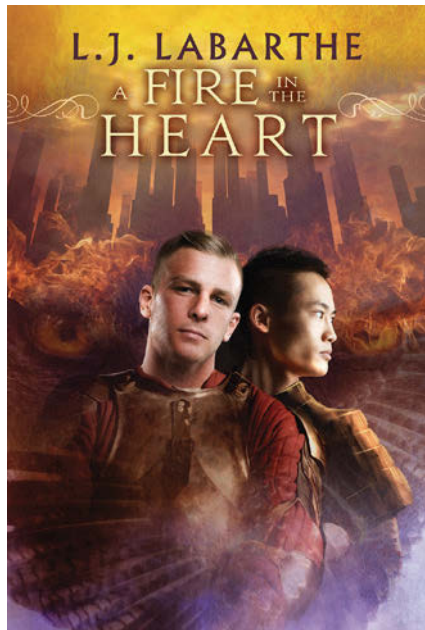
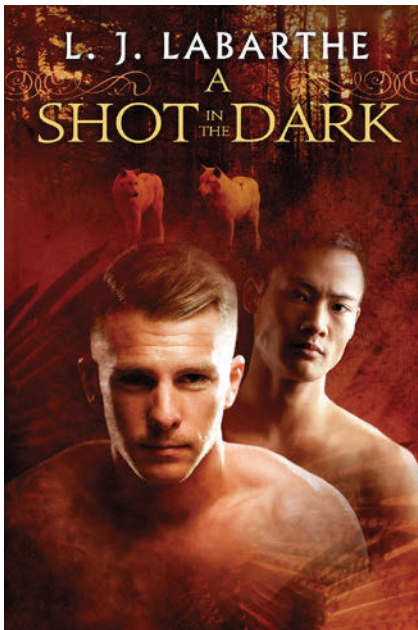
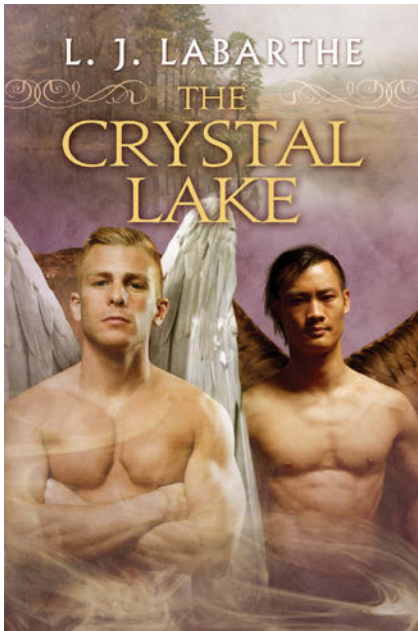
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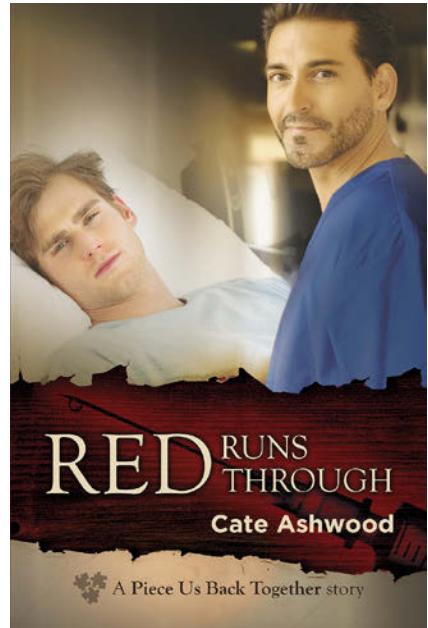


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Red Runs Through

A Piece Us Back
Together Story

By Cate Ashwood



Carter McClintock's life is uncomplicated. For the past five years, he's spent so much time in hospital scrubs that one day bleeds into the next, and that's just the way he likes it. That is, until he meets Matthew Nolan. Carter has never had a patient affect him the way Matthew does. During Matthew's stay in the hospital, the chemistry is unmistakable, and once he is discharged, Carter asks him out.

Despite the obvious attraction between them, Matthew's HIV status keeps him from handing Carter his heart, refusing to believe anyone could ever truly want him. When Matthew's past comes to light, their budding relationship is threatened before it has even begun. But Carter isn't one to give up without a fight, and he will do anything to show Matthew the lengths he will go to keep them together.

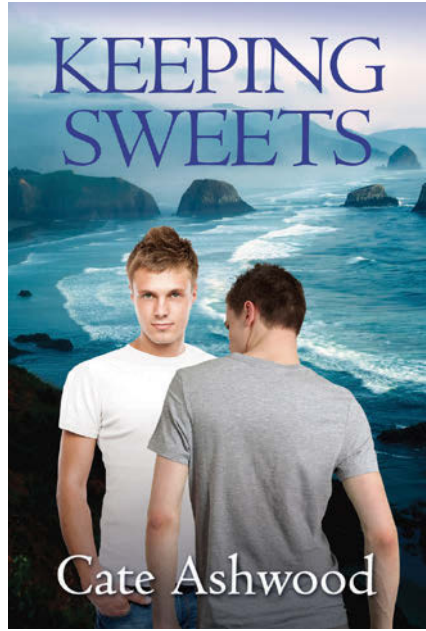
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CATE ASHWOOD & SKYLAR M. CATES

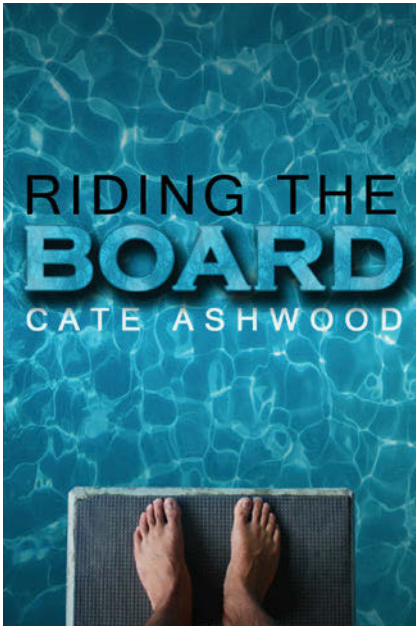
**FIVE
WAYS
A BOY
CAN
BREAK
YOUR
HEART**



**KEEPING
SWEETS**



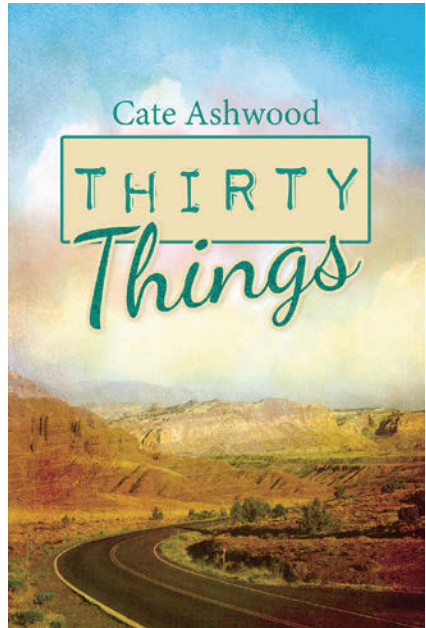
**RIDING THE
BOARD**
CATE ASHWOOD



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Thirty Things

By Cate Ashwood



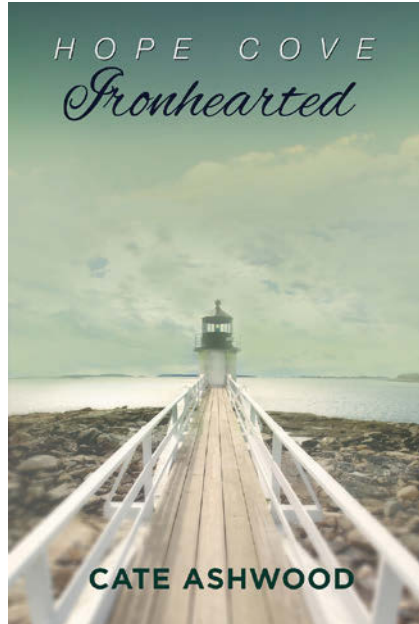
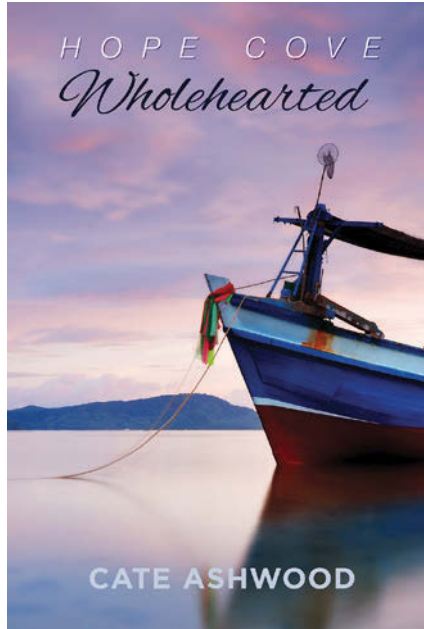
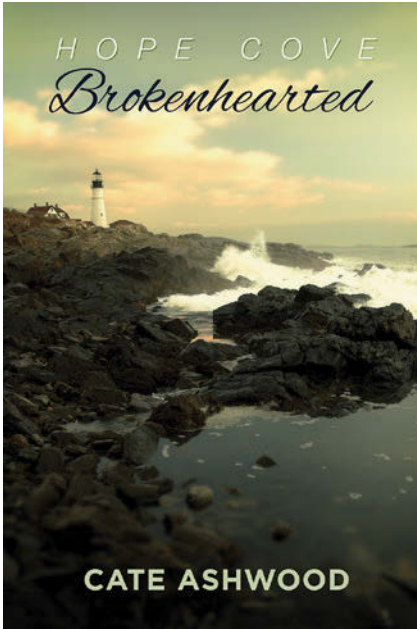
All their lives, Finn and Nate have been inseparable, sharing everything, and when a childhood accident left Finn broken, Nate stood by his side as all his other friends left. After all their years together, there's one secret Finn still hasn't revealed: he has been in love with Nate since they were eight years old. Hiding his feelings for twenty-one years—terrified of what might happen if Nate ever found out—has been difficult, but losing his best friend would be worse than living with a bad case of unrequited love. Unfortunately for Finn, Nate doesn't make it easy.

Nate believes there are some things that just have to be done before your thirtieth birthday. As a gift to Finn, he plans an adventure to check off a list of thirty things to experience before hitting that milestone. Starting in Crawfordsville, Indiana, they tour the country, trying new things and meeting interesting new people. Nate's having the time of his life, but he can tell Finn is holding something back. As the days count down, navigating the back roads suddenly seems easier than figuring out where their relationship is heading.

One thing's for certain. There will be no turning back.

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